

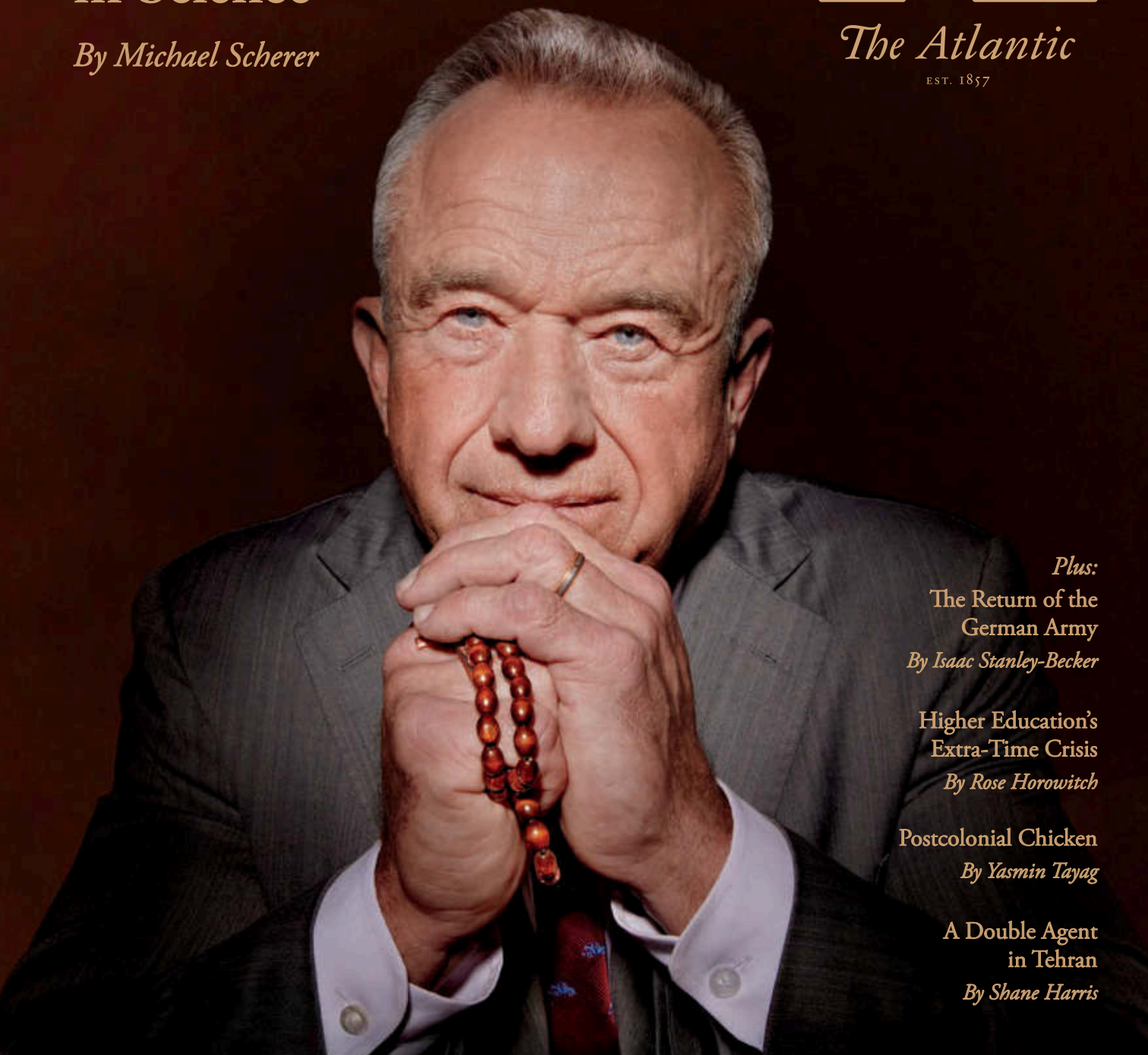
The Most Powerful Man in Science

By Michael Scherer



The Atlantic

EST. 1857



Plus:

The Return of the
German Army

By Isaac Stanley-Becker

Higher Education's
Extra-Time Crisis

By Rose Horowitz

Postcolonial Chicken

By Yasmin Tayag

A Double Agent
in Tehran

By Shane Harris





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From her earliest days to the present, Brown's journey distills three enduring principles: the power of a clear vision, the courage to evolve, and the value of surrounding yourself with people who share your dedication.

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ANNE SPENCER HOUSE & GARDEN MUSEUM IN LYNCHBURG, VIRGINIA.
PHOTO BY LINCOLN BARBOUR



National Trust for Historic Preservation

African American
Cultural Heritage Action Fund



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FOR THE ATLANTIC

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Behind the Cover: In this month's cover story, "The Most Powerful Man in Science" (p. 34), Michael Scherer profiles Secretary of Health and Human Services Robert F. Kennedy Jr. Kennedy has broken with his family and his former political party, and has attacked the scientific establishment. For this month's

cover image, the photographer Elinor Carucci—known for her intimate explorations of family and identity—captured Kennedy in his HHS office. Kennedy suggested that she shoot a portrait with him holding his rosary.

— *Bifen Xu*, Senior Photo Editor

THE

This Is What the End of the Liberal World Order Looks Like

*In the September issue,
Anne Applebaum
documented the anarchy
and greed of Sudan's
devastating civil war.*

Letters

I have studied Sudan all of my adult life. I lived there in 1980 and wrote my doctoral dissertation on Sudanese foreign policy. It's a country, I learned, that breaks the heart of anyone who loves it.

In the years since, I have not found a single American article or book on Sudan that did not get some detail wrong. But Anne Applebaum's "This Is What the End of the Liberal World Order Looks Like," deeply depressing though it is, gets everything right. It even conveys, somehow, the *feeling* of Sudan.

I had thought that I should write something about the utter depravity of the current civil war, but now I don't have

to. The absence of any coverage was horrifying. The scale of the tragedy in Sudan has to be described before anyone will try to do anything about it.

Sally Ann Baynard
Alexandria, Va.

In "This Is What the End of the Liberal World Order Looks Like," Anne Applebaum writes that "Sudan is a good place to fight." But we should also remember that Sudan is a good place to wage peace.

Beginning in 1989, Jimmy and Rosalynn Carter made Sudan a primary focus of their peace-building efforts. During the Second Sudanese Civil War, President Carter negotiated a six-month humanitarian

cease-fire—during which international health workers were able to enter the country to support more than 2,000 Guinea-worm-endemic villages and distribute more than 200,000 cloth filters for drinking water. Now, less than 40 years later, we have forgotten the success of that effort.

The Sudanese people, too, have proved their skill as peace builders. In 2018 and 2019, young people—undeterred by decades of war and authoritarian rule—demonstrated non-violently, culminating in the removal of the dictator Omar al-Bashir. After war broke out again in April 2023, ordinary citizens negotiated local peace deals. Today, Sudan's Emergency Response Rooms, volunteer-led initiatives providing humanitarian aid to civilians, exemplify the resilience of the country's citizens.

The Trump administration has taken important steps toward an agreement, but Congress and the White House must escalate their advocacy with Sudan's warring parties and regional backers. Sudan's fighters must allow humanitarian access everywhere it is needed, especially al-Fashir. And the global community must support negotiations for a cease-fire.

If there is nihilism in Sudan, let us acknowledge that it belongs not to the Sudanese people, but to the rest of the world. The Sudanese remain committed to conflict resolution. We must join them in the fight for peace.

Benjamin Spears
Atlanta, Ga.



As a long-ago newspaper correspondent in West Africa, I greatly admire Anne Applebaum's intrepid reporting on Sudan. Her judgment that the "liberal world order has already ended" there, leaving nothing "to replace it," is hard to dispute. It does, though, presuppose that such an order ever carried political weight in Sudan or sub-Saharan Africa more broadly.

True, the World Bank, the International Monetary Fund, and other multilateral development and disaster-relief institutions labor in the field. So, as Applebaum movingly showed, do a number of extraordinary humanitarian NGOs. What has long been missing, however, is any coherent or consistent undertaking by the former colonial rulers and the United States to deter disorder and promote democratic stability.

The liberal world order failed a significant test on January 13, 1963, when Togo's then-president, Sylvanus Olympio, was assassinated. That evening, the American, British, and French ambassadors to neighboring Dahomey (now Benin) and its president, Hubert Maga, considered whether and how to respond.

They concluded that no effective redress was feasible. The ambassadors' governments were unprepared to act, and at the time, Dahomey's military forces moved mostly on bicycles. Thus,

until he died in office in 2005, Gnassingbé Eyadéma, the former French-army sergeant who masterminded Olympio's murder, ruled Togo. His son succeeded him as president. Even without the title, he holds power there today.

Dahomey's army chief of staff deposed Maga less than a year after Olympio's death. Similar coups toppled leaders in Nigeria (six times), Ghana, Liberia, and other countries. Over the subsequent decades throughout much of Africa—not just in Sudan—the phrase *liberal world order* has carried the oxymoronic ring of *the Holy Roman Empire*.

Alfred Friendly Jr.
Washington, D.C.

The Man Who Ate NASA

The agency once projected America's loftiest ideals, Franklin Foer wrote in the September issue. Then it ceded its ambitions to Elon Musk.

Franklin Foer's article "The Man Who Ate NASA" mentions only in passing NASA's greatest achievement to date: the James Webb Space Telescope. The telescope is an unrivaled accomplishment. Its design, construction, and flawless deployment came about through international cooperation spearheaded by NASA. Such a project requires visionary, sophisticated

leadership that respects all collaborators. A leader who lacks humility and demands obedience is unlikely to bring about a similar success, no matter his level of wealth and power. This is the great tragedy of Elon Musk's ascendancy within the space industry. This may be tragic for Musk, but if left uncorrected, it will be a still-greater misfortune for the United States and the international community.

Kathleen Early
Campbell, Calif.

My Father's Work

When the greatest musicians of the 1970s needed an instrument—or a friend—Nancy Walecki's dad, Fred, was there, she wrote in the September issue.

I'm not a person of any fame, so it was a new feeling to see the face of someone I know when I opened the September issue. Fred Walecki and I were friends during our days together at the Vineyard Church in Los Angeles. In the early 1980s, we met for breakfast every Wednesday at Mary & Robbs, a diner up the street from Westwood Music. We'd discuss spirituality, sin, music, social issues—just about everything.

I was in my early 20s when I first met Fred, and in the first of the many crummy bands I'd end up in during that period.

He was 10 years older and a kind of mentor to me. In her article, Nancy Walecki describes her father's tireless joy for helping addicts of all stripes toward sobriety. One of the people Fred helped was a family member of mine. He had a way of making even something as serious as addiction feel lighter—and beatable.

Even though Fred knew many of my rock heroes personally, he never name-dropped. He was always just happy, warm, joyful Fred. The smile was real, and he was generous with his time with everyone, including me.

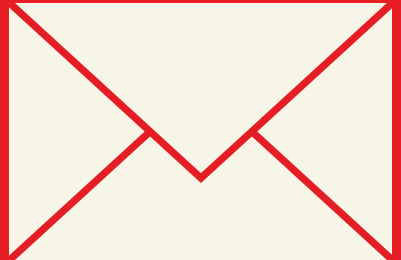
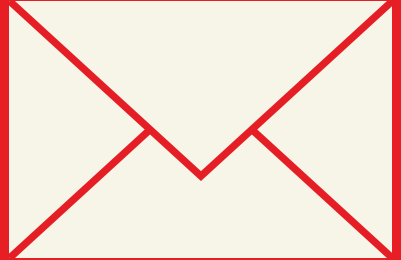
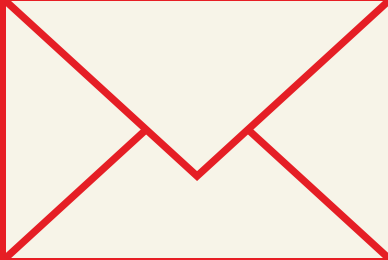
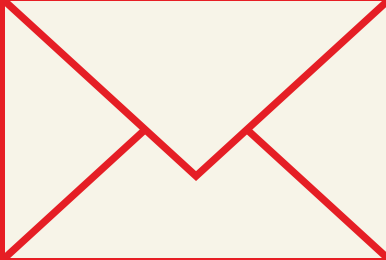
A few months ago, I returned to Westwood and found it to be a shadow of its former self. It's a lot of empty storefronts now. Tragically, Westwood Music is one of them. Peering through the window, I wished that I'd kept some small memento from the place, which housed so many warm memories for me. Westwood Music was where virtually anyone could walk in, sit down on the couch with a cup of coffee, and have Fred treat you the same as he would Joe Walsh. And then Joe Walsh would walk in.

Mark Wagner
Camarillo, Calif.

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DISPATCHES

OPENING ARGUMENT

ACCOMMODATION NATION

*America's colleges have an
extra-time-on-tests problem.*

BY ROSE HOROWITZ

AAdministering an exam used to be straightforward: All a college professor needed was an open room and a stack of blue books. At many American universities, this is no longer true. Professors now struggle to accommodate the many students with an official disability designation, which may entitle them to extra time, a distraction-free environment, or the use of otherwise-prohibited technology. The University of Michigan has two centers where students with disabilities can take exams, but they frequently fill to capacity, leaving professors scrambling to find more desks and proctors. Juan Collar, a physicist at the University of Chicago, told me that so many students now take their exams in the school's low-distraction testing outposts that they have

become more distracting than the main classrooms.

Accommodations in higher education were supposed to help disabled Americans enjoy the same opportunities as everyone else. No one should be kept from taking a class, for example, because they are physically unable to enter the building where it's taught. Over the past decade and a half, however, the share of students at selective universities who qualify for accommodations—often, extra time on tests—has grown at a breathtaking pace. At the University of Chicago, the number has more than tripled over the past eight years; at UC Berkeley, it has nearly quintupled over the past 15 years.

The increase is driven by more young people getting diagnosed with conditions such as ADHD, anxiety, and depression, and by universities making the process of getting accommodations easier. The change has occurred disproportionately at the most prestigious and expensive institutions. At Brown and Harvard, more than 20 percent of undergraduates are registered as disabled. At Amherst, that figure is 34 percent. Not all of those students receive accommodations, but researchers told me that most do. The schools that enroll the most academically successful students, in other words, also have the largest share of students with a disability that could prevent them from succeeding academically.

"You hear 'students with disabilities' and it's not kids in wheelchairs," one professor at a selective university, who requested anonymity because he doesn't have tenure, told me. "It's just not. It's rich kids getting extra time on tests." Even as poor students with

disabilities still struggle to get necessary provisions, elite universities have entered an age of accommodation. Instead of leveling the playing field, the system has put the entire idea of fairness at risk.

FORTY YEARS AGO, students with disabilities could count on few protections in higher education. Federal law prohibited discrimination against disabled students, but in practice schools did little to address their needs. Michael Ashley Stein, a disability-rights expert who teaches at Harvard Law, recalled the challenges of attending law school as a student using a wheelchair in the 1980s. "I sat in the back of the classroom, could not enter certain buildings in a normal way, became the first person on the law review with a disability, and dragged myself up the stairs," he told me.

The Americans With Disabilities Act, passed in 1990, was meant to make life fairer for people like Stein. The law required public and private institutions to provide reasonable accommodations to individuals with "a physical or mental impairment" that "substantially limits one or more major life activities."

Change was slow at first, in part because Supreme Court rulings narrowed the scope of the law. Professors I spoke with told me that, even in the early 2000s, they taught only a handful of students with disabilities. Then, in 2008, Congress amended the ADA to restore the law's original intent. The government broadened the definition of *disability*, effectively expanding the number of people the law covered. It also included a list of major life activities that could

be disrupted by a disability ("learning, reading, concentrating, thinking," among others) and clarified that individuals were protected under the ADA even if their impairment didn't severely restrict their daily life.

In response to the 2008 amendments, the Association on Higher Education and Disability (AHEAD), an organization of disability-services staff, released guidance urging universities to give greater weight to students' own accounts of how their disability affected them, rather than relying solely on a medical diagnosis. "Requiring extensive medical and scientific evidence perpetuates a deviance model of disability, undervalues the individual's history and experience with disability and is inappropriate and burdensome under the revised statute and regulations," AHEAD wrote.

Schools began relaxing their requirements. A 2013 analysis of disability offices at 200 post-secondary institutions found that most "required little" from a student besides a doctor's note in order to grant accommodations for ADHD. At the same time, getting such a note became easier. In 2013, the American Psychiatric Association expanded the definition of ADHD. Previously, the threshold for diagnosis had been "clear evidence of clinically significant impairment." After the release of the *DSM-5*, the symptoms needed only to "interfere with, or reduce the quality" of, academic functioning.

Recently, mental-health issues have joined ADHD as a primary driver of the accommodations boom. Over the past decade, the number of young people diagnosed with depression or anxiety has exploded. L. Scott Lissner,

the ADA coordinator at Ohio State University, told me that 36 percent of the students registered with OSU's disability office have accommodations for mental-health issues, making them the largest group of students his office serves. Many receive testing accommodations, extensions on take-home assignments, or permission to miss class. Students at Carnegie Mellon University whose severe anxiety makes concentration difficult might get extra time on tests or permission to record class sessions. Catherine Samuel, the school's director of disability resources, told me. Students with social-anxiety disorder can get a note so the professor doesn't call on them without warning.

The types of accommodations vary widely. Some are uncontroversial, such as universities outfitting buildings with ramps and providing course materials in braille. These allow disabled students to access the same opportunities as their classmates. Some students get approved for housing accommodations, including single rooms and emotional-support animals.

Other accommodations risk putting the needs of one student over the experience of their peers. One administrator told me that a student at a public college in California had permission to bring their mother to class. This became a problem, because the mom turned out to be an enthusiastic class participant.

Professors told me that the most common—and most contentious—accommodation is the granting of extra time on exams. For students with learning disabilities, the extra time may be necessary to complete the test. But unlike a wheelchair



ramp, this kind of accommodation can be exploited. Research confirms what intuition suggests: Extra time can confer an advantage to students who don't have a disability.

Complicating matters is the fact that the line between having a learning or psychological disability and struggling with challenging coursework is not always clearly defined. Having ADHD or anxiety, for example, might make it difficult to focus. But focusing is a skill that the educational system is designed to test. Some professors see the current accommodations regime as propping up students who shouldn't have perfect scores. "If we want our grades to be meaningful, they should reflect what the student is capable of," Steven Sloman, a cognitive-science professor at Brown, told me. "Once they're past Brown and off in the real world, that's going to affect their performance."

NO ONE IS more skeptical of the accommodations system than the academics who study it. Robert Weis, a psychology professor at Denison University, pointed me to a Department of Education study that found that middle and high schoolers with disabilities tend to have below-average reading and math skills. These students are half as likely to enroll in a four-year institution as students without disabilities and twice as likely to attend a two-year or community college. If the rise in accommodations were purely a result of more disabled students making it to college, the increase should be more pronounced at less selective institutions than at so-called Ivy Plus schools.

In fact, the opposite appears to be true. According to Weis's research, only 3 to 4 percent of students at public two-year colleges receive accommodations, a proportion that has

stayed relatively stable over the past 10 to 15 years. He and his co-authors found that students with learning disabilities who request accommodations at community colleges "tend to have histories of academic problems beginning in childhood" and evidence of ongoing impairment. At four-year institutions, by contrast, about half of these students "have no record of a diagnosis or disability classification prior to beginning college."

No one can say precisely how many students should qualify for accommodations. The higher prevalence at more selective institutions could reflect the fact that wealthy families and well-resourced schools are better positioned to get students with disabilities the help they need. Even with the lowered bar for a diagnosis, obtaining one can cost thousands of dollars. And as more students with

disabilities get help in middle and high school, that could at least partially explain their enrollment at top colleges.

Still, some students are clearly taking advantage of an easily gamed system. The Varsity Blues college-admissions scandal showed that there are wealthy parents who are willing to pay unscrupulous doctors to provide disability diagnoses to their nondisabled children, securing them extra time on standardized tests. Studies have found that a significant share of students exaggerate symptoms or don't put in enough effort to get valid results on diagnostic tests. When Weis and his colleagues looked at how students receiving accommodations for learning disabilities at a selective liberal-arts school performed on reading, math, and IQ tests, most had above-average cognitive abilities and no evidence of impairment.

A parent in Scarsdale, New York, who works in special education told me that it's become common for parents of honors students to get their kids evaluated so they can have extra time on tests. The process usually starts when kids see that their peers have accommodations—or when they bring home their first B. "It feels in some ways like a badge of honor," she said. "People are all talking about getting their children evaluated now." In 2019, a *Wall Street Journal* analysis found that one in five Scarsdale High School students was considered disabled and eligible for accommodations on college entrance exams—a rate more than seven times higher than the national average.

Several of the college students I spoke with for this story said they knew someone who had obtained a dubious

diagnosis. Hailey Strickler, a senior at the University of Richmond, was diagnosed with ADHD and dyslexia when she was 7 years old. She was embarrassed about her disabilities and wary of getting accommodations, until her sophomore year of college. She was speaking with a friend, who didn't have a disability but had received extra time anyway. "They were like, 'If I'm doing that, you should definitely have the disability accommodations,'" Strickler told me.

"We know that people will act as they are incentivized to act," Brian Scholl, a Yale psychology and cognitive-science professor, told me. "And the students are absolutely incentivized to have as much extra accommodations as they can under any circumstances." Students who receive extra time on the LSAT, for example, earn higher average scores than students who don't.

Even if students aren't consciously trying to gain an unfair edge, some seem to have convinced themselves that they need extra help. Will Lindstrom, the director of the Regents' Center for Learning Disorders at the University of Georgia, told me that the fastest-growing group of students who come to him seems to be those who have done their own research and believe that a disability is the source of their academic or emotional challenges. "It's almost like it's part of their identity," Lindstrom said. "By the time we see them, they're convinced they have a neurodevelopmental disorder."

Lindstrom worries that the system encourages students to see themselves as less capable than they actually are. By attributing all of their difficulties to a disability, they are

pathologizing normal challenges. "When it comes to a disorder like ADHD, we all have those symptoms sometimes," Lindstrom told me. "But most of us aren't impaired by them."

One recent Stanford graduate told me that when she got mononucleosis as a freshman, she turned to the disability office: Because she couldn't exercise, she was struggling to focus in class. Though she'd always been fidgety, she'd never had academic issues in high school—but high school had been easier than Stanford. The office suggested that she might have ADHD, and encouraged her to seek a diagnosis. A psychiatrist and her pediatrician diagnosed her with ADHD and dyslexia, and Stanford granted her extra time on tests, among other accommodations.

Collar, the University of Chicago physics professor, said that part of what his exams are designed to assess is the ability to solve problems in a certain amount of time. But now many of his students are in a separate room, with time and a half or even double the allotted time to complete the test. "I feel for the students who are not taking advantage of this," he told me. "We have a two-speed student population."

MOST OF THE disability advocates I spoke with are more troubled by the students who are still not getting the accommodations they need than by the risk of people exploiting the system. They argue that fraud is rare, and stress that some universities maintain stringent documentation requirements. "I would rather open up access to the five kids who need accommodations but can't afford

documentation, and maybe there's one person who has paid for an evaluation and they really don't need it," Emily Tarconish, a special-education teaching-assistant professor at the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, told me. "That's worth it to me."

Tarconish sees the growing number of students receiving accommodations as evidence

"STUDENTS ARE ABSOLUTELY INCENTIVIZED TO HAVE AS MUCH EXTRA ACCOMMODATIONS AS THEY CAN UNDER ANY CIRCUMSTANCES."

that the system is working. Ella Callow, the assistant vice chancellor of disability rights at Berkeley, had a similar perspective. "I don't think of it as a downside, no matter how many students with disabilities show up," she told me. "Disabled people still are deeply underemployed in this country and too often live in poverty. The key to addressing that is in large part through institutions like Berkeley that make it part of our mission to lift people into security." (One-third of the students registered with Berkeley's disability office are from low-income families.) At the University of Chicago, members of a committee to address the surge in accommodations don't even agree on whether a problem exists, Collar told me.

The surge itself is undeniable. Soon, some schools may have more students receiving

accommodations than not, a scenario that would have seemed absurd just a decade ago. Already, at one law school, 45 percent of students receive academic accommodations. Paul Graham Fisher, a Stanford professor who served as co-chair of the university's disability task force, told me, "I have had conversations with people in the Stanford administration. They've talked about *at what point can we say no?* What if it hits 50 or 60 percent? At what point do you just say 'We can't do this?'" This year, 38 percent of Stanford undergraduates are registered as having a disability; in the fall quarter, 24 percent of undergraduates were receiving academic or housing accommodations.

Mark Schneider, the former head of the educational-research arm of the Department of Education, told me that three of his four grandkids have "individualized education programs," the term of art for accommodations at the K–12 level. "The reward for saying that you have a disability, versus the stigma—the balance between those two things has so radically changed," he said. Were it not for that shift, he added, his grandchildren may not be receiving benefits and services they need. But at the very least, the rewards are not evenly distributed. As more elite students get accommodations, the system worsens the problem it was designed to solve. The ADA was supposed to make college more equitable. Instead, accommodations have become another way for the most privileged students to press their advantage. *A*

Rose Horowitz is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

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BRING BACK THE NEOCONS

They could be an antidote to Trumpism.

BY DAVID BROOKS

W

What comes after Donald Trump? What compelling social vision can replace MAGA's offerings and reverse the tide of global populism? In considering these questions, I find myself returning to an unlikely group of 20th-century thinkers: the neoconservatives.

These days, when people hear the word *neocons*, they tend to think of Republicans who supported the Iraq War. But the notoriety the neocons attained for supporting that war has obscured their origins as a dissident faction within

the American left, one that was staunchly anti-communist but mostly preoccupied with domestic policy.

Here's why the original neocon thinkers—people such as Irving Kristol, James Q. Wilson, Jeane Kirkpatrick, and Daniel Patrick Moynihan—can be so helpful right now: They focused their attention on the bloody crossroads where morality and politics intersect. They saw politics through the lens of not only polling and social-science data, but also literature, philosophy, psychology, and theology. They asked the big questions—not just *How can we win the next election?* but *How can we create a civilization to be proud of?* The moral and spiritual tenor of their political writings could be a tonic for a society in moral and spiritual crisis.

NEOCONSERVATISM coalesced into a movement in the 1970s, but it has its roots in the cafeteria of the City College of New York in the late 1930s. The poor immigrant kids who would go on to found the movement were the Trotskyists who sat in one alcove of that dining hall. They spent their days arguing with one another and with the Stalinists who sat in the neighboring alcove. In those days, Kristol, Irving Howe, Seymour Martin Lipset, Nathan Glazer, and others were convinced that communism was the future, and so it mattered what kind prevailed.

The neoconservatives all broke with Marxism during the Stalin era, and most of them became Franklin D. Roosevelt-style Democrats. Kristol fought the Nazis in Europe and realized that if communism ever came to

America, it would turn into a massively corrupt criminal enterprise, which is what eventually happened in the Soviet Union. After the war, many of the neocons went on to become social scientists at places such as Harvard, Princeton, and UC Berkeley. Others became journalists or editors of magazines such as *Commentary* and *Encounter*.

Their second big shift occurred during the 1960s and '70s. Glazer went to work in the Kennedy administration, at the Housing and Home Finance Agency (the predecessor to the Department of Housing and Urban Development). In 1965, Kristol and Daniel Bell founded a magazine called *The Public Interest*. Swept up in the intoxicating social-science confidence of the era, they believed that we now had the knowledge to settle old ideological feuds and solve social problems scientifically. "Men are learning how to make an industrial economy work," Moynihan wrote in the magazine's first issue.

That confidence underlaid the explosion of social-policy making that helped define the '60s. Lyndon B. Johnson's Great Society brought a raft of new programs that aimed to eliminate poverty and inequality. The Nixon administration followed with more in the same vein—the creation of the Environmental Protection Agency and the Occupational Safety and Health Administration, along with a 20 percent increase in Social Security benefits and proposals for both a national health-insurance system and a universal basic income for households with children.

From 1960 to 1980, federal spending increased from about \$91 billion to about \$584 billion. In 1960, defense spending

made up about half of the federal budget. By 1980, it was down to less than a quarter. At the start of 1960, approximately 250,000 people were on welfare in New York City. At the beginning of 1969, about 900,000 were.

The new programs did not produce the intended results. By the 1970s, the economy was in terrible shape, pushed into a

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recession by the Vietnam War, an oil embargo, and the high cost of Johnson's Great Society. In May 1975, the unemployment rate hit 9 percent. A few years later, the inflation rate neared 15 percent. The productivity rate started to decline in 1973—and the poverty rate ticked upward.

Social measures, too, painted a grim picture. From 1960 to 1980, divorce rates more than doubled. The share of children born out of wedlock more than tripled. Violent-crime rates also more than tripled. Drug use exploded. The public-housing projects that had been built with such promise turned into hellscape.

As someone who grew up in New York City in the '70s, I'm astounded by the level of social disorder we all learned to live with. Pretty much everyone I knew got mugged. In 1972 and 1973, there was a serial castrator and killer in Manhattan nicknamed Charlie Chop-Off. He was never caught, and such was the general chaos that it wasn't even that big of a story.

The neocons were mostly immigrant kids who'd grown up in places like Brooklyn, when the borough was still a haven for working-class New Yorkers. They had seen their families rise out of poverty by embracing the common bourgeois virtues: hard work, thrift, self-reliance, self-discipline, respect for tradition, and an intense focus on education. When the counterculture arose in the '60s, the neocons were dismayed to see affluent kids at Berkeley, Harvard, and Columbia dropping out, doing acid, denouncing the industrious and traditional culture of their parents, and embracing the social anarchy resulting from that culture's erosion.

The disillusionment of the '60s made neoconservatism bipartisan. Some neocons—such as Kristol, Norman Podhoretz, and Midge Decter—became Republicans. Others—such as Moynihan and Glazer—stuck with the Democrats. But they remained a coherent and ever more influential intellectual force in American life.

The events of the '60s and '70s taught the men and women who would become neocons two big lessons. The first was that society is a lot more complicated than it looks, and that many attempts to reengineer it end up producing no benefits at all—or worse. A 1971 essay by Glazer

in *Commentary*, “The Limits of Social Policy,” captured the chastened mood. So did Kristol’s famous definition of a neoconservative: “a liberal who has been mugged by reality.” In 1973, in another essay for *Commentary*, the neoconservative political scientist Aaron Wildavsky observed that experts had a lot of information about society’s problems, but nobody knew how to fix them. Consequently, “vast amounts of money and even vaster amounts of enthusiasm were poured into various programs that ultimately ended in failure and bewilderment.”

Those commonly associated with the neoconservative crew were not against trying to use government to relieve poverty or inequality—Moynihan, Glazer, and Bell were not libertarians or even small-government conservatives. But their insight was that if you’re going to launch a big federal program, you had better acknowledge that most programs—whether job training, education reform, or efforts to reduce juvenile delinquency—fail. You had better have a lot of evidence that your idea will work, and you had better proceed cautiously, experimentally, and without building big bureaucracies.

Given this hard-earned skepticism and epistemological modesty, it is ironic that many later conservatives—including me—who had supped at the neocon table would come to embrace a grand project to create democracy in Iraq. In fact, the single most famous neoconservative essay on foreign policy is Jeane Kirkpatrick’s 1979 article “Dictatorships & Double Standards,” also in *Commentary*, in which she explains that laying the groundwork for a democracy where one does

not yet exist requires decades of civil-society work. “It seems clear that the architects of contemporary American foreign policy have little idea of how to go about encouraging the liberalization of an autocracy,” she wrote. Somehow, 24 years later, that lesson was forgotten on the way to Iraq.

ANOTHER IMPORTANT truth the neocons learned from the ’60s is that you can’t separate policy making from moral character. The political scientist James Q. Wilson put it this way in *The Public Interest* in 1985: “The most important change in how one defines the public interest that I have witnessed—and experienced—over the last twenty years has been a deepening concern for the development of character in the citizenry.”

When trying to effect social change, Wilson continued, “the essential first step is to acknowledge that at root, in almost every area of important public concern, we are seeking to induce persons to act virtuously, whether as school children, applicants for public assistance, would-be lawbreakers, or voters and public officials. Not only is such conduct desirable in its own right, it appears now to be necessary if large improvements are to be made in those matters we consider problems: schooling, welfare, crime, and public finance.”

When neocons evaluated any policy proposal, the core questions they asked were: Does this moralize or demoralize the people it touches? Does this induce them to behave more responsibly or less? By *morality*, they didn’t mean the kind of fancy notions explored by Thomas Aquinas

and Immanuel Kant. They just meant the basics: Does this policy encourage people to work hard, be good parents and neighbors, delay gratification, and recognize not just their rights but their responsibilities?

Neocons like Kristol had no problem with Social Security, which reduced poverty among seniors. Giving seniors money doesn’t give them a greater incentive to grow old. But neoconservatives noticed that the number of single-parent families surged following the War on Poverty’s expansion of welfare. A guaranteed income, they argued, reduced labor-force participation and the desire to work. They noticed that when you give a country permission to rack up a huge federal deficit, you are giving people permission to behave more and more selfishly toward future generations. So the neocons put virtue at the center of their public-policy thinking; they were not afraid to be moralistic.

They rejected the privatization of morality, which they saw happening around them, especially in the 1960s, ’70s, and ’80s. During that hyper-individualistic moment, many Americans valorized the idea that a person’s values, tastes, and cultural attitudes are a private affair. Because everybody’s moral standards are different, no one should try to impose their morality on someone else. Live and let live. That idea is still with us.

The neocons, by contrast, believed that humans are social and spiritual creatures whose souls are either ennobled or degraded by the systems, cultures, and behaviors in which we are enmeshed. We’re constantly influencing and being influenced by one

another. We’re all reliant on a shared pool of moral capital—the values, norms, behaviors, and institutions that make it easier for people to be good. When you privatize morality, you drain the pool of shared moral capital.

The neocons inspected each of society’s systems, trying to identify ways they ennobled or degraded people. For example, their support for capitalism was ambivalent because, although capitalism encourages risk taking and industriousness (good for the economy), it also tends to inflame greed and philistinism (bad for the soul). Bell’s 1976 book, *The Cultural Contradictions of Capitalism*, noted that although capitalism relies on farsighted, self-disciplined people to create value and grow the economy, the advertising and the consumerist mentality that capitalism generates encourage shortsightedness and self-indulgence.

The neoconservatives also paid enormous attention to the mediating institutions of society, those entities that successfully transmit values from one generation to the next—families, neighborhoods, congregations, civic organizations. The neocons argued that the left, seeing society almost exclusively in terms of the individual and the state, gave short shrift to these valuable institutions. Because neocons saw them as seedbeds of character and as cultural shock absorbers for when times get hard, they were concerned that the expansion of the state seemed to be weakening and displacing these institutions. Though many neocons were not religious themselves, they were alarmed by the decline of religion and of congregational life. They were alarmed, too, by the

policy of deinstitutionalization, which took mentally ill people out of mental-health facilities, put them on the street, and called it freedom. This kind of approach, neocons argued, was hopelessly hyper-individualized, placing the “freedom” of the individual before the safety of the community.

The neocons also paid enormous attention to the prevailing ethos of their time—what we might call the spirit of the age. They believed that this ethos was not driven primarily by economic and political forces, but shaped by shifts in culture and ideas. “Individuals, families, churches, and communities cannot operate in isolation, cannot long maintain values at odds with those legitimated by the state and popularized by the culture,” Gertrude Himmelfarb, a neoconservative historian, wrote in *The Public Interest* in 1994. So if the wider assumptions of society are shaped by hyper-individualism, antinomianism, and (as Christopher Lasch put it) a culture of narcissism, then society is likely to deteriorate. One of Moynihan’s famous essays, published in *The American Scholar* in 1993, was “Defining Deviancy Down,” which theorized that as the amount of deviant behavior in a community rises, people tend to define behavior that was once considered deviant as normal and acceptable.

While old-fashioned conservatives cited Edmund Burke and libertarians cited Adam Smith, neocons never tired of quoting Alexis de Tocqueville. He shaped how they saw society—as a single civilization in which politics and culture, economics and morality, democracy and

spirituality were all fundamentally inseparable. The spirit of civilization shapes who people are, how they perceive reality, and what they think is right and wrong. In every endeavor, the crucial question is: What sort of people are we nurturing into being?

The neoconservatives believed that they were living amid a crisis of values. Not a clash between two different value systems but a crisis in the very idea of value. Seduced by social-science rationalism, moral relativism, or political partisanship, people had trouble thinking clearly about what separates a morally healthy society from a morally unhealthy one. This created a void in the soul of society and engendered a sense of alienation. “Secular rationalism has been unable to produce a compelling, self-justifying moral code,” Kristol said in 1991. The result is nihilism—an amoral culture in which people grow up without coherent values.

SO HOW CAN neoconservative thinking help us today? The first big lesson of neoconservatism is that character is destiny. That lesson applies whether you’re talking about the character of a leader, an organization, or a nation. If you disregard truth—as many Republicans plainly do these days—you will wind up in some pretty ugly places.

If you want to improve the character of a nation or an organization, you have to change its culture so that it nurtures basic decency. Which leads to the second lesson of neoconservatism: The most important values in a democratic society are the pedestrian bourgeois virtues. Aristocratic societies may do

better at inspiring heroism, genius, love of honor. But democratic societies rely on showing up on time, working hard, being there for your neighbor, listening with curiosity, respecting traditions.

The third crucial insight from the neoconservatives is that culture drives history. The assumptions people rely on, the mental categories in their heads, the things they admire

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and disdain, the way they process the world, their norms and habits—all of this will determine how they behave.

But perhaps the most important belief that the neoconservatives can impart to us is that the American dream is real. The original neocons, the sons and daughters of immigrants, aspired to make it in America and contribute to their adopted home. If libertarians oriented their politics around freedom, and progressives oriented their politics around equality, the neocons tended to orient theirs around social mobility. They wanted to create a world in which poor boys and girls like themselves could rise and

succeed. They understood that this ascent required not just economic opportunity, but also the right values.

Today, roughly 70 percent of Americans say they don’t believe in the American dream. That loss of faith is like a giant bomb detonated in the middle of our society, robbing us of our central, unifying vision. Absent that shared vision of possibility, people revert to a tribal, us-versus-them morality. If the ghosts of the original neocons have anything to tell us about specific policy choices, it’s that we need to do what we can to expand social mobility and restore faith in the American dream.

The other thing the ghosts of the neocons would tell us is that the fight for the American dream is as much moral as political or economic. When he was running for president in 2020, Joe Biden was right to say that the election was a struggle for the soul of America. The problem was that neither he nor the people in his administration knew how to wage a moral and cultural battle. Trump, in contrast, is a genius at cultural warfare. Because of their history going back to the New Deal, Democrats are more comfortable talking about expanding health insurance, investing in infrastructure, and reducing prescription-drug prices. All of that is important. But they will continually lose to MAGA’s cultural warriors unless they can connect those policies to a story about reversing America’s moral decline. This is where a new and repurposed neoconservatism can help them. *A*

David Brooks is a contributing writer at The Atlantic.

By the Horns

Photographs by Owen Harvey

The week before the biggest bullfight of her career, in Cádiz, Spain, this past July, 24-year-old Miriam Cabas posted a carefully produced video on Instagram. Cabas appears not in a traditional matador costume but in a cream pantsuit, watching a little girl—4, maybe 5—wave a red muleta at an imaginary bull. “Dreams come true,” she wrote in the caption. “The little girl I used to be still guides me.”

Cabas triumphed that day, killing two bulls and receiving three of their ears as trophies. It was the first time she had fought animals antagonized by picadors, men on horseback who stab the bulls with lances, testing their aggression and forcing them to lower their heads on their subsequent charges at the bullfighters. For the uninitiated, this was a big deal: Cabas had reached the final stage of her training to become a professional matador, one of vanishingly few women to compete in the intensely traditional field.

The British photographer Owen Harvey was there to document her victory. Harvey has followed Cabas’s career for more than a year as part of a series on young matadors. He could feel the crowd rooting for her, he told me. Cabas is a local talent, born in Los Barrios, a small town on Spain’s southern tip where bullfighting is still very much alive. She was introduced to the activity by her grandfather, who

signed her up for after-school lessons when she was just 5. There were other girls, though not many, and only she persevered to become a professional.

Effectively banned in certain regions and vilified by some members of Spain’s left-wing coalition government, bullfighting has become a potent political symbol for the country’s resurgent far right. The populist Vox party has made a point of celebrating it as an essential Spanish tradition—and of trolling those concerned about animal cruelty. Cabas, for her part, prefers not to be explicit about her politics. She appreciates those who have protected bullfighting and does consider it an important aspect of Spanish identity, but, unlike some of her peers, she doesn’t post photos with far-right politicians. (Though Vox supports the way Cabas makes a living, its leaders are unequivocally anti-feminist.) Cabas doesn’t linger on her role as a barrier breaker, either. “You risk your life before a *toro bravo*, and that’s equally hard for men or women,” she told me.

These days, she balances an intense training regimen with her college courses. She’s studying to become a veterinarian. “Nobody loves bulls like us,” she said. “We devote our lives to them—if that’s not love, then what is?”

—Begoña Gómez Urzaiz





Miriam Cabas killed two bulls at a fight in Cádiz, Spain, on July 19, 2025. The crowd waved white handkerchiefs to signal its satisfaction with her performance.





THE MYSTERY OF MOHAMMAD TAJIK

*A man
claiming to
be an Iranian
intelligence
officer promised
me he'd reveal
his country's
secrets. But first
he had a game
to play.*

*Illustrations by
Adam Maida*

BY SHANE HARRIS

I.



THE GAME

In December 2011, the CIA lost control of a stealth drone near the Iranian city of Kashmar, about 140 miles from the Afghanistan border, and it wound up in the regime's possession. On state television, the Iranian military displayed the boomerang-shaped craft like a trophy. Triumphant banners beneath its 30-foot wings said, in Farsi, *THE US CAN'T MESS WITH US* and *WE'LL CRUSH AMERICA UNDERFOOT*.

The cause of the crash was a mystery. Had the Lockheed Martin drone—a multimillion-dollar RQ-170 Sentinel—simply gone off course? Or had Iranian hackers commandeered the aircraft, demonstrating the prowess of a growing cyberarmy that had already alarmed U.S. officials?

Just over four years later, in April 2016, a known Iranian hacker group named Parastoo—the Farsi word for “swallow,” the small bird—posted its email address to a cybersecurity message board, inviting journalists to ask it about what had happened to the drone. In my experience covering national security, people who claim to have “the real story” are usually quacks or kooks. Still, I figured it was worth an email.

“I understand you want to discuss the CIA's RQ-170 drone,” I wrote to parastoo@unseen.is on April 12, 2016. “Want to talk?”

Thirty-six hours later, someone calling himself “P” responded, in clumsy but mostly legible English. “Yes, i want my identity protected and in series of either live interviews or chat-based conversations i would like to reveal all behind that story.”

Reveal all. Sounded kooky.

P said he was part of Parastoo, which had once broken into a server of the United Nations' International Atomic Energy Agency and claimed to have hacked the U.S. National Nuclear Security Administration. The group had also bragged that it could take over U.S. military drones, even once suggesting that it could send one to attack then-Vice President Joe Biden.

P said he would communicate initially via an encrypted text-messaging app called Cryptocat, but coordinating our schedules wasn't easy. P said he was in Tehran, which was seven and a half hours ahead of Washington, D.C. We settled on Monday, May 2, 2016, for our first conversation.

P asked me questions designed to confirm that I was the person he had corresponded with over email. Where did I work? (*The Daily Beast*, at the time.) Did I have a phone number tied to a specific location? He also asked me a series of biographical questions, such as where I went to college, that he could easily corroborate online. My answers, P said, “helped my investigations on you.”

No source had ever interrogated me like this before. P didn't talk like a hacker. He was acting like a spy.

P said he was an officer in the Ministry of Intelligence and Security, Iran's CIA. And not just any officer. He said he was in charge of an elite cyber-warfare unit—the kind of group that might have been tasked with taking down an American drone.

P described how his colleagues had captured the Sentinel. His unit obtained satellite and radio information about how the drone communicated with its base, as well as technical information about its stealth capabilities, which he claimed Iran had received from the Chinese People's Liberation Army. Iran then located the drone mid-flight and prevented it from returning to Afghanistan. The drone wandered aimlessly until gravity took over.

“She ran outa gas and had to emergency landing by parachute,” P typed.

By May 11, he trusted me enough to identify himself. “My name is Mohammad Hossein Tajik,” he wrote. “I am 35 but very older like 999 years older in the heart and in the ass!” I didn't quite get the joke, but it seemed that life had taken a toll on him.

A “huge number” of Iranian cyber operations “had my signature on the paperwork or I designed it altogether,” Mohammad claimed. At the time, Iran had been credibly linked to disruptions of the global financial system and to the penetration of computers that run crucial infrastructure, such as electrical grids and dams, including one in New York State. Was I now talking to the guy who oversaw those covert operations? And if so, why was he talking to me?

The more we communicated, the less kooky he sounded. Mohammad didn't try to confuse me with technical jargon or wow me with heroics—which made him more credible. Then he said that he didn't actually want to talk about the drone. The Sentinel had been a lure to get my attention.

Mohammad said he wanted my help with a plan. Part one of it: revenge. He wanted to leak information about Iranian intelligence operations in order to hurt and humiliate Iran's leaders, who had profoundly upset him, though he didn't tell me how. In his plan, I would vet Mohammad's claims with my intelligence sources and publish the information if it checked out.

This idea suited me fine. An aggrieved government employee is often a journalist's best source.

Part two of Mohammad's plan was, frankly, insane. He told me he was once an asset for the CIA, and had worked on “big ops.” He wanted to rekindle his relationship with the agency. He was hoping I would connect with his former CIA handler using my contacts within the agency, and convey that Mohammad was still a valuable asset, as evidenced by my eventual news articles sourced to him. If the CIA didn't welcome Mohammad back in from the cold, he would expose how the CIA operated inside Iran.

“Using this model,” he texted, “i can work with you and get what i want in return.”

In blunt fashion, he was expressing how both our businesses work. Mine eschews deception, but journalists collect sources, then assess and second-guess them, just as spies do. A journalist and an intelligence officer are both trying to piece together a coherent story from confusing fragments of reality. And very few

journalists, if any, could count a senior Iranian intelligence officer turned American spy as a source.

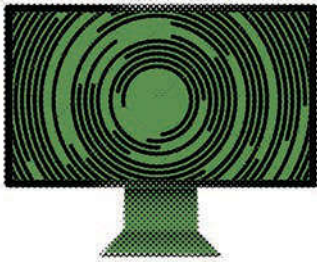
"Are you in?" Mohammad asked me.

I did not commit to part two of the plan—journalists don't negotiate on our sources' behalf, or involve ourselves in intelligence operations—but was happy to proceed with part one: leaking secrets to me.

"I'm in," I typed.

"Alright—let the game begin."

II.



THE SOURCE

I had never spoken with an Iranian intelligence officer before, so I had no baseline to assess whether Mohammad fit the profile. I pictured some version of Shaun Toub, the actor who had played an Iranian spy chief turned CIA asset in the third season of *Homeland*. Restrained. Unhurried. Elegant.

That was not Mohammad. His patience was short. He tried a little too hard to be funny. He was cocky but vulnerable, and sometimes goofy. I remember thinking, *He's a nerd*.

He had never married, which was unusual for someone in his position of responsibility, he told me. For several years he'd had an online relationship with a woman, but they had not met in person. He never mentioned friends in Tehran.

"I got not much social life outside work," he said.

He loved Western culture, especially American movies. He quoted a scene from *The Shawshank Redemption* in which Morgan Freeman's character, released from prison into an unfriendly world, narrates: "No way I'm gonna make it on the outside." We discovered that we

were both fans of *All the President's Men*. Perhaps Mohammad fancied himself as Deep Throat, meeting me in a virtual parking garage and hinting at greater revelations to come. Our weekly encrypted conversations—over Cryptocat, Skype, and Proton Mail—had a cinematic thrill. But unlike in *All the President's Men*, I was learning as much about the source himself as the regime he claimed to be undermining.

Mohammad told me he was born into a religious and politically active family. In 1979, his father joined fellow revolutionaries in storming the headquarters of the Shah's secret police force, and interrogating and torturing officers; then he helped found Iran's intelligence service. "I hate this whole SHIT immeasurably," Mohammad told me about the family business. But he was a math prodigy and computer whiz, and at age 18, he started working for the intelligence ministry. Within a decade, he said, he was playing a central role in Iran's aggressive expansion into cyber warfare.

Over several conversations, Mohammad gave me a detailed overview of Iran's cyber battlefield: the countries it was targeting in the Middle East, particularly Israel and Saudi Arabia, and the alliances it had formed with Russia and China. He explained how the intelligence ministry concealed its hand by hiring contractors—specifically tech companies run by young men who, like Mohammad, had graduated from computer-science and engineering programs at Iranian universities. Two of Mohammad's contractor friends were indicted in a U.S. district court in March 2016 for cyberattacks against dozens of U.S. financial institutions. Like Mohammad, his friends were the children of military or political officials "who got into business based on their fathers reputation," he said. One of their fellow hackers was also indicted for breaking into the control systems of the dam in New York.

If he was telling the truth, Mohammad was taking me deeper into the regime's cyberworld than any of my sources had ever done. He said he'd been involved in an audacious 2012 attack on Saudi Aramco, the kingdom's oil company, that wiped out information on three-quarters of its office computers. In 2015, Mohammad claimed, his team penetrated a commercial satellite

network called iDirect to take control of U.S. drones. I've seen no evidence that Iran was able to use a drone in an attack, though Mohammad described to me how Iran could commandeer one. ("There is no record, evidence, or indication of any such incident" like what Mohammad described, an iDirect spokesperson told me, noting that the company doesn't own or operate drones, nor does it operate any satellite networks.)

Mohammad said his colleagues shared techniques with Russia's military-intelligence service, the GRU, and were behind the 2015 attacks on the electrical system in Turkey, a NATO member.

In his most astonishing claim, Mohammad told me that Iran was responsible for a major cyberattack on the central bank of Bangladesh, from which hackers stole \$81 million in February 2016, sowing panic throughout the global financial system. The U.S. Justice Department indicted three hackers from North Korea. Mohammad said that Iran had played a secret role. It had given technical instructions to Hezbollah, the Lebanon-based militia, about how to manipulate a communications network known as SWIFT, which connects financial institutions. The group then traded the information, for missiles, to North Korea.

Mohammad said Iran gave permission for Hezbollah to attack. "Our assumption was they'd do the hack," he said. "But they did something smarter."

If it was revealed that Iran and North Korea were covertly collaborating, the United States' retaliation would presumably be severe. To test Mohammad's claims, I spoke with half a dozen researchers who'd studied the Bangladesh Bank robbery. None had found any indication that Iran had participated. But they thought Mohammad's description of events sounded plausible.

My notebook was filling up with plausibilities. Was Mohammad giving me major scoops, or tall tales? If he was being honest, then he was putting his life at great risk. How badly had the regime wronged him that he would tell these secrets to a journalist? And, before that, to the CIA?

Mohammad said he had been an American intelligence asset for about five

years, but indicated that the relationship had ended on bad terms. He told me that the CIA would now engage with him for only one reason: to exfiltrate him from Iran. All he had to do was get to a U.S. consulate or embassy in another country and say an agreed-upon passcode at the front desk. Then he would be protected and free. If that was true, why hadn't he accepted the offer?

III.



THE EGO

There's an old saw in the intelligence profession about what motivates someone to betray their country and spy for another: MICE.

Money: They need it, and will sell information for it.

Ideology: They want to help a cause, or tear one down.

Coercion: They're being blackmailed.

Ego: They have a big one, and it needs feeding.

Mohammad lightly checked the "I" box. Service to the Islamic Republic was Mohammad's "family legacy," he told me, but he'd begun to view the regime as corrupt, hypocritical, and out of touch. The intelligence ministry spied on Iranians with professional ties overseas and accused some of plotting revolution. Iran was cutting itself off from the rest of the world and dismantling recent reforms just as Mohammad was going online and imagining a life beyond the one he knew.

"Through the years specially after internet i get to read and see very much, previously hidden from me and i started to change," Mohammad told me in May 2016, adding: "Eventually i turned into a TRUE ENEMY of this whole

shitty regime and all that relates to it from every aspect."

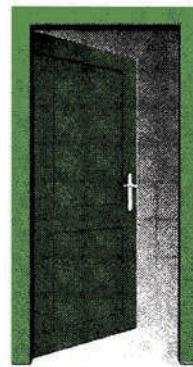
But what really motivated Mohammad was the "E" box: ego. He believed he was smarter than most people, including his contacts at the CIA. He relished playing two roles—trusted by Iran, engaged by the United States. But that took a toll.

Mohammad worked hard to keep up his outward persona of a fervent supporter of the regime and the Islamic Revolution. A member of "God's party/army in all aspects," as he put it. "I live a complicated double life, and it's hurting me as a human inside," he told me. At one point, he described his life as a CIA asset: "Being still a double—turning into a triple and later to a nothing/everything/ticking-bomb." I didn't understand what he meant, but I had the sense that I didn't know the real Mohammad.

As he rose in the intelligence ministry's ranks, he told me, he took several trips to Lebanon and grew close to top Hezbollah leaders, including Imad Mughniyeh, who'd plotted the 1983 bombings of the U.S. embassy and Marine barracks in Beirut. Mohammad's friendships with some of the world's most notorious terrorists—who had American blood on their hands—would have made him a prized CIA asset. He told me that he'd shared information about Hezbollah's organizational structure with the CIA, and told the agency how Hezbollah units interacted with the Iranian intelligence ministry.

The CIA had hunted Mughniyeh for decades and finally killed him in a joint operation with Israel in February 2008, the same year that Mohammad said he began working for the agency. In our conversations, Mohammad never claimed direct credit for American operations—that was another sign of his credibility, in my book—but his time with the CIA coincides with other notable U.S.-intelligence successes in Iran. In September 2009, for example, Western leaders announced the discovery of Fordow, an underground uranium-enrichment plant (which the Trump administration would bomb in 2025). Given his position, Mohammad could have known about the site. If he had wanted to "hurt the regime," as he said, he was well placed to do so.

IV.



THE VISIT

For two months in the late spring and early summer of 2016, Mohammad told me stories about his family, his cyber exploits, his work with the Americans, his plans to settle scores with the regime. I liked him. He made me laugh. I wouldn't call him a friend, but we were friendly.

Vetting Mohammad's more sensational claims took a back seat as I tried to keep pace with a furious news cycle. In one week during July 2016, I juggled stories about the FBI's decision not to recommend prosecution of Hillary Clinton for using a private email server, the Russian government's hacking of the Democratic National Committee's computer network, and the Republican National Convention in Cleveland.

When Mohammad and I spoke on July 2, 2016, he was anticipating a new round of cyberattacks, this time on Saudi Arabian banks. He told me more about how Hezbollah had assisted North Korea with cyber tactics, and I wanted to devote our next conversation to the subject. We agreed to speak three days later.

Mohammad didn't show up online at our designated time. He had never missed an appointment, though he was often preoccupied with work. A few days later, I got a text from a well-known journalist named Ruhollah Zam, an Iranian dissident living in exile in Paris. Mohammad had been sharing information with him, too, and had introduced us weeks earlier. Zam sounded panicked.

"Have you heard what happened?" he asked.

Mohammad was dead.

I felt sick—not just at the news, but out of fear that I might have done something to get Mohammad killed. Had Iranian counterintelligence officers been monitoring us? I spent the next two weeks reviewing our security protocols, agonizing over whether we could have been safer.

Zam forwarded me a text exchange with a member of Mohammad's family that suggested that Mohammad had been murdered by the regime. Zam also sent me Mohammad's death certificate, showing that he had died on July 5, the day we were supposed to speak. His body had since been buried in Behesht-e Zahra, Tehran's main cemetery.

Using Google Translate, I made sense of Zam's subsequent messages. Amir, Mohammad's youngest brother, had found the body. There had been no autopsy. Zam alleged that Mohammad's father, who was known by the honorific Hajji Vali, had killed his own son in an act of loyalty to country over family.

Then, on July 18, I got a call from the FBI. An agent from the Washington field office said he needed to discuss something sensitive.

The agent came to my house two days later. We sat in the living room. He told me that he specialized in notifying victims of computer hacking. People—presumably unfriendly ones—were chattering about me overseas, and the FBI wasn't sure why. The agent asked: Had anyone sent me strange messages recently?

You don't know the half of it, I thought. "It's Iran, isn't it?" I asked.

The agent nodded. He asked why I thought so.

Without revealing Mohammad's name or that he'd claimed to work for the CIA, I told the agent that I had developed an Iranian source and that we had communicated over the previous two months.

The agent asked for his whereabouts.

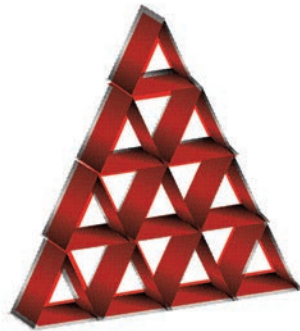
He was killed two weeks ago, I said.

The agent sat in silence for a moment. He appeared to choose his next words carefully. A group of Iranians—he didn't say whom they worked for—was discussing me by name, and clearly wanted to know more about me. Now he understood why.

Were my husband and I in danger? The agent said he didn't think so. One of our cats strolled into the living room and sniffed at the agent's pants. "My security detail," I said.

The agent doubted that I was to blame for the killing. Mohammad had indeed been playing a game. And now I was left with a puzzle.

V.



THE PIECES

First, I wanted to finally answer the big question: Was Mohammad really a spy for the CIA?

One of my intelligence sources gasped when I mentioned Mohammad's name over lunch, and described him as "a brilliant hacker." Another smiled nervously and called him "the person you're talking about," as if saying Mohammad's name would reveal classified information. Yet another confirmed that, earlier in the Obama administration, a prized Iranian asset had made it possible for the United States to confidently and publicly blame Iran for the cyberattack on Saudi Aramco. Mohammad had told me that he participated in that operation; apparently, he also told the CIA about it.

Mohammad was indeed among the CIA's most well-placed assets, as he had claimed.

The other pieces of the puzzle—who had killed Mohammad, and what had led him to that fate—were harder to assemble.

When Mohammad and the CIA parted ways, in 2013, it was a bad time for spies. Iran had breached the CIA's internet-based system for covertly communicating with its agents in the field. Mohammad told me that he'd never trusted Langley's

communications procedures. When he communicated with his handlers, he said, he used his own private network to connect with the Sony laptop the agency had given him.

The laptop prevented Mohammad from taking screenshots, so he used his personal phone to photograph his communications and made copies of information he gave the CIA. "For insurance," he told me. He had broken protocol because he thought he was smarter than the Americans. This was a profound mistake.

After Mohammad's death, I tracked down people who knew him, including friends and Iranian activists living abroad. I learned that he had been arrested by Iran a few months after the CIA cut ties with him, three years before he connected with me. Those phone photos easily could have tipped off the regime. In August 2013, he was taken to a detention center on the eastern outskirts of Tehran. A month later, Mohammad was transferred to Evin Prison, a notorious facility designed to isolate detainees and break them.

Mohammad endured months of torture, he would later tell friends. Interrogators poured boiling water on his penis. They forced him to curl up in a pit shaped like a grave, with a light shining on him at all hours. Mohammad was charged with spying for Iran's adversaries.

All the President's Men had been a touchstone for our relationship. But, with the revelation of his imprisonment, I thought about that other favorite movie of ours. Mohammad had ended up in *Shawshank*—a prisoner in the torture chambers at Evin, but also a lifelong captive of the regime itself.

After spending half a year in jail, Mohammad was released to await trial. This is highly unusual in Iran. But Mohammad was bailed out, according to his friend, by a powerful ally in the security establishment: his father, Hajji Vali.

Mohammad spent six months in a hospital recovering from his injuries. His dark beard turned white. For a year, he couldn't sit straight. Then, in January 2015, Mohammad sent an email to Zam, who had also been tortured in Evin, after he participated in the political protests in 2009. Mohammad told Zam

that he had spied for the CIA and that he didn't trust his father. He couldn't talk to his brothers; two also worked for the intelligence service, and the other, Amir, was too young to comprehend the mess Mohammad had made. But he could talk to journalists and dissidents.

Zam told me that he and Mohammad spoke nearly every night for a year. Zam wanted political change. Mohammad wanted payback through political change. He became a valuable anonymous source within the regime for Zam's independent news organization, which had a following in the Iranian diaspora and among foreign journalists. If he ever did leave the country, Mohammad said, he wanted to be known as "Iran's Snowden": a former insider who became a symbol of resistance.

Ego, indeed. Mohammad was engaged in the very behavior for which he was awaiting trial. As if that wasn't crazy enough, he soon started talking to me.



Mohammad Tajik (*left*) and his youngest brother, Amir

VI.



THE TRIPLE AGENT?

Mohammad never told me about his time in prison, or that he had been charged with espionage. Now I understood why he wanted to hurt the regime: It had hurt him.

But I also questioned how truthful Mohammad had been with me. In 2011, *The Christian Science Monitor* had published some of the details of the Sentinel-drone takedown, though not nearly as precise as Mohammad's version. Perhaps he was just parroting that report back to me, with his own embellishments. Mohammad also had been in custody during some of the exploits that he'd claimed his team carried out. How did he know about them? And had he gone back to work for the regime after he was released and was awaiting trial?

That seems implausible. More likely, I have concluded, is that Mohammad remained in touch with colleagues and was aware of what they were up to. In hindsight, he was more reckless than I knew.

Even as he stared down a court date, he was trying to use me to rekindle his relationship with the CIA. And the whole time, he was leaking to me and Zam. He took yet another risk introducing the two of us, a month before he died, because the Iranians were almost certainly trying to penetrate Zam's communications, given his prominence in the dissident community. Zam urged Mohammad to leave Iran. Mohammad said he wasn't ready. He worried about leaving behind Amir.

And, of course, Mohammad had unfinished business with the regime. That's where I came in, as his desired broker with the CIA.

But here's what Mohammad probably never knew, or didn't want to admit: The CIA had cut ties because the risk of working with him became greater than the value of his information. My sources told me he didn't follow instructions. One day he'd be clearheaded; the next he'd be acting paranoid, imagining conspiracies.

Some officers wondered if he was taking drugs that impaired his judgment. It's a handler's job to manage sources. And Mohammad, one U.S. official told me, had become "unmanageable."

Something else gave CIA officers pause. No one had ever met Mohammad in the flesh. He was a "walk-in": a volunteer spy rather than a recruit. Mohammad's handlers knew he was special—a senior intelligence officer from a prominent family with access to extraordinary information—but the CIA never seemed fully comfortable with him.

And the CIA had good reasons to suspect that Mohammad may have been compromised. He had been thrown in prison for espionage shortly after the agency cut ties. Then, months after his arrest, he was suddenly set free and wanted to reestablish his relationship with the agency. Perhaps the Iranians had coerced him into working against the Americans, in exchange for his freedom.

I thought about the cryptic message he'd sent me about his life at that time: "Being still a double—turning into a triple and later to a nothing/everything/ticking-bomb."

When Mohammad was trying to reconnect with the Americans, was he actually working for Iran? And by asking for my help, had Mohammad been using me to entrap the CIA?

A nothing/everything/ticking-bomb. That's a man who had come to the end of his rope. Who thought he was dangerous, to others and maybe himself. Now I know that while he was talking with me, Mohammad was about to take the biggest—and final—risk of his life.

VII.



THE PUZZLE

In July 2016, two months into our communications, Mohammad planned to fly to Turkey and give regime documents to Zam. He spent days scanning them. He converted Iranian currency into U.S. dollars. His suitcase was packed.

According to Zam, Mohammad's next leak was supposed to involve Iran's efforts to acquire a nuclear weapon from another country. I have only Zam's word on this. Mohammad never told me about any such operation; my other sources have never even suggested that Iran attempted to procure a nuke. I can't say if Zam was exaggerating, or if Mohammad had led him on.

Amir, who was perhaps the main reason his brother had stayed in Iran, saw the suitcase and asked where Mohammad was going.

To Turkey to meet a friend, Mohammad replied. You should come with me.

Amir refused. He left the house and told their father that Mohammad was leaving, according to information Zam pieced together from conversations with his own sources and text messages with Amir.

At 3 p.m. on July 5, the day Mohammad and I were supposed to next meet online, his father, Hajji Vali, and another

official from the intelligence ministry came to his house, Zam told me. Amir returned home that evening and found his brother's body. A few days later, the home was raided. The authorities took Mohammad's possessions, including his computer.

Rumors have circulated for years in the diaspora about how Mohammad died. His burial certificate lists no cause of death. I've read claims on Iranian blogs that he had a heart attack, but friends told me he was in relatively good health, save for a reliance on painkillers (torture has a long tail).

The most widely shared story among regime critics in exile is that Hajji Vali killed him—if not with his own hands, then by his orders. Zam was certain of this, but he, too, had come from a prominent family that he left behind in Iran. Maybe Mohammad's father was merely a convenient villain for the story Zam was trying to tell.

Hajji Vali kept away from his son's grave at the burial service and watched from under the shade of a nearby tree, Zam later recounted in a lengthy interview with Voice of America's Persian News Network. Mohammad's death was an assassination, Zam said, "one of those ideological murders, where a father, in order to stick to his beliefs, is content with the death of his son." Avoiding a trial would also have saved the Iranian intelligence service and his father from significant embarrassment.

Could Hajji Vali have murdered his own son? In our many conversations, Mohammad neither excoriated nor extolled his father. He understood Hajji Vali as a product of revolutionary circumstances. Men like him probably wanted Mohammad dead. I can't speak for Hajji Vali, and I couldn't locate him for comment. (Iran's mission to the United Nations declined to comment.)

Iranian intelligence surely found my conversations with Mohammad in his computer hardware. I think what sent the FBI to my door was U.S. surveillance of Mohammad's colleagues as they discussed whether to hack me.

In 2021, five years after Mohammad died, I wanted to check in with Zam to compare notes, to finally start putting together the puzzle after years of professional distraction. I discovered that a year earlier, Zam had been lured to Iraq with the promise of interviewing a prominent

When Mohammad was trying to reconnect with the Americans, was he actually working for Iran?

And by asking for my help, had Mohammad been using me to entrap the CIA?

cleric—and then apprehended, taken to Iran, and hanged.

YOU CAN FIND only traces of Mohammad today. Search his name online, and you'll see some court documents, a few blog posts about his death, and a short Wikipedia entry. Activist bloggers briefly celebrated Mohammad as a martyr, but he was not, in the end, "Iran's Snowden."

I won't pretend that I really knew Mohammad. Maybe I knew one version of him—the version in a selfie I obtained. With his thick black glasses and rumpled shirt, he looked like the intense nerd I'd always envisioned. I suspect he never told me about his prison time and torture because he considered them detours from his objectives.

Sometimes I think about how Mohammad first introduced himself to me: "I am 35 but very older." I understand now. He was traumatized. He was tired. And he was trapped in a fantasy of revenge. "But there is another thing named life," Mohammad told me, "and i strongly miss it." *A*

Shane Harris is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

THE MOST POWERFUL MAN IN SCIENCE

WHY IS ROBERT F.
KENNEDY JR. SO
CONVINCED HE'S RIGHT?

BY MICHAEL SCHERER

Photographs by ELINOR CARUCCI



R

Robert F. Kennedy Jr. somehow knew, even as a little boy, that fate can lead a person to terrible places. “I always had the feeling that we were all involved in some great crusade,” Kennedy once wrote, “that the world was a battleground for good and evil, and that our lives would be consumed in that conflict.” He was 9 years old when his uncle was assassinated and 14 when his father suffered the same fate. I happened to be sitting next to him this

fall when he learned that his friend Charlie Kirk had been shot. We were on an Air National Guard C-40C Clipper en route from Chicago to Washington, D.C., and one of Kennedy’s advisers, her eyes filling with tears, whispered the news in his ear. “Oh my God,” he said.

National Guard stewards handed out reheated chicken quesadillas, which Kennedy declined in favor of the quart of plain, organic, grass-fed yogurt his body man had secured for him. A few weeks earlier, a man who believed that he’d been poisoned by a COVID vaccine had fired nearly 200 bullets at the CDC’s campus in Atlanta, hitting six buildings and killing a police officer. Kennedy, who as secretary of Health and Human Services oversees the CDC, had just told me that his security team recently circulated a memo warning him of threats to his own life. “It said the resentments against me had elevated ‘above the threshold of lethality,’” he said. Kennedy greeted the threat assessment with remarkable equanimity. He put down his spoon in order to finish his yogurt in gulps directly from the container.

In an atmosphere of rising distrust of U.S. institutions, where even once-untouchable bastions of expertise such as the scientific establishment had been badly weakened by the coronavirus pandemic, Kennedy had emerged as a Rorschach test—truth-telling crusader, or brain-wormed loon?—for how Americans understood the populist furies riling the country. I’d told him that I wanted to understand his journey from liberal Democrat and environmental activist to MAGA insider and Kennedy-family heretic, on the theory that by examining his odyssey, I might better understand what separates us and help narrow the political divide. He was sympathetic but skeptical. “Yeah, if you pull that off . . .,” he said, trailing off with a laugh.

Kennedy himself has done much to fuel the rising distrust. He views some of the world’s most celebrated scientific and political leaders as charlatans. He calls some of the experts who work under him at HHS “biostitutes,” because he considers their integrity for sale to the industries they regulate. He rejects much of the

scientific consensus regarding vaccines, arguing that they have likely seeded the growing epidemic of chronic illnesses. During a Senate Finance Committee hearing just days before our flight from Chicago, Kennedy had called one U.S. senator a liar and another ridiculous. A bipartisan majority of the panel, including two Republican doctors, voiced concerns that vaccine policies he supported threatened the lives of American children. Kennedy argues that journalists like me are complicit, along with the public-health establishment, in hiding truth from the American people. The nation was tearing itself apart, and Kennedy had positioned himself at the seams.

“The whole medical establishment has huge stakes and equities that I’m now threatening,” he told me. “And I’m shocked President Trump lets me do it.”

A year earlier, Kirk, the founder of the conservative youth group Turning Point USA, had hosted an event with Kennedy the same day the candidate ended his quixotic presidential campaign and endorsed Donald Trump. JFK and RFK Sr. “are looking down right now and they are very, very proud,” Trump had said on the occasion. Now, as we flew over Ohio, no one knew if Kirk would live. At the front of the plane, aides to Attorney General Pam Bondi, who was also on board, were using the in-flight Wi-Fi to stream the gruesome videos of the shooting on social media. Kennedy’s adviser came back with a draft post for the secretary’s X account: “Praying for you, Charlie.”

“Say ‘We love you, Charlie.’” Kennedy instructed.

THREE DAYS LATER, Kennedy had just returned from a Saturday-morning 12-step meeting for addiction near his new house in Georgetown—a neighborhood that the extended Kennedy clan had long called home but that he now described as a “liberal enclave”—when he texted me saying that he wanted to continue our conversation about the country’s social breakdown.

A majority of the people in his recovery meeting, he said, “were probably horrified the first time I walked in, because, you know, they read *The New York Times* and they watch CNN, and so I’m kind of like a monster to them,” he said. “Over time, I became very welcome.”

This gave him hope that, outside the rooms of recovery, we could shrink our divisions. Parts of society, he said, are supposed to function independent of politics. Science is one of them. “The entire purpose of science is to search for existential truths,” he said. “It’s not subjective. It should be objective. I believe science is a place where you can find unity if you can get a conversation going.”

The problem is that the conversation had long since broken down. In 1900, the top three causes of death in the United States were pneumonia, tuberculosis, and diarrheal diseases, which collectively killed nearly 1 percent of the country every year. A staggering 30 percent of all deaths occurred in children younger than 5. By the end of the century, vaccinations, antibiotics, clean water, improved sewage treatment, and pest control had drastically reduced the lethality of infectious diseases. Today, young children account for less than 1 percent of U.S. deaths. Life expectancy has been extended by nearly 30

years. This is a monumental accomplishment, attributable to the efforts of scientists and lawmakers who tested hypotheses, built consensus to pass policies, and then corrected that consensus when new evidence arose.

But since about 2010, the long, steady increase in life expectancy has flatlined. Chronic illnesses such as heart disease, cancer, stroke, and lung disease now top our mortality tables—affecting some 130 million Americans and accounting for 90 percent of our \$4.9 trillion annual health-care expenditure. We are the world's least healthy high-income nation, bombarded with prescription-drug ads and buffeted by a wellness industry of alternative fixes. A September poll by Navigator, a Democratic public-opinion firm, found that seven in 10 Americans are convinced that the health system “is designed so drug and insurance companies make more money when Americans are sick.”

Kennedy aims to channel the frustrations of that majority to remake public health. He arrived at this goal by way of his decades as a trial lawyer focused on contamination of the nation's water by polluting corporations. In the latter part of his career, he has come to perceive a comparable contamination of American health by pharmaceutical and food companies. A central premise of Kennedy's leadership at HHS is that modern science is infected with bias that costs lives—that the regulatory agencies have been captured by industry, that medical journals are corrupted by the need to turn a profit, that even respected organizations such as the American Academy of Pediatrics operate with a myopic groupthink that hurts kids.

For years, Kennedy was a gadfly outsider. The scientific establishment ignored him. Even now that he sits atop America's health bureaucracy, Kennedy told me, public-health authorities—whose convictions, he said, are more akin to religion than science—will not engage with him. He blamed his opponents for dodging his arguments on vaccines. “Why for 15 years have they refused to have a conversation with me? I've been asking for 15 years for somebody to come up and debate me on this,” he told me. “Their reaction to that is ‘Oh, don't debate him. He's too crazy. You don't want to give him a platform.’”

In 2017, Kennedy thought he'd finally gotten the audience that would allow him to make his case about vaccines. At Trump's insistence, Kennedy and some allies, including Aaron Siri, a vaccine-safety litigator, came to the National Institutes of Health with a stack of 84 studies that they said supported their claims about the unrecognized dangers of vaccines.

“We tried to engage him. We were trying to debate him,” Joshua Gordon, the former director of the National Institute of Mental Health, told me. He and his colleagues attended the meeting to argue that existing studies demonstrated no connection between vaccines and conditions such as autism, and to explain why Kennedy's papers “were suspect.” But, Gordon said, “Kennedy and Siri refused to engage.”

Kennedy and Siri insist that it was the doctors and scientists who refused to engage, and Siri has published emails showing that Gordon eventually ended the conversation by referring them to the CDC. The meeting solidified Kennedy's conviction

that he was dealing with a cult unwilling to look at evidence that challenged its worldview.

Today, a similar pattern is playing out between Kennedy and his own staff. In late August, Kennedy asked that Trump fire Kennedy's handpicked CDC director, just four weeks after she'd been confirmed by the Senate, because Kennedy was convinced that she was aligning herself with her agency's scientific staff and against him. He then replaced the members of the CDC's vaccine advisory committee because he'd concluded that their COVID-era decision making had been unscientific and industry-influenced. His team uses social media to attack science reporters by name.

Even some members of Kennedy's newly adopted party are alarmed. Last February, Senator Bill Cassidy of Louisiana, a gastroenterologist and the Republican chair of the Senate Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions Committee, cast the deciding vote to confirm Kennedy as HHS secretary. A liver specialist, Cassidy has treated patients with cirrhosis caused by having been born with hepatitis B, a condition that can be avoided with newborn vaccination. Though Cassidy has thus far declined to renounce his endorsement of Kennedy, he rejects the secretary's suggestion that the hepatitis vaccine might be dangerous when given to newborns.

“I've invited Bill Cassidy and others to sit down with me and go through the studies and let's figure out which ones are right,” Kennedy told me. “That has to happen through real debate and conversation, and there's no real place to have that in the current political milieu.”

When I conveyed Kennedy's frustrations to Cassidy, the senator said that he and the HHS secretary regularly share scientific articles and papers with each other. “I find that he often will send me the same article more than once,” Cassidy told me. Yet whenever Cassidy points out “statistical flaws” in the article, he said, Kennedy says he considers those “immaterial.”

I had been having a similar experience. As I reported this article, Kennedy referred me to many studies meant to convince me there are not two valid sides to this debate, that his is the only valid one. I'm not a scientist. I've admittedly been inconsistent in getting my yearly COVID and flu boosters, confused about their benefits. Now the most powerful public-health official in the U.S. was asking me, a political reporter, to referee a medical debate with life-and-death stakes.

I called Paul Offit, a pediatrician and the director of the Vaccine Education Center at the Children's Hospital of Philadelphia, and one of the most outspoken critics of Kennedy's vaccine views. Offit helped invent a rotavirus vaccine that has mitigated a major cause of early-childhood hospitalization around the world. Kennedy routinely attacks him as a paragon of financial conflict because the owners of the vaccine patent, including his hospital, gave him some of the proceeds from its sale. The accusation relies entirely on circumstantial evidence: Offit's early rotavirus research was funded by the National Institutes of Health, not private industry; he advocates for vaccination and sells books about the benefits of vaccines, but nothing suggests that he has ever done anything untoward in pursuit of profit. Like many of the people I spoke with for this article, Offit has

faced death threats from radicals who believe his vaccine advocacy is deadly. Some have targeted his children.

Offit told me that Kennedy is a “liar” and a “terrible human being.” I asked him to explain. “It doesn’t matter what I say,” Offit said. “He thinks the medical journals are in the pocket of the industry, he thinks that the government is in the pocket of the industry, he thinks I’m in the pocket of industry, and he’s wrong.” Offit continued: “If he has data showing he’s right, then fucking publish it. He can’t, because he doesn’t have those data.”

I asked Offit if he saw a way to reverse the public’s rising distrust in science. “I don’t think there is any way to regain that trust other than have the viruses do the education, and the bacteria do the education, and then people will realize they paid way too high a cost,” he said.

From 2011 to 2024, the percentage of kindergarten students whose families asked for nonmedical exemptions to vaccine mandates doubled, to more than 3 percent, according to the CDC. Florida just announced an end to school vaccine mandates, and Idaho passed a law banning them. Cassidy’s office has been monitoring rising rates of pertussis, a bacterial infection also known as whooping cough; symptomatic infection is avoidable with a vaccine. Cassidy’s working hypothesis is that declining vaccination rates in red states will show up in the data. Kennedy counters that existing data are not specific enough to show whether the new infections are among the unvaccinated.

I FIRST INTERVIEWED KENNEDY for this story in June, in his office on the sixth floor of HHS headquarters, a brutalist gray block of concrete that resembles a giant air-conditioning unit. Kennedy’s staff jokes that the building feels like a prison; the secretary pointed out the great view he would have of the U.S. Capitol’s dome, if not for the building’s deep-set windows.

Kennedy is 71, but with the help of weight lifting, artificial tanning, a careful diet, and testosterone-replacement therapy, he looks more like a comic-book character than a senior citizen, his bronzed face all chiseled angles, his eyes sky blue. He adheres to a strict uniform at work—dark, embroidered skinny ties like his father sometimes wore, with suit jackets that bulge over his bodybuilder’s chest and biceps. He regularly pulls Zyn nicotine pouches from his shirt pocket or desk drawers to tuck between his lower lip and gum. When I asked him to square his nicotine habit and the time he spends tanning with the federal health advisories against both, he shifted in his chair. “I’m not telling people that they should do anything that I do,” he said. “I just say ‘Get in shape.’”

Kennedy told me his staff believed that speaking with me was a mistake. For the first half century of his life, national magazines hailed him as a public servant, a potential heir to the Kennedy kingdom—even, as *Time* magazine put it in 1999, a “Hero for the Planet.” “The Kennedy Who Matters,” *New York* magazine declared in 1995, saluting RFK Jr.’s environmental advocacy. In 2006, *Vanity Fair* posed him on the cover of its “green issue” with George Clooney and Julia Roberts.

But the favorable coverage dried up about 20 years ago, when he began arguing that mercury additives in vaccines were likely causing an epidemic of autism. This claim was contradicted even

at the time by epidemiological studies by the CDC and others. Editors who did not want to discourage lifesaving vaccination stopped running flattering articles and started running critical ones. “All-out hit pieces,” he told me, “every one of them—like, ugly, hateful stuff.” For 20 years now, he said, only “bad articles” have been written about him.

Yet in the aftermath of COVID, his popularity has surged. Like Trump, Kennedy has drafted on the currents of populist backlash against expert authority. “When I’m on the street, I get stopped three times a block by people saying that they love me,” he said. Kennedy is among the most popular members of Trump’s Cabinet, according to an August Gallup survey: 42 percent of the country holds a favorable view of him, on par with the president himself. The public attacks on Kennedy’s character and integrity bother him, naturally, but he wanted me to know that I was not a threat. “If he screws us on this,” he recounted telling his staff, “it’s just another shitty article in a liberal paper, which doesn’t really hurt me.”

He believed that I’d screwed him before, anyway. I’d first met him in the spring of 2023, when he was challenging President Joe Biden for the Democratic Party’s nomination. The *Washington Post* story I wrote focused on his argument that the powerful were lying to the American people—about vaccines, environmental threats, the assassinations of his father and uncle, and much else. He hated the story largely because I’d used the word *conspiratorial* in the headline, which he argued was an elitist epithet for *tinfoil hat*. I placed him in the tradition of what the political scientist Richard Hofstadter described as America’s paranoid style, while acknowledging that secret conspiracies of the powerful—tobacco companies, the intelligence community—sometimes do exist.

He responded by sending me an email nearly twice the length of my original article, with 78 footnotes. (At the time, he was suing the *Post* for its role in a consortium designed to combat misinformation online.) “Your reporting on me reflects, exquisitely, the overt aspirations by your employer and its co-conspirators to crush nonconformist viewpoints in order to secure their own economic self-interests,” he wrote. Weeks later, on a podcast, he accused me of being “part of a conspiracy, a true conspiracy.”



I had never received an email like that from a politician. If I was hopelessly corrupt, why spend hours writing a response? It struck me that Kennedy believed himself to be on a ferocious quest. “There is nothing that is a show about what you are seeing,” Mike Papantonio, a former legal partner of Kennedy’s who co-hosted a program with him on the liberal radio network Air America in the mid-aughts, told me. “That is real rage.”

Kennedy and I stayed in touch. In October 2023, getting little traction from Democratic-primary voters, he relaunched his presidential campaign as an independent. Despite not having a clear path to even a single electoral vote, he didn’t stop until August 2024, when he endorsed Trump, a man he had weeks earlier publicly described as appealing to “some of the darkest impulses in the national psyche.”

As we talked more recently in his wood-paneled HHS office, he leaned back in his chair behind an oversize desk, with one of his five book-length attacks on the federal medical establishment, *The Real Anthony Fauci: Bill Gates, Big Pharma, and the Global War on Democracy and Public Health*, displayed nearby. From that seat, he oversees one out of every four dollars in the federal budget and regulates about 17 percent of the nation’s economy. How, I asked him, did he explain going from scorned activist to the boss of the public-health apparatus?

“I would say in one word: *providential*,” Kennedy said.

“IF HE HAS DATA SHOWING HE’S RIGHT, THEN FUCKING PUBLISH IT,” PAUL OFFIT, THE DIRECTOR OF THE VACCINE EDUCATION CENTER AT THE CHILDREN’S HOSPITAL OF PHILADELPHIA, SAYS. “HE CAN’T, BECAUSE HE DOESN’T HAVE THOSE DATA.”

Left: Robert F. Kennedy, campaigning for president in 1968, three months before he was assassinated

IF I WERE to do this story right, Kennedy told me, I needed to talk with his top deputies: Jay Bhattacharya, the director of the NIH; Marty Makary, the commissioner of the FDA; and Mehmet Oz, the cardiothoracic surgeon turned TV doctor known for having hyped dubious “miracle” cures, who is now running the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services. All three of these physicians, like Kennedy, say that they were transformed by the pandemic, which they thought public-health authorities had mishandled. They had dissented from government edicts regarding vaccine mandates and masking. Although they do not embrace all of Kennedy’s views on vaccines, his deputies share his big-picture view that America’s public-health system is broken.

Early in the pandemic, Bhattacharya, a Stanford University physician and health economist, co-wrote the 2020 “Great Barington Declaration,” a document that argued against universal COVID lockdowns in favor of allowing healthy people to gather while isolating only those groups at greatest risk of severe illness or death, such as the elderly and the infirm. For this, Bhattacharya was ostracized by colleagues at Stanford and the broader scientific community: An email that later became public shows Francis Collins, then the NIH director, telling colleagues that they needed a “quick and devastating published take down” of the declaration. (Tens of thousands of Americans a month were dying from COVID at that time; overstrained hospitals were at risk of collapse.) Death threats—a recurring feature of public-health work these days—followed for Bhattacharya, who now compares the COVID years to pre-Enlightenment Europe, when Galileo Galilei was imprisoned by Catholic leaders for arguing that the Earth orbited the sun.

“What you had is a relatively small number of scientists who could decide what is true or false for all of science and all of society,” Bhattacharya told me. Today, even some of those who led the public-health response during those years admit that COVID-vaccine mandates may have been counterproductive, that social distancing lasted too long, and that masking may not have done much to limit transmission—though it is also true that we cannot know now how much higher the death rate would have been *without* those measures in place.

The COVID vaccines led to a substantial reduction in hospitalization and death from the disease, according to peer-reviewed studies. But Kennedy likes to emphasize that, as the virus evolved, the vaccines failed to prevent infection, as scientific authorities had initially suggested they would. Kennedy also dismisses the mathematical modeling of the lives saved, and says CDC estimates of the COVID death toll were inflated by “data chaos” in the government. What no one doubts is that the severity of the pandemic—more than 95,000 Americans were reported dead in one month at its height—has transformed the nation’s relationship with medical authority. From 2020 to 2022, public confidence in the CDC dropped from 82 to 56 percent, according to a study by researchers at the University of Texas Southwestern Medical Center. The country has still not recovered.

Kennedy’s team blames its Biden-era government predecessors. When I met with Makary, who worked as a pancreatic surgeon before being named FDA commissioner, he said that, in times

of uncertainty, a dangerous and self-defeating “groupthink” can take over. Kennedy and his allies point to how public-health authorities urged social-media platforms to curb the posting of COVID misinformation, stifling debate. Kennedy himself got kicked off Instagram. In one social-media post, he called the death of the baseball great Hank Aaron at age 86 “part of a wave of suspicious deaths among elderly closely following” COVID-vaccine shots. Critics accused Kennedy of speculating baselessly about Aaron’s cause of death, and quoted the medical examiner’s office saying Aaron had died of natural causes. Kennedy, in turn, accused his critics of ruling out a vaccine connection without a proper autopsy, and demanded that one be done.

The COVID experience bonded Kennedy, Makary, Bhattacharya, and Oz in a fellowship of the ostracized. “We became renegades, personae non gratae, because we asked questions which you would think, certainly within academic medicine, you should be able to ask,” Oz told me in his office, where he keeps a taxidermic honey badger to symbolize fearlessness and aggression.

After Trump’s reelection, Kennedy’s HHS-leadership-team-in-waiting gathered at Oz’s 10-bedroom, 18,559-square-foot Palm Beach house, not far from Trump’s Mar-a-Lago estate. The house was built by the same architect who built the mansion down the beach where Kennedy had spent vacations during his childhood. “It has the same smell to it,” he said. In the mornings, Kennedy would call on anyone who was around to go swimming in the ocean or throw a football with him, before his team settled down to plan the future of U.S. medicine. Kennedy’s friend Russell Brand—a comedian, an actor, and a fellow recovering addict who has pleaded not guilty to rape and sexual-assault charges in England—would sometimes join them. Kennedy says that those months in Palm Beach validated his decision to walk further away from the Democratic Party and most of his own family, who remained prominent Trump opponents. The Republicans hanging around Oz’s house, Kennedy told me, “were all very idealistic people, which was not my view of the Republican Party growing up. To me the most breathtaking and refreshing part of being down there is that people were not sitting in rooms, as the Democrats imagine, thinking, *How do we cut taxes for rich people and screw the poor?* They were saying, ‘How do you make every American better?’”

At one point, leaders of Stanford visited, only to be grilled by Kennedy and Oz about why the university had opened an investigation into Bhattacharya’s professional conduct during the pandemic. The outcasts had become the authorities.

KENNEDY NOW COMPARES his relationship with the president to “when you’re dating somebody that you keep liking more and more.” They began meeting after the failed assassination attempt on Trump in July 2024. Kennedy came to believe that his previous impressions of Trump—that he was a “bombastic narcissist” who lacked curiosity and didn’t read books—had been wrong. “One day he sat on the plane with me. We were talking about Syria, and he drew a map of the Mideast for me. And it was a perfect map,” Kennedy told me. “Then he drew in the troop strength of each country, and also the troop strength on various borders.”

Trump would recite sports trivia to Kennedy, and recount the net worth of major Wall Street financiers.

“I had to start seeing Trump as a populist who is standing up to really entrenched power and the deep state and that merger of state and corporate power,” Kennedy told me. He acknowledges that this makes Trump a strange “paradox”—“because he’s the most business-friendly guy at least since George W. Bush.”

That’s saying something coming from Kennedy, who in the early 2000s compared Bush’s pro-corporate environmental policies to the work of European fascists. I asked how he reconciled his criticism of Bush with working in the Cabinet of a president who appointed an oil executive, Chris Wright—who recently called Al Gore’s climate-change warnings “nonsense”—as energy secretary. “Chris Wright has a diverse worldview,” Kennedy told me.

For decades, RFK Jr. continued to call himself an “FDR/Kennedy liberal.” The embrace of MAGA has lost Kennedy friends and strained his family. At a rally against vaccine mandates in 2022, Kennedy described the U.S. COVID response as totalitarian, and warned that new technologies would give the government greater power to control Americans than the Nazis had over Anne Frank in Europe. In response, his sister Kerry Kennedy posted on X, “Bobby’s lies and fear-mongering yesterday were both sickening and destructive.” When RFK Jr.’s own wife, Cheryl Hines, famous for playing Larry David’s wife on the HBO show *Curb Your Enthusiasm*, publicly criticized him for those remarks, he apologized. Kennedy and Sheldon Whitehouse, a Democratic senator from Rhode Island, were once such close friends that they were in each other’s weddings. Now, when Whitehouse questions Kennedy at public hearings, his voice drips with disdain. “You have my cell-phone,” Kennedy told his former friend during their last Finance Committee confrontation, in September. “I’ve never heard from you in seven months. Call me up. I’d love to meet with you.” (Kennedy says Whitehouse replied to his offer in late October and said he would meet, after Whitehouse’s Senate office had declined a request for comment from *The Atlantic*.)

“To stay on course despite that jeering really tells you a lot about his messianic self-regard,” the New York Democratic politician Mark Green, another former friend of Kennedy’s, told me recently. “He is sadly off his rocker to argue that Biden was more anti-speech and fascist than Donald Trump.”

OVER TIME, Kennedy and his team united around an organizing theory of their department. “It’s a \$1.73 trillion bundle of perverse incentives,” he told me. “The doctors, the hospitals, the insurance companies, the other providers, the pharmaceutical companies are all incentivized to make money by keeping people sick.” Fixing this would require radical measures.

The ensuing year has been a whirlwind of controversy, destruction, and new initiatives. Kennedy and the Trump White House pushed out, through firings and induced retirements, about one in four HHS employees, including much of the senior career staff and thousands of workers at the CDC, which Kennedy described to me as a “snake pit.” Early on, working with Elon Musk’s team at the Department of Government Efficiency, Kennedy canceled hundreds of millions of dollars in research

grants, and defended a White House budget proposal that cut 40 percent of the NIH's funding, even while saying that he would accept more money if Congress decided differently. "I talked to Elon a lot about this," Kennedy told me. "You have to do something disruptive at the beginning." If you don't, "you lose momentum."

On May 27, he shook scientists at the CDC by announcing that his department would no longer recommend COVID boosters for healthy children or pregnant women, on the grounds that clinical trials had not sufficiently demonstrated safety and efficacy for those populations. The career staff was outraged; Kennedy presented no new data on potential harm that would have compelled rescinding the existing recommendation, and it is well established that COVID infection increases the danger to both mother and fetus. "I knew that those decisions were going to harm people," Lakshmi Panagiotakopoulos, a top adviser on COVID vaccines for the CDC, who resigned in response to Kennedy's new policy, told me. "From my perspective as a scientist and someone who has done this her entire career, he has a lot of blood on his hands."

Days later, Kennedy removed the 17 members of the CDC committee responsible for recommending vaccination schedules and replaced them with a smaller group that promptly ordered the removal of a mercury preservative, thimerosal, from flu vaccines, even though the CDC continues to describe thimerosal as "very safe." Kennedy's new committee put up barriers against a single shot to vaccinate children for measles, mumps, rubella, and varicella, citing past studies by Merck and the CDC that found a higher incidence of febrile seizures following the combined vaccine. Kennedy also canceled \$500 million in federal grants for mRNA-vaccine research, citing his conclusions, disputed by medical associations, that the technology performs poorly against fast-mutating respiratory viruses.

In other areas, he's pushed for changes that health activists and wellness influencers on the left, as well as many in the scientific mainstream, have long sought. He launched initiatives to review baby-formula ingredients, issue new guidelines for fluoride use, limit student cellphone use, stop the sale of illegal flavored vapes, and remove restrictions on whole-milk sales at schools, and he persuaded governors in 12 states to ban the use of food stamps to buy sugary sodas. He announced plans to explore limits on direct pharmaceutical advertising and the marketing of unhealthy food to children, increase nutrition education for doctors, reduce prices on some drugs, add front-of-package labeling on ultra-processed foods, and require more testing of food additives. Under pressure from Kennedy's HHS, major food producers announced that they would remove certain petroleum-based food dyes from cereals and candy.

Kennedy's deputies describe him as endlessly curious about new science, and willing to listen to dissenting views. Bhattacharya told me that, during the 2025 measles outbreak in Texas, the worst in decades in the U.S., he privately advised Kennedy to endorse the measles vaccine as the most effective way to prevent the disease. "When you give him the evidence, he changes his mind along the lines of what the evidence says," Bhattacharya said. Kennedy did

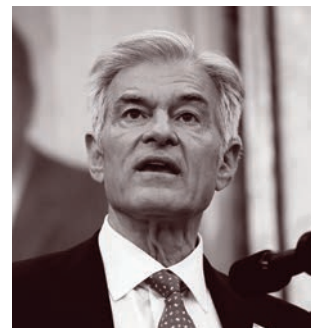
go on to call the measles vaccine effective—while also emphasizing that parents should make their own decisions and promoting disputed treatments such as cod-liver oil for measles symptoms.

The secretary also consumes scientific studies by the bushel. In August, Andrea Baccarelli, the dean of the Harvard T. H. Chan School of Public Health, published a review of the existing science suggesting a possible connection between taking Tylenol during pregnancy and the development of autism or attention deficit disorder in children. Kennedy told me he spent a weekend reading 70 studies related to this. He spoke with Baccarelli, started texting directly with another researcher on the topic, and asked the CEO of Kenvue, the company that now owns the Tylenol brand, to bring scientists to HHS to brief him.

Kennedy arrived at a rather nuanced set of conclusions—more nuanced than what his boss would subsequently express. High fevers in pregnant women are known to cause bad outcomes in newborns. So any public-health advice recommending against Tylenol, which reduces fevers, would have to be carefully weighed, he told me. But when he briefed Trump on his findings, Kennedy said, the president's response was to suggest immediately posting a Tylenol warning on social media.

"You can't do that," Kennedy said he told the president. "There's nuance to it, and you can't scare people away from Tylenol, and you're going to get a huge amount of pushback from powerful pharmaceutical companies." Trump's reply: "I don't give a shit about that." The FDA-advisory note that Marty Makary released to accompany the announcement weeks later asked doctors to exercise caution in using the medication for low-grade fevers but said that there was as yet no proof of a causal link between Tylenol and developmental disorders.

Trump, however, has less patience for nuance. "Don't take Tylenol. Don't take it," the president said at a press conference on September 22. "Fight like hell not to take it." The medical community responded with



Kennedy's deputies (top to bottom): Jay Bhattacharya, the NIH director; Marty Makary, the FDA commissioner; and Mehmet Oz, who oversees Medicare and Medicaid



Kennedy and President Donald Trump in the Roosevelt Room of the White House on September 22, 2025, when the president urged pregnant women not to take Tylenol, enraging the medical community

outrage. The American Academy of Pediatrics, the American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists, and other prominent health organizations put out statements advising doctors and patients to disregard Trump's recommendation.

Through all this, Kennedy has praised the president's fearlessness and compassion. A few months earlier, at a White House event, RFK Jr. compared Trump to President Kennedy, who had worked with the biologist Rachel Carson in the early 1960s to reduce the use of pesticides. "My uncle tried to do this, but he was killed and it never got done," Kennedy said, sitting alongside Trump. "And ever since then, we've been waiting for a president who would stand up and speak on behalf of the health of the American people."

IN A FAMILY steeped in its own mythology, RFK Jr. was always particularly susceptible to the pathos and grandeur of the Camelot mystique. His father encouraged him to read heroic poems like Alfred, Lord Tennyson's "Ulysses," and as a child Bobby Jr. memorized Rudyard Kipling's "If—" and "Gunga Din."

The legend of King Arthur resonated with a boy who was more interested in catching salamanders and snakes in the forest than in schoolwork. T. H. White's novel *The Once and Future King*, which tells the story of young Arthur's tutelage under Merlyn, was a particular favorite. "That was how I got interested in falconry," Kennedy told me. When he was 11, his father gave him his first red-tailed hawk. Kennedy named the bird Morgan le Fay, after Arthur's sorcerer half sister.

But when his father was murdered, Ethel Kennedy, Bobby Jr.'s mother, was left to care for 11 children in a world churning with youthful rebellion. One day in the summer of 1969, Kennedy remembers, he attended a farewell party on Cape Cod for a young soldier heading off to Vietnam. He said LSD had arrived from California that summer, and while he was hitchhiking home that night, someone offered him a dose. His favorite comic book at the time, *Turok, Son of Stone*, followed the exploits of Native Americans who lived among prehistoric animals. In one of the comic's

storylines, the Native Americans consume a hallucinogenic fruit. "Will I see dinosaurs?" Kennedy told me he asked the person offering him the LSD. "I had a deep interest in paleontology," he explained to me. That was perhaps the first time this particular reason has ever been given for deciding to take psychedelics.

A picture of his dead father and uncle behind the counter of a local diner as the drug wore off spoiled his trip. At which point another group of kids offered him a line of

crystal meth. The initial rush was strong enough to set him on a new life path. Within months, he was traveling to New York City to buy \$2 heroin on 72nd Street. "I had been administering drugs and giving shots to animals since I was a kid. And so it wasn't a hard jump for me," he said, about using needles to inject himself with drugs. "There were other kids in my town who were shooting speed." He was 15.

In January 2025, after Trump announced that he would be nominating Kennedy as HHS secretary, his cousin Caroline Kennedy, JFK's daughter, wrote a public letter opposing his confirmation, in part because of what she'd witnessed during his years as a young drug user; she blamed him for leading others in the family "down the path of addiction." She described young Bobby as a "predator" like the raptors he'd raised, saying he had grown "addicted to attention and power." "His basement, his garage, and his dorm room were the centers of the action where drugs were available, and he enjoyed showing off how he put baby chickens and mice in the blender to feed his hawks," she wrote. "It was often a perverse scene of despair and violence."

When I read Kennedy those words, he barely reacted. "I would not contest it that much," he said. "Addiction is kind of narcissistic."

By the time he was accepted into Harvard (his father, his uncles, and his grandfather had all gone there), he had been pushed out of multiple boarding schools, been arrested for marijuana possession, and become estranged from his mother. When he was still a teenager, he hopped trains to Haight-Ashbury, in San Francisco, to hang with the hippies, and worked in a Colorado lumber camp. His heroin addiction would last 14 years, continuing during his time as a law student at the University of Virginia, as well as through his first marriage, to Emily Black, a fellow UVA law student, whom he married in 1982. In September 1983, he overdosed on a flight to South Dakota. He was charged with heroin possession, for which he was sentenced to two years' probation, and spent the next five months in a rehab facility in New Jersey. Shortly after he left treatment, his brother David Kennedy, younger by about a year, died of a drug overdose

in a Palm Beach hotel room while other family members were gathered at the Kennedy estate nearby.

Although Kennedy says he has not taken heroin since he got clean, he still considers his brain to be a sort of “formulation pharmacy,” able to transform anything—rock climbing, falconry, sex—into a drug. In 2024, *New York* magazine parted ways with its reporter Olivia Nuzzi after learning of what it deemed was an inappropriate personal relationship with Kennedy, whom she’d profiled the previous year. A former babysitter for Kennedy’s children told *Vanity Fair* that he had groped her when she was 23 and he was 45. Kennedy apologized to the babysitter in a text message after the article’s publication, though he said he did not remember the incidents she described. “I am not a church boy,” he said publicly. “I have so many skeletons in my closet that if they could all vote, I could run for king of the world.”

After his time in rehab in the early 1980s, Kennedy says he remade himself through the routines and principles of Alcoholics Anonymous—a combination of spiritual devotion, radical transparency, and a focus on service. As a presidential candidate, he told his security detail that he had to attend a 12-step meeting every day, no matter where he traveled. He has continued that practice since moving to Washington from Los Angeles. I asked him how much being an addict in recovery still affects him. “I think it’s shaped everything,” he said. Even as HHS secretary, he sponsors others in recovery. “I take calls all the time.”

In his own view, recovery from heroin addiction has returned him from damnation to walk again among the living. “Having kind of lived through hell,” he told me, paraphrasing something he said he’d read while he was still using, gives you a different perspective on life, and the opportunity for “a kind of redemption.” To rebuild his self-esteem, he worked to replace the secret shame of his addiction with a life dedicated to a purpose bigger than himself. In this way, his private recovery, anchored in his Catholic faith, fused with his public crusade against what he believes are grave threats to American health. But this is also, perhaps, what gives his jeremiads about vaccines and other matters such fervor. “You’ve got to, you know, completely commit yourself to a way of life,” he said, talking about the 12-step process. “It’s Joseph Campbell’s hero’s journey that we are all on.”

After entering recovery, he built up Riverkeeper, a nonprofit dedicated to protecting the Hudson River and other New York watersheds; founded an environmental-law practice; divorced Black; got married a second time, to Mary Richardson, an architect; and began a lifelong battle against chemical contamination of human health. In 2010, after 16 years of marriage, he filed for divorce from Richardson; she accused him of extensive infidelity, and he described her as abusive. Before the acrimonious proceedings concluded, Richardson committed suicide. In 2014, Kennedy married Hines. He has six children, two with Black and four with Richardson.

In his work as a litigator, he thrived: He won judgments against General Electric for contaminating the Hudson River; DuPont for contamination at a zinc-smelting plant in West Virginia; and Monsanto for a type of cancer allegedly caused by glyphosate, then the key ingredient of one of the world’s most

popular herbicides, sold under the brand name Roundup. He argued many cases himself.

John Morgan, one of the nation’s most successful trial lawyers, worked with Kennedy on lawsuits after a natural-gas leak in Southern California in 2015 and the spectacular 2023 train derailment in East Palestine, Ohio. Morgan says there are three types of lawyers: finders, who get the plaintiffs; grinders, who try the cases; and minders, who keep it all on track. Kennedy was one of the best finders he’d ever met. “People follow him,” Morgan told me.

Although Kennedy has been litigating against environmental polluters for more than four decades, his focus on vaccines began only after mothers with autistic children started showing up at his talks—and after one of them persuaded him to read studies suggesting a link between vaccines and autism. The fact that vaccines can harm people is not contested: The existence of the National Vaccine Injury Compensation Program is a testament to the American public-health establishment’s acknowledgment of that. The frequency and nature of that harm, however, is highly contested. From 2006 to 2022, about 5 billion vaccine doses were distributed in the U.S. The NVICP paid about one settlement for every 1 million doses. Kennedy believes that the real rate of injury could be 100 times higher than what is reported. As in his crusade against corporate polluters, he brings a litigator’s tools to the vaccine fight—humanizing the victims, demonizing his opponents, and overwhelming his audiences with his research and with the nuclear force of his indignation.

SCIENCE, UNLIKE FAIRY TALES and courtroom dramas, does not always offer a clear narrative. Initial results may fail to replicate. Real findings can get drowned out by statistical noise. Catastrophic side effects may take time to emerge. In the evolving search for truth, the public can find itself whipsawed: Margarine was a healthy butter alternative—until studies found it to be a source of the artificial trans fats that cause 50,000 premature deaths a year. The Merck drug Vioxx was a miracle pain reliever—until researchers estimated that it was associated with as many as 140,000 excess cases of heart disease. The food pyramid of the 1990s, which emphasized processed carbohydrates over fiber and protein, now looks like a sick joke given what research has shown about the roots of our current obesity epidemic.

Kennedy thinks more people should follow his lead by consuming science directly. “‘Trusting the experts’ is not a feature of science,” he likes to say. “It’s not a feature of democracy. It’s a feature of totalitarianism and religion.” But having everyone “do their own research,” as Kennedy recommends, was untenable even before the advent of technologies like nanoscience and genomic editing. When I suggested to Kennedy that he was now presuming to play the role of health expert himself, he rejected that. “I don’t tell people to trust me. I tell people, ‘Don’t trust me.’”

Throughout our conversations, we often found ourselves jousting about the details of one scientific debate or another. For instance, I reminded Kennedy that back in 2005, he had suggested that the removal of thimerosal from most vaccines would result in a decline in autism diagnoses—but that since then,

thimerosal *had* been removed from most vaccines, yet autism diagnoses continued to rise. He in turn argued that this could be explained by the addition of aluminum to vaccines during that same period, and by the fact that some flu vaccines still contained thimerosal. But most pregnant women and young children no longer receive flu vaccines with the preservative—and that’s been true since before Kennedy banned thimerosal from flu vaccines.

Another time, he pointed out that the U.S., a heavily COVID-vaccinated country, represents only 4.2 percent of the global population but accounts for 19 percent of the deaths from COVID. I countered that those differences are likely explained by other factors, including America’s more comprehensive reporting, higher chronic-disease rates, older population, and colder climate. He conceded all of that, but said he was making a narrower point, which was that the notion “that the only thing that saved us was the vaccine is unconvincing.”

He sent me a placebo-controlled COVID-vaccine study of pregnant women, conducted by Pfizer, which showed more congenital anomalies in babies born to the vaccinated group than the unvaccinated group. I countered that Pfizer had found the difference statistically insignificant. The reason the difference didn’t reach statistical significance, he pushed back, was that the study was not large enough and “Pfizer cut it off as soon as they saw a bad result.” If true, this suggested malicious intent on the part of the company. “Why aren’t you asking Pfizer about this?” he asked. “You should be burning up their phone line.”

So I called Pfizer, which granted me an interview with a scientist who was part of the company’s COVID-vaccine program, but requested that I not use the scientist’s name, to protect their privacy. This researcher told me that the study had been stopped not because of a bad result but because the data revealed no safety concerns with the vaccine—which meant that keeping the control group from getting it would have been unethical, given the serious risks stemming from COVID infection during pregnancy.

The researcher also explained that further investigation had determined that, of all the congenital anomalies initially reported, only one had originated after the vaccine administration, at 24 weeks’ gestation. “You cannot make a vaccine responsible for something that happened before you gave the vaccine,” the researcher told me.

When presented with data that contradict his arguments, Kennedy regularly claims bad faith on the part of his adversaries—that they’re motivated by profit or professional advancement. His experience as a litigator may have made this reflexive. As John Morgan, his litigation partner, told me, it’s hard to sue polluters and cigarette companies and not come away convinced that the defendants are “in the business of premeditated murder.” Kennedy has applied the same lens to the medical establishment, casting it as powered by the big pharmaceutical companies and their government protectors—despite the fact that most pediatricians and virologists and epidemiologists have devoted their lives to helping children and reducing suffering.

And if Kennedy is so concerned about conflicts of interest, what of his overhauled CDC vaccine panel? Some of the experts

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he appointed had previously been paid to serve as witnesses for plaintiffs in vaccine-safety lawsuits. Kennedy himself, in addition to the millions he made as a trial lawyer, took a large salary from Children’s Health Defense—\$510,515 in 2022—a nonprofit he led from 2016 to 2023 that fundraises to fight for tighter vaccine regulation. His entire political project—his campaign, his hiring by Trump, his role at HHS—is entwined with his ability to prove that scientists were deceiving the public about vaccines. He would lose a lot if he changed his mind.

During his presidential campaign, Kennedy would repeatedly say that in a study of the COVID vaccine, Pfizer had found that “the people who got the vaccine had a 23 percent higher death rate from all causes at the end of that study”; he still says this today. He bases this on his interpretation of an early trial of the Pfizer COVID vaccine, and it sounds terrifying—a smoking gun for those looking for a reason to doubt official health advice. The main takeaway from that 2020 trial was that the rate of infection was significantly lower in the vaccinated group than in the placebo group (eight infections versus 162). The study followed about 44,000 people, who were randomly divided into two blinded groups, one that got the COVID vaccine and one that got a placebo shot. Over the course of six months, 21 people in the vaccine group and 17 in the placebo group died. (Scientists use these numbers to derive what they call “all-cause mortality rates.”) These are the numbers Kennedy uses to claim that a study found that your risk of death increases by 23 percent if you take the vaccine.



Top: RFK Jr. at a celebrity tennis tournament in 1972, the summer before starting college. Bottom: Kennedy and his sister Kerry Kennedy, one of the family members who recently called for him to resign from government, in 1974.

But the scientists I spoke with about Kennedy's assertion explained that the study was not large enough and did not last long enough to reveal any increased mortality risk. In addition, an FDA review said none of the deaths in the study was vaccine-related. (Kennedy says this review was subjective.) Kennedy's numbers were also misleading. During the blinded portion of the study, there were 15 deaths in the vaccine group, and 14 deaths in the group that received the placebo. (After the unblinding, the placebo group started getting the vaccine.) In 2023, Peter Doshi, an editor of a prestigious British medical journal, wrote Kennedy's team an email advising that, based on these numbers, the proper conclusion about mortality from the study was that "there were basically equal numbers of deaths in vaccine and placebo arms."

As we talked and texted this past fall, Kennedy and I kept returning to the same arguments we'd been having two years earlier. He would point to the all-cause mortality data from the Pfizer-vaccine study. I would respond that scientists who understood the data said they didn't mean what he said they did—and I would point out that, even after the virus had mutated into new variants, observational studies continued to show that the Pfizer shot remained highly effective against both hospitalization and death.

Kennedy refused to relent. When the vaccines were introduced, he told me, public-health experts "were telling people, 'This will save your lives.' They didn't have evidence for that. Twenty-three percent all-cause mortality! That's not meaningful? I don't know what universe you're living in."

Vaccinologists told me they're living in a universe where they are trained to read and interpret data—not one in which you cherry-pick data from studies, extrapolate alarmist conclusions, and then suggest that they show a vaccine-caused increase in mortality when in fact they show nothing of the sort.

Like Bhattacharya, Kennedy tends to invoke Galileo. But in Kennedy's telling, the villains were not only the clergy who arrested Galileo and censured his discoveries, but also the astronomer's fellow scientists, who, wary of suffering his fate, refused to look through his telescope. It is a parable that posits unrecognized vaccine dangers as a sort of fixed point in the night sky, a supernova or moon, ready for discovery by anyone willing to risk their reputation in order to seek the truth.

FOUR DAYS AFTER Charlie Kirk's death, Kennedy asked to speak with me again. He had his daughter Kick set up a Zoom call so that he would have a recording of our exchange. My efforts to transcend the divide were not going well.

"You kind of telegraphed where you were going," he said when we convened that Sunday. "That there's two sides that aren't hearing each other, and both of them are intractable, and both of them think they are science-based." He called this a journalistic device. "It's a little bit self-serving because, you know, the journalist takes the position that 'Okay, I'm looking at this phenomenon where there's two sides and I'm in the middle'—the wise person who can kind of see everything," he said. He suggested that he regretted agreeing to talk with me, and compared our relationship to the fable of the scorpion who asks the frog for help crossing a river, only to sting and kill the frog after it does.

"Every article about me is the same, which is never science-based; it's never an argument; it's always an ad hominem attack," he continued. "He's a conspiracy theorist, he's anti-science, he's a crazy person, he's got a brain worm,' or the bear story, or the whale story, or the dog story, any of these, and that's what they focus on." Articles about some of these colorful episodes from his past, he believed, were efforts to distract from the substance of his arguments. "I challenge you to tell me one conspiracy that I've talked about that has not come true," he said. "Is it a conspiracy that I said that glyphosate—that Roundup—can cause cancer, like non-Hodgkin's lymphoma? All three juries agreed with me. Is it a conspiracy theory that I said that the COVID vaccine was not going to prevent transmission? Now everybody admits that. Is it a conspiracy theory that I said that masks are not science-based? Everybody now agrees with that. School closures were a mistake."

He wasn't done. He fumed that people had used his interest in his father's and uncle's assassinations to discredit him. "I've never said my father was killed by the CIA. I've said there's circumstantial



evidence.” No one, he said, has explained the inconsistencies in his father’s autopsy, which contradicted the claim that his father’s sole killer was the Palestinian activist Sirhan Sirhan. “Robert Kennedy was shot from behind four times. We know what happened to every bullet in Sirhan’s gun. He hit six other people. He could not have killed my father. So, you know, that’s a fact. It’s science. And maybe you can figure out a way that he could’ve gotten behind my father.”

We were back where we started. “You know, a real journalist” would report that people were afraid of his arguments and that they were denying facts, he said, “but I don’t think *The Atlantic* will allow you to do that.”

“You’re the HHS secretary,” I said. “Presumably you can call anybody at CDC to have this debate.”

“There’s 21,000 people in that agency, and I’m not going to have a personal debate with each one of them,” he responded. “By the way, they’re leaving because they can’t defend their position.” Of course, the people quitting their jobs would dispute that. But to win in the court of public opinion, I suspected, Kennedy preferred to debate me.

THIS WAS ALL starting to seem rather hopeless. As I drafted this article, I felt growing dismay over my inability to establish even the basic factual common ground that scientific progress generally requires. So I sent Kennedy a message describing where I had ended up, and asking for another conversation. Minutes later, an adviser texted: “Want to meet at Secretary’s house today at 1 pm?”

Kennedy bought his new Georgetown home, not far from where Uncle Jack had lived as a congressman and senator, weeks after his confirmation. An interior doorway is decorated with signed notes to him from four recent Republican presidents—Gerald Ford, Ronald Reagan, George H. W. Bush, and Trump. I asked him why there were no letters from Barack Obama or Bill Clinton, the last presidents he’d campaigned for before Trump. “They’re in storage,” he said. An American flag from 1865 hangs in his living room, a companion, Kennedy told me, to one that was given to President Abraham Lincoln shortly before he was shot.

We started out by finding at least one point of agreement, the importance of free speech. In fact, Kennedy broke with many of his Republican brethren, saying that “anything that weaponizes Charlie Kirk’s death to justify censorship is not consistent with his values.”



Kennedy in his office at the Department of Health and Human Services, October 2025

Inevitably, though, we were soon back where we'd left off. Kennedy suggested that my story conclude by looking at a statement published on the CDC website—"Vaccines do not cause autism." During the confirmation process, Bill Cassidy had made him promise not to remove the phrase in exchange for his vote. Kennedy did not want to agree, because a law called the Data Quality Act makes it illegal for his agency to make a public statement on its website that is not supported by data. Studies of the MMR vaccine and thimerosal have shown no ties to autism, but Kennedy says he still has significant unanswered questions. Neither as an independent citizen nor as HHS secretary, Kennedy says, has he been able to find any studies of possible autism risk from various infant vaccines given during the first year of life. This absence of research, he believes, undercuts the validity of the CDC's website claim.

Kick joined us on the couch. Hines sat upstairs, running through the final edits of her memoir. I asked Kennedy:

Was he now, as the nation's health secretary, arguing that science showed vaccines caused autism, as he had in the past? Or was he simply arguing that the question had not been conclusively answered by science? He responded carefully. "I have opinions about things, but, you know, my opinions are irrelevant," he said. "What we need is science, and we need definitive science. We have suggestive science."

I had spoken with others about this point. They agreed with Kennedy that not every vaccine had been studied for its effect on autism rates. But they argued that doing so was not urgent, because the existing high-quality evidence around vaccines showed no connection. Joshua Gordon, who as the director of the National Institute of Mental Health helped oversee federal autism research, told me that the recent increase in autism rates could mostly be explained by broadened criteria for diagnosis and by the advancing average age of parents at the time of conception.

"If vaccines contribute to autism, it is such a very, very small effect that there is no question that if you did the study and you definitively showed the small effect, that small effect would be far outweighed by the benefit of vaccines," Gordon told me. "The

notion that after you did those studies you would come up with a different scientific recommendation is patently false." When I asked him about the statement on the CDC website that Kennedy contests ("Vaccines do not cause autism"), Gordon said it was "a plain-English statement" that distilled the scientific consensus and was meant to encourage lifesaving vaccination.

Stanley Plotkin, one of the nation's premier vaccinologists and the lead author of the medical-school textbook *Plotkin's Vaccines*, had a similar message. "Can I say that vaccines do not cause autism?" he asked rhetorically. "All I can say is there is no evidence" that they do. He rejected some of the studies Kennedy cited as poorly conceived. He said he would not oppose a large new epidemiological study that looked at the issue, with the right design to take into account confounding variables. But he said he would not accept "a study constructed by a biased person with the objective of obtaining a certain result."

Trump was duly elected, and he appointed Kennedy as HHS secretary to carry out priorities Trump had advanced during the campaign. This gives Kennedy's scientific policies democratic legitimacy, even if trained health experts shudder at what that may mean. But as we sat in his living room, I realized that Kennedy was making an argument I had not previously understood—a policy claim, not a factual one. He was saying that regardless of the lives saved by vaccines, it was irresponsible for the government to recommend them without first comprehensively ruling out all hidden dangers. He believes that only a few vaccines, including the tuberculosis vaccine, have been studied enough to clear this bar. Kennedy had slashed the budget of his own department. But now, he says, he plans to spend billions of dollars on hundreds of studies investigating vaccines' potential ties to chronic diseases. "The default setting in medicine is 'Do no harm,'" he said, as we talked about the COVID-vaccine boosters. "You never do an intervention—particularly with a healthy human being—unless you know that it's safe and effective. And we don't know if it's safe and effective."

What if you are wrong about vaccines? I asked. Six former surgeons general, most vaccine experts, and almost the entire scientific establishment believes he is. What if, over time, the evidence shows that his actions lowered vaccination rates with no reduction in chronic diseases, but with an increase in suffering and death from viruses and bacteria? How would he respond?

"I mean, we would listen," Kennedy said. It was the answer I wanted to hear. But then he listed, once again, the reasons he would not be wrong: He spoke about the chronic diseases that appear as potential adverse reactions on the manufacturers' label for vaccines; the evidence that death rates from the diseases that vaccines inoculate against were already declining before the vaccines materialized; and America's poor policy decisions and high mortality rates during the COVID years. "You know, we have all kinds of interventions," he said. "Good health does not just come in a syringe." The trial lawyer was still laboring to connect the dots that led to his preferred verdict, the orphaned child of American royalty, back from hell, still fighting to fulfill his birthright. *A*

Michael Scherer is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

Postcolonial Chicken

By Yasmin Tayag

The U.S. introduced fast food to the Philippines. Now Jollibee is serving it back to America.

Photograph by Sonny Thakur





“JOLLY MORNING!”

is a weird way to be greeted, no matter the context. But it rang out, like birdsong, from behind the counter of a fast-food joint I visited in the Los Angeles suburbs in May. Although the restaurant's bright overhead lighting and giant menus suggested a typical American chain, something was a little off. Along one wall, a floor-to-ceiling mural depicted a cartoon bee in a chef's hat demonstrating the dance steps of the twist.

The bee is the eponymous mascot of Jollibee, which now has about 80 locations across the United States. Its food seems familiar until you taste it. Chickenjoy, the chain's signature fried chicken, has a golden, rippled exterior, just as you might expect. But tooth meets flesh with a burst of garlic, citrus, and something salty and fermented, a little like soy. What lingers on the tongue is a blast of umami that's so deeply chicken-y, it's hard to square with the mild-flavored meat that Americans have come to know.

The menu's other highlights smack of the surreal. The Aloha Burger is savory-sweet, sporting a halo of grilled pineapple beneath layers of bacon and cheese. Jolly Spaghetti is slathered in a sugary meat sauce and garnished with grated cheese and hot-dog slices. Crisp hand pies ooze purple ube and golden mango.



Above: A statue of the Jollibee mascot, ushering customers into a store in West Covina, California. Opposite page: Ernesto Tanmantiong, the global CEO and president of Jollibee Foods Corporation.

Jollibee does not serve American food, not exactly. The chain is based in the Philippines, which developed a taste for burgers and fried chicken during its years as a U.S. colony, and has since made the foods its own. Despite Jollibee's off-kilter dishes and feel—or perhaps because of them—Americans are eating it up. *USA Today* and *Eater* recently ranked its fried chicken as the best in the country among fast-food restaurants, beating out brands such as Popeyes, Chick-fil-A, and KFC. The company, once threatened by the incursion of McDon-

ald's into its territory, is aggressively expanding across the U.S.; in 2022, it opened its flagship in Times Square, a block away from McDonald's New York anchor store. Fast food, an export pushed out around the globe by the U.S., is now boomeranging back in unexpected—and, so far, lucrative—ways.

TWO SYMBOLS DOMINATE the haze of Manila's skyline: church steeples and signs bearing Jollibee's logo. Often, the Catholic Church and Jollibee go hand in hand: Final blessings at Sunday Mass release worshippers to their post-service meal, and children's birthday parties start with blessings over sweet spaghetti (and sometimes end with a visit from an employee in a giant bee costume, as I observed enviously in my own childhood during visits to Manila).

Jollibee is often described as the McDonald's of the Philippines, but that doesn't do the chain justice. It has approximately 1,300 locations across the nation, which is about the size of Arizona. Per square mile, Jollibee has nearly four times the number of stores in the Philippines as McDonald's does in the U.S.

Driving down Manila's main highway in May, I turned at a colossal golden statue of the Virgin Mary and headed toward one of the city's main business districts. Chubby red lettering at the top of a skyscraper came into view: JOLLIBEE TOWER. At a Jollibee across the street from the headquarters, I met Ernesto Tanmantiong, the global CEO and president of Jollibee Foods Corporation. We sat down for a light breakfast: a Burger Steak (beef patties smothered with mushroom gravy) and rice for me; Chickenjoy and pineapple juice for him.

Tanmantiong, who is trim with graying hair, wore a bright-red polo embroidered with the words CHOOSE JOY! He told long-winded stories and laughed at his own jokes, which made him seem less like the leader of a company worth north of \$4 billion and more like a guy who hangs out in the food court at the mall, albeit one wearing what appeared to be a blue IWC Portugieser watch worth about \$13,000. Employees call him Sir Ato, combining respect for authority with the familiarity of a nickname. He has worked at the company since his older brother, Tony Tan Caktiong, known as Sir Tony and now Jollibee's chairman, founded it in 1978.

Culinary ambitions ran in the family. Tanmantiong's father had cooked at a Chinese temple in Manila before opening a restaurant in the southern city of Davao. In 1975, Tan Caktiong borrowed family money to open two Manila franchises of Magnolia, a popular Filipino ice-cream company established by a U.S. volunteer

Army cook. With college graduation and a wedding imminent, Tan Caktiong figured that ice cream was as good a way as any to make a living. But before long, he started serving burgers too, bringing on his sister to develop recipes and Tanmantiong to manage operations. He renamed his restaurants Jollibee, which captured the family's business ethos: Employees should work as hard and harmoniously as bees, but unless they're happy, that kind of effort is "not worth it," Tanmantiong said. Jollibee's burgers were soon outselling the ice cream.

The U.S. had seized control of the archipelago at the turn of the previous century, after the Spanish-American War, bringing American soldiers and officials—along with the food they ate back home. Over time, that reshaped the national appetite. Tom's Dixie Kitchen, a Manila hot spot opened in the 1910s by a Black GI, popularized southern-style fried chicken. After the Philippines was granted independence in 1946, the hunger for American food remained. Local burger chains such as Big 20, 50/50, and Tropical Hut proliferated by serving distinctly Filipinized burgers. The Filipino palate, also shaped by a long history of Indigenous, Chinese, and Spanish settlement, demands maximum levels of sour, sweet, salty, and umami. Tropical Hut, for instance, serves an onion-sweet, heavily seasoned beef patty sandwiched between sweetened buns.

Jollibee followed in this same tradition. Its Yumburger—so named because it was "more yummy than others," Tanmantiong said—appears to be a standard American burger. Yet its patty is sweet and intensely savory (the recipe is kept secret, but amateur attempts to re-create it rely on flavorful add-ins such as oyster sauce, banana ketchup, and MSG). Its dressing—thick, tangy, saccharine—is like Big Mac sauce, distilled into something more potent. The company may prize joy, but its burger recipe is the result of a ruthless development strategy, carried out by Tanmantiong's father and sister: Copy the competition, then improve it.

Chickenjoy was designed the same way. Homegrown chicken chains, such as Max's Restaurant and Classic Savory, were popular, but they didn't serve the southern-style breaded version that the family had in mind. Tanmantiong sought inspiration abroad, before Filipinizing the final recipe. The chicken is served with a gloopy sweet gravy that Anthony Bourdain once described, not disparagingly, as the "sinister brown sauce." (He also called the sweet spaghetti—a spin on the pasta dish once served as rations to American GIs—"deranged, yet strangely alluring.")



IN JOLLIBEE'S EARLY DAYS, even as it was seeking to perfect American fast food for the Filipino palate, American fast-food chains were racing into the country. Around 1980, Tanmantiong and his brother started to notice American businessmen hanging around local Jollibees. "We already knew that it was McDonald's," he said. With just 10 locations across the country, Jollibee seemed to stand little chance against the global giant. Tan Caktiong sought advice from E. Smith Lanning, an American corporate strategist living in Manila. Lanning's prognosis was grim: Jollibee's service was too slow, its footprint too small.

Perhaps most challenging was the prospect that its identity was too Filipino to compete with McDonald's. Minyong Ordoñez, a titan of Filipino advertising, warned the family about what some locals derisively called the "American mentality";

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people assumed that anything made in the U.S. was better by default, and thus worth paying more for.

“We decided to face them head-on,” Tanmantiong said. Unable to fill locations as big as its competitor’s, Jollibee swarmed each new McDonald’s with a ring of smaller stores. It marketed itself as a restaurant where every family could go for an affordable treat; even today, a combo meal of spaghetti, fries, and a drink is cheaper than McDonald’s. (Ahead of my meeting with Tanmantiong, Jollibee corporate staff cautioned that the restaurant might be crowded because it was payday for many workers; it was indeed packed.)

Most of all, Jollibee set out to convince locals that its food was superior—more flavorful and better aligned with their taste buds—than whatever McDonald’s could offer. During our breakfast, Tanmantiong expounded on a concept that is central to the Jollibee brand: *langhap sarap*, which roughly translates to “breathe in deliciousness.” The fried chicken is not just meant to be eaten; you should be able to taste it before you even unwrap it. When I ordered the chicken at a drive-through in the Manila suburbs, the closed paper bag filled the car with dizzying richness. It verges on sensory overload, which is the point: Any American meal should seem bland in comparison.

And more often than not, it does. McDonald’s has tried to adapt its menu in the Philippines to local tastes, and it thrives there today, but it has failed to surpass Jollibee in terms of market share or cultural significance. The bone-in fried chicken I ordered at a McDonald’s drive-through was monotonously salty; the sweet spaghetti tasted synthetic and was topped with a single hot-dog slice. As an American, I found it both disorienting and disappointing to see McDonald’s playing catch-up. As a Filipino, I was appalled that I hadn’t gotten my money’s worth of hot dogs.

WHEN I VISITED the Jollibee Commissary in nearby Laguna, the company’s 24-acre flagship production plant, I didn’t breathe in deliciousness so much as bathe in it. A cloud of steam, perfumed with onions and beef, marked the entrance to the spaghetti room, where sugary sauce bubbled in stainless-steel vats the size of hot tubs. Buckets of diced bell peppers, beef tallow, and textured vegetable protein were stacked next to sealed containers of powder, which I assumed was the company’s secret spice mix. (My guides, in lab coats, would neither confirm nor deny this.) In the pie room, huge metal tubes squirted jammy mangoes and peaches onto strips of pastry. The Laguna plant is one of many, but it is the only one that makes Jollibee’s peach-mango pies (the company insists on using Filipino mangoes). I watched assembly-line workers hand-packing them—tens of thousands a day—into boxes addressed to stores across the globe.

Jollibee’s growth outside the Philippines initially followed the migration of Filipinos abroad. Since the 1970s, so many Filipinos have left home in search of better jobs that, in 2024, their remittances accounted for more than 7 percent of the Philippines’ national income. Many of Jollibee’s 1,800-plus international locations exist where there are large pockets of homesick Filipinos, which is most places: the Middle East, Southeast Asia, Europe, and America. Even in areas without a Jollibee, its parent company is at work. Worldwide, Jollibee Foods Corporation operates more



A Burger Steak, Chickenjoy, Jolly Spaghetti, and rice



Beth Dela Cruz, the president of Jollibee's North America division, at a restaurant (also pictured on the opposite page) in West Covina, California

Tanmantiong's hopes for expansion rest mostly, but not *entirely*, on the distinctive flavor of Jollibee's food. During our interview, about three-quarters of the way into my Burger Steak, we were interrupted by whistles and cheers. Jollibee himself had arrived, and he was bounding toward me in a flame-red suit and black bow tie. The lids of his huge doll eyes fluttered maniacally as he spread his arms for a hug. I let out a little scream—whether from joy or shock, I'm not sure. The staff clapped in unison as he invited me to dance by the counter, his striped thorax—abdomen?—gyrating. A pirouette later, he raised his hands for a double high five. In addition to the fried chicken, this is what Tanmantiong is exporting to America. “Aside from superior taste,” he told me later, in a boardroom in the company's tower, “you get the joy of eating in a Jollibee store.”

HOW FAR CAN JOLLIBEE GO in the U.S.? A week after my trip to Manila, my stomach still reeling from my fast-food extravaganza there, I sat down with Beth Dela Cruz, the president of the chain's North America division. I'd made the mistake of scheduling another breakfast meeting, at a franchise in West Covina, California, a suburb of Los Angeles. Dela Cruz, compact and energetic, had an auntie's indefatigable determination to compel me to eat more. Our meal included, but was not limited to, fried chicken (regular and spicy), spaghetti, two kinds of burgers, pineapple juice, and peach-mango pie. Across the street from the restaurant was Jollibee's American headquarters, a glass tower topped with the company logo.

I wanted to know how the company, having overcome Filipinos' “American mentality” decades ago in Manila, was seeking

PHILIP CHEUNG FOR THE ATLANTIC

than 10,000 stores under the 19 Filipino and international brands it has swallowed up, which include Smashburger, the Coffee Bean & Tea Leaf, and the Michelin-starred dim sum chain Tim Ho Wan. Tanmantiong's goal is to become one of the top five restaurant companies in the world (one recent estimate ranked Jollibee 17th; McDonald's is consistently first). He believes it can happen—if Jollibee can win over America.

Jollibee opened its first U.S. store in 1998; by 2020, it had 48. Most were concentrated in regions with dense Filipino-immigrant populations, such as Los Angeles and New York. But those locations have been successful enough that Jollibee has ventured into other markets. In October, when I visited the Times Square restaurant at lunchtime, a steady flow of customers—roughly half were Filipino—cycled in and out of the packed dining area, where Chickenjoy or chicken sandwiches were on nearly every table. Nationwide, average revenues per store were at least double those of Popeyes and KFC in 2024, David Henkes, a food-and-beverage-industry analyst at Technomic, told me.

The warm reception from the “mainstream”—company parlance for non-Filipino Americans—has emboldened Jollibee to ramp up its expansion, Tanmantiong said. In 2021, it announced a plan to open 500 stores across North America before the end of the decade, and recently launched a franchising program to accelerate its growth. A few blocks away from the Times Square flagship, a new storefront is preparing to open by Grand Central Station, right next door to a McDonald's.

WE WERE INTERRUPTED BY WHISTLES AND CHEERS. JOLLIBEE HIMSELF HAD ARRIVED, AND HE WAS BOUNDING TOWARD ME IN A FLAME-RED SUIT AND BLACK BOW TIE.

to do so again, in America itself. Chickenjoy may be exceptionally tasty, but Americans do not live on fried chicken alone. Jollibee's other offerings—which, in addition to the burgers and spaghetti, include *palabok*, rice noodles slathered in pork-and-shrimp gravy—are not as approachable.

Dela Cruz was, unsurprisingly, sanguine. “People freak out” about the sweet spaghetti, she said. “But then when they taste it, it becomes, like, an unexpected experience.” (In the Times Square restaurant, I’d watched a middle-aged flight attendant from Atlanta carefully remove the hot-dog slices from hers; she told me she loved the chicken but wouldn’t be ordering the spaghetti again.) The company has made concessions to its American audience. The spaghetti here is less sweet, and the pies are bigger. A line of Angus-beef burgers, available only in the U.S. and Canada, was designed to meet North American expectations: less seasoning and more sauce, Luis Velasco, the region’s senior vice president and marketing head, told me. Other menu items found in some U.S. locations include baked macaroni and cheese, chicken tenders, and southern-style biscuits, all of which I tasted during my breakfast with Dela Cruz. They were good, but they weren’t all that distinctive. The Angus burger, Dela Cruz said, “has really good flavors, but it’s meant for the mainstream”—a euphemism, I thought, for *relatively bland*.

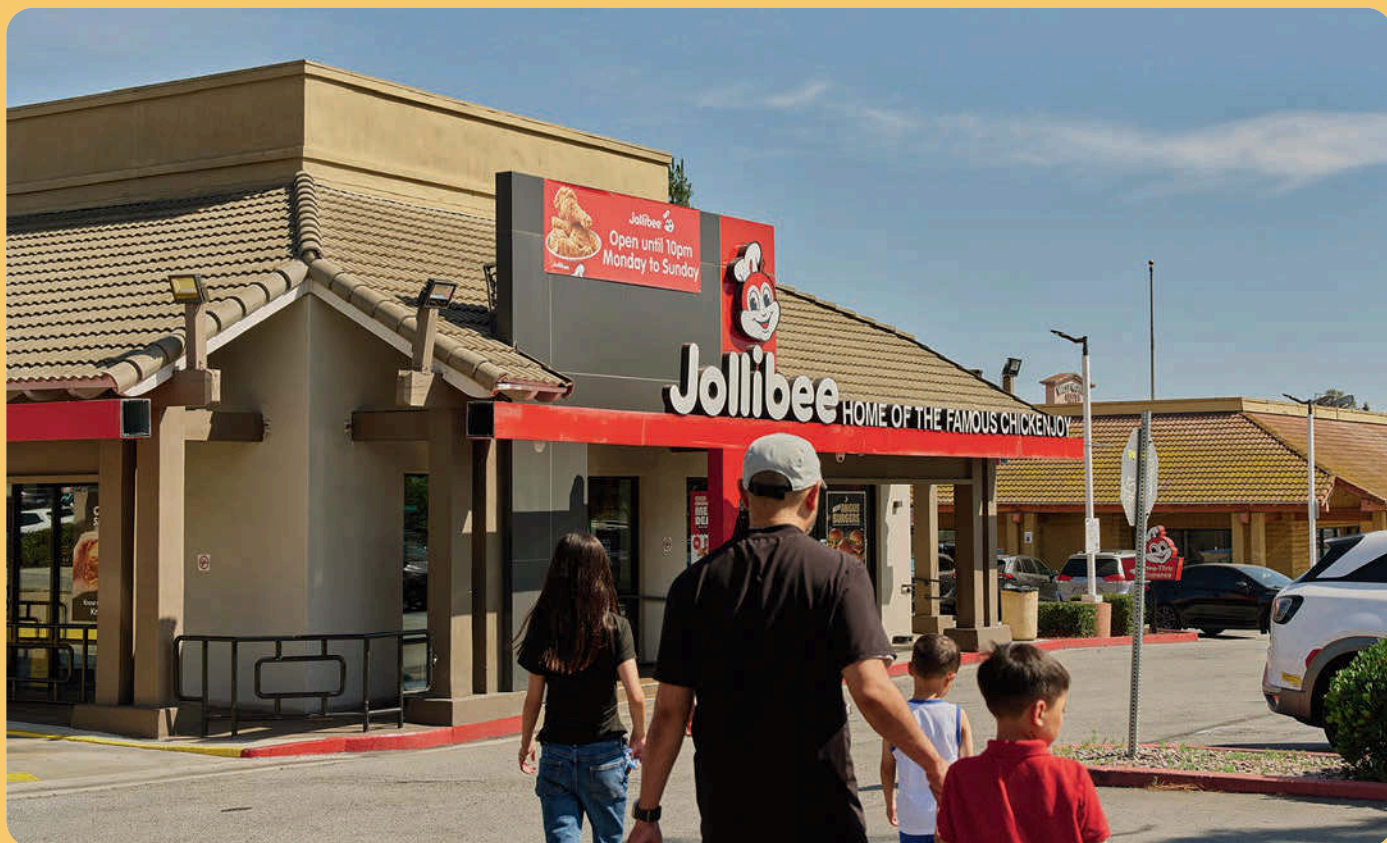
And as for the joy? Dela Cruz has succeeded, at the least, in importing Jollibee’s colorful branding and goofy mascot. Ty Matejowsky, an anthropology professor who studies Jollibee (yes, really) at the University of Central Florida, told me about

a recent proliferation of memes expressing nostalgia for a more fun era of American fast food, before McDonald’s cartoonish red roofs and PlayPlaces and Pizza Hut’s kitschy pendant lamps were given a sterile modern makeover. Jollibee seems to supply something a little like that—a “current of happiness,” he said. The service at the locations I visited was typically about as warm as any I’d experienced in Manila.

But happy low-wage workers aren’t always widely available in America. (In 2023, Jollibee settled a legal dispute with a group of employees in New Jersey who had sought better working conditions and higher pay.) Over-the-top friendliness is not the cultural default in the U.S. the way it is in the Philippines, and fundamental elements of the brand are inevitably lost in translation. In the Philippines, Jollibee is an institution; in America, it’s mostly just another chicken restaurant, and may never be destined to be anything more. Even if Jollibee opens up 500 stores in the U.S., McDonald’s has more locations in Ohio alone.

Still, Jollibee doesn’t have to topple the fast-food giants, or re-create an era when fast food was a little more fun, to play a part in reshaping the American palate, much as the U.S. reshaped the Filipino palate a century ago. On that front, it has one major advantage. For all of Jollibee’s weirdness, it isn’t entirely foreign. Because it is Filipino, it is also American. *A*

Yasmin Tayag is a staff writer at The Atlantic.





The New German War Machine



*After World War II, Germany embraced pacifism as a form of atonement.
Now the country is arming itself again.*

BY ISAAC STANLEY-BECKER PHOTOGRAPHS BY HANNES JUNG

The Bendlerblock is an imposing neoclassical building near the center of Berlin—severe and symmetrical, with a red-tile roof. It once served as the headquarters of the Wehrmacht, and it's where officers who plotted to kill Hitler in 1944 were executed by firing squad. Now the complex houses Germany's defense ministry, which oversees the armed forces.

I went to the Bendlerblock this past summer to meet with German military officials and see how they're responding to an aggressive Russia and a mercurial America. Two sergeants escorted me to the office of Lieutenant General Christian Freuding.

At the time of our meeting, Freuding was in charge of the ministry's Ukraine unit, but he had just been named the next chief of the army, a role he assumed in October. His actual, ambivalent-sounding title is inspector of the army. Freuding is gaunt and soft-spoken, with something of an aristocratic bearing. He doesn't come from a long line of military officers, he told me, but his grandfather served in both world wars and was imprisoned by Allied forces in 1945.

I told him about my own German family. A century ago, my great-grandfather Hans Salzmann was a soldier in the German army. He fought in the First World War and was wounded near Verdun and awarded the Iron Cross before returning home to practice medicine. But then his country turned on him. When the Nazis stripped him of his citizenship, he fled, sailing from Hamburg to Cuba and then to New York City, with a red J stamped on his passport.

Freuding nodded. "So you have a very personal relationship to this topic as well," he said.

The topic in question was the past and future of German militarism and its meaning for German society—a topic about which my great-grandfather thought deeply. He clung to the belief that his homeland would one day be redeemed—that the nation of "*Dichter und Denker*," of poets and thinkers, had not "disappeared entirely beneath the dirt and mud of the Third Reich." He wrote these words soon

after the Nazi surrender, as the Allies destroyed what was left of Germany's war machine and put its leaders on trial for crimes against humanity.

At first, disarmament was imposed on Germany. American and Russian forces seized weapons depots, sealed off factories, and sent trainloads of military equipment out of the country. During the Cold War, countering the Soviet threat required a new West German military, rebuilt from the ranks of former Nazis, but always under Washington's supervision.

Germany eventually embraced its own relative powerlessness as a symbol of atonement, and of human progress. After the Cold War, the country's pacifism became a mark of its faith in a global system of rules and treaties. Germany, the thinking went, could relinquish its own self-defense because brutish competition for continental dominance was over.

What made this possible was U.S. power, and in Germany, signs of it were everywhere—on bases where American troops were deployed and American nuclear weapons were stored, in cafés where Radio Free Europe broadcast American news and music, in schools and hospitals rebuilt under the Marshall Plan. Freuding said that he spent time as a teenager in the 1980s at American bars in Grafenwöhr, a town near a U.S. Army garrison that serves as one of NATO's most important training bases. American soldiers were a constant presence, and he liked them. To Germans, Freuding said, the soldiers seemed steady, dependable—an embodiment of the American-led order.



Above: The author's great-grandfather fought for Germany in World War I; his unit is pictured here taking a break from fighting at the front.

Below: Lieutenant General Christian Freuding, chief of the German army





But now that order is vanishing, Freudling said. My presence seemed to offer him something he'd been missing: an interested American audience for his worries about European security. Freudling had once been able to text American defense officials "day and night," he said, but lately communication with his counterparts in Washington had been "cut off, really cut off." The Trump administration had offered no warning, for instance, about its move to suspend certain weapons shipments to Ukraine. For information about American policy, Freudling has looked to the German embassy in Washington, where "there is somebody who tries to find somebody in the Pentagon."

The faltering of American support couldn't come at a worse time. The German officials I met, a sober group of military planners, spend their days watching Moscow's troop mobilizations, trying to determine if Vladimir Putin will order an attack on a NATO country by the end of the decade and whether the American president would, in such a case, come to Europe's defense. "You not only have an enemy knocking at the door," Freudling said, "but you also are in the process of losing a true ally and friend."

So Germany has recognized that it needs to rearm. It's spending billions on

weapons and repurposing civilian industries for arms production. It's even debating whether to reintroduce conscription. The government has promised to transform the army into the strongest in Europe. For the first time since the Second World War, Germany is permanently stationing troops beyond its borders.

Not long ago, these plans would have set off international alarms. But as the United States upends the global order it created, Germany may have no other choice.

Boris Pistorius, the German defense minister, couldn't believe what J. D. Vance was saying. On the main stage of the Munich Security Conference last February, the vice president was attacking America's NATO partners, comparing European democracies to authoritarian regimes and accusing Europe's leaders of stifling free speech and suppressing support for far-right parties. The targets of his criticism sat before him: the presidents of the European Commission and the European Council; heads of government from countries including Germany, Sweden, Ireland, and Latvia. A stunned silence fell over the grand hall of the Hotel Bayerischer Hof.

The annual security conference is traditionally a chummy event, sometimes

described as a "transatlantic family meeting." It's not always harmonious; in 2003, Germany aired doubts about American plans for the war in Iraq. But criticism of the host country is considered uncouth. And in recent years, the meeting in Munich has represented a show of Western solidarity with Ukraine. But Vance used the conference as a platform for MAGA grievances. "The threat that I worry the most about vis-à-vis Europe is not Russia; it's not China," he said. "What I worry about is the threat from within."

Pistorius couldn't let the vice president's comments pass without rebuke. "That is unacceptable," he shouted in English from the second row. Vance continued, unfazed. Later, at the lectern, Pistorius declared that he must "explicitly contradict and oppose" Vance's claims before turning to the focus of the conference: European and international security. Because the White House was pressing for a quick settlement to Russia's war in Ukraine, and signaling that Europe would have to enforce the terms, Pistorius warned, "The choices we make now will determine whether we live in peace or in crisis."

Pistorius has a restless air about him; his gait is hurried, his gestures emphatic. When I met with him at the Bendlerblock, he told me he'd never imagined that he

would lead his country's rearmament. His father was a pacifist who didn't allow toy guns in the house. During the Cold War, Pistorius joined the Social Democratic Party, which had made *Ostpolitik*, aimed at easing relations with Moscow, the center of its foreign policy. "America is indispensable," went the credo, but "Russia is immovable." But after the Iron Curtain fell, Pistorius recalled, Germans thought they were living in a world without threats.

After Russia's annexation of Crimea, in 2014, Germany agreed to work toward spending 2 percent of its economic output on defense within a decade. But its progress was slow in the years that followed, and Donald Trump complained in his first term that Germany and other NATO members weren't paying their share. German soldiers told me it was common then for members of the officer corps to purchase their own gear: boots, pants, field jackets.

Then, in 2022, Russia launched its full-scale invasion of Ukraine. At the outset of the war, Europe's largest since World War II, Germany's army chief admitted in a public post that the forces under his command were "more or less bare." The German government declared a *Zeitenwende*, or "turning of the times." It promised a burst of cash for the Bundeswehr—the armed forces—that would finally bring the country, which has Europe's biggest economy, in line with NATO targets. A second shock came not long after the Munich Security Conference, when German officials watched in disbelief as Trump, in a televised Oval Office meeting, reprimanded Volodymyr Zelensky for refusing peace on terms dictated by the White House. Freuding said that he had never sent as many texts in a single night as he did on that occasion, to his friends and colleagues in Ukraine.

For Friedrich Merz, then the chancellor-in-waiting, the confrontation made clear that Europe could no longer rely on the United States. A senior German official who spoke on the condition of anonymity told me that Merz, a member of the center-right Christian Democratic Union, is haunted by the question "Will America serve its allies to the dogs?" After the spectacle in the



Oval Office, he became convinced of the need to amend Germany's constitution to authorize unlimited government borrowing for defense. Within a month, the Bundestag approved the reform.

Görlitz is Germany's easternmost city, adjacent to the Polish border. It was spared Allied bombing during World War II, and its old town bears the imprint of centuries of European history. Now Görlitz offers a glimpse of the future: At a ceremony there last February, then-Chancellor Olaf Scholz heralded the city as a hub of rearmament. Production lines once used for double-decker train cars are being altered to make parts for Leopard 2 battle tanks, Puma infantry fighting vehicles, and Boxer armored vehicles. The defense firm KNDS is taking over a factory from the rail company Alstom. The transition will be complete in 2027.

I asked Pistorius why manufacturers can't move faster, noting that Germany has been adept at making tanks when it puts its mind to it. He said the companies, like the rest of German society, had

grown accustomed to peacetime. When the Cold War ended, and a reunified Germany reduced its military, tanks were sold abroad or scrapped for metal and parts. By one estimate, Germany had only about 340 tanks by 2021.

According to Bruegel, a Brussels-based think tank, effective European deterrence—averting a Russian invasion of the Baltics, for example—would require 1,400 tanks and 2,000 infantry fighting vehicles, more than the combined capabilities of Germany, France, Britain, and Italy. Although all four countries are spending more on their armed forces to close the gap, no other Western European country matches Germany, which will devote more than 460 billion euros, or \$538 billion, to the Bundeswehr over the next four years.

But in Görlitz, the shift to weapons manufacturing has run up against the growing power of political extremes. The far-right Alternative for Germany is the largest opposition bloc in the Bundestag, controlling nearly a quarter of the seats. The party's base of support is in the former Communist East, where economic hardship fuels nostalgia for the world before



**Boris
Pistorius,
the German
defense
minister**

German reunification, and sympathy for Moscow endures. The AfD's national co-leader Tino Chrupalla, who represents Görlitz in the Bundestag, is scornful of the need to deter Russia. In 2023, he wore a tie with the Russian tricolor to an event at the Russian embassy in Berlin. And in a recent interview with a German broadcaster, he asked, "Do we really believe that we can defeat the world's greatest nuclear power and win this war that isn't even ours?" Sebastian Wippel, the AfD candidate who narrowly lost Görlitz's mayoral race in 2019, told me that weapons made in the city must be used only to defend Germany, not to arm Ukraine. Deterrence, he said, can't mean "threatening Russia."

Some on the left are also skeptical of rearmament. Environmental and social activists protested in the spring against the planned assembly of weapons in Görlitz. NEVER AGAIN WAR! reads graffiti on a factory wall. Outside the plant that will soon manufacture tanks, I met an expert in the technical preparation of train parts who has worked in the rail industry for 16 years. He told me he would transfer to a factory in a nearby city to avoid making weaponry. "I want no part in it," he said.

Across the Spree River from the Bundestag is an office building occupied by a start-up that makes suicide drones. On the ground floor is a showroom with an elegant minimalist aesthetic, a space so airy and bright that it could be an art gallery—except that military payloads fill the glass display cases. In one corner stands a drone. It's tall, like a Giacometti sculpture.

The drone is named Virtus. It takes off vertically and tilts in the air to fly like a plane, a loitering munition with four rectangular wings. Guided by artificial intelligence, it circles a target area, identifies an enemy asset, and slams into it with an explosive warhead. The start-up, called Stark, has begun supplying the German armed forces with weapons for testing and certification, and the government plans to purchase a large stock of such drones next year.

Stark was founded in Berlin in 2024, and now has outposts in both England and Ukraine. It works only with NATO

and allied militaries. The company's drones are easy to assemble, a Stark spokesperson told me. This is important because armies differ in their techniques; the Ukrainians, for instance, use Velcro to strap the warhead in place.

The company's pitch is that a drone is cheaper, and more cost-effective, than a tank. Powered by a battery, Virtus can fly for about 60 minutes at a cruising speed of 75 miles an hour, and dive at up to twice that velocity. The aim was "to make this kind of equipment a commodity, to make it easy to order it, easy to produce it, and easy to pay for it," Johannes Arlt, a former air-force officer and Social Democratic Party politician who is now a Stark executive, told me. On his phone, he showed me a video of the drone landing deftly on a piece of printer paper.

Germany has long been inhospitable to defense start-ups because of too little demand and too much political opposition. But the country's venture-capital firms have lately been flooded with proposals from such start-ups, according to Jack Wang, who leads investments in defense technology at a firm called Project A. The proposals cite Vance's speech at the Munich Security Conference and Trump's Oval Office confrontation with Zelensky, appealing to investors who see opportunities in the White House's animus toward Europe. One is Peter Thiel, a Vance mentor who has invested in Stark. Another is the American venture-capital firm Sequoia Capital, whose most outspoken partner, Shaun Maguire, is a prominent Trump supporter.

As the Germans ramp up their own arms production, they still need to import weapons from abroad. I met with Colonel Dennis Krüger at the General Steinhoff Barracks. The facility was built by the Third Reich on the outskirts of Berlin, and later became a site of the Berlin Airlift, receiving the supplies that sustained the city during the Soviet blockade. Now the barracks are home to Germany's air force. In the courtyard, Krüger showed me a retired Patriot launcher. Made in the United States, the anti-ballistic-missile system is a pillar of NATO air defense, able to neutralize drones, cruise missiles, and tactical ballistic missiles.

Recently, though, Germany has begun to look beyond the U.S. for air-defense weaponry. Krüger told me about traveling to Tel Aviv to fine-tune a missile-defense system purchased from the Israelis that can intercept and destroy long-range ballistic missiles in space. On the sleeve of his military shirt, below a decal of the German flag, is another with Hebrew lettering, the logo of the weapons project: Arrow 3. For decades, Germany has been a top exporter of arms to Israel, its commitment to the security of the Jewish state a legacy of the Holocaust. Arrow 3, the largest defense deal in Israeli history, reverses that logic by making Israel a guarantor of German safety.

Krüger said that work on the weapons system turned representatives from the two militaries into a “family,” and that they built camaraderie when his staff waited out missile attacks in Tel Aviv’s belowground shelters with their Israeli counterparts. The weapons acquisition from Israel is “one next step,” Krüger said, “in overcoming our history.”

Weapons—even unmanned drones—need soldiers to operate them. On the sidewalk outside a Berlin military-recruitment office, I met a young German named Julian Boy. At the time, the Bundeswehr was advertising an open house on its website: “Do you know exactly what you want? Then join the Bundeswehr now.” Boy, who is 24, fit and broad-shouldered with close-cropped hair, looked like an ideal recruit. Boy did know exactly what he wanted, and it was not to join the military.

He told me that he believes Germany should have more weapons and troops. “I don’t know if America will be there to support Europe,” he said. “So we need to do it ourselves.” But he has never considered enlisting. He already has a job, as a metalworker. Besides, the Bundeswehr’s deficiencies were legendary. Stories of scarcity and incompetence—that’s what his generation knows of the army. “It’s a meme,” he said. “Munitions being used up in two minutes.”

Changing this perception is the defense ministry’s hardest task. NATO targets call for a German fighting force

of 260,000, far more than the country’s current roster of about 182,000 active-duty soldiers. Thomas Röwekamp, who chairs the Bundestag’s defense committee, told me that the government needs to convince a generation raised in peacetime that they can’t take their safety for granted anymore.

Germany is set to begin compulsory military screening in 2026, but won’t yet resume conscription, which was suspended more than a decade ago. All 18-year-olds will receive a questionnaire assessing their willingness to join the armed forces; men must respond, and women will have the option to do so. The hesitation about a draft—which Röwekamp argued will eventually be necessary—struck me as evidence of Germany’s abiding unease about preparing for war. Pistorius still hopes that a voluntary model can work.

Recruitment advertising is everywhere. A TikTok series offers a “road trip” through the Bundeswehr—the chance to follow four influencers on military missions. Calls to enlist adorn train stations and buses, even fast-food packaging. DO YOU HAVE WHAT IT TAKES? asks text printed on pizza boxes.

In the decades since World War II, Germans have developed a deep aversion to anything that resembles the Nazi veneration of the soldier. They’ve been outraged by recent scandals that seem to reflect the Third Reich’s lasting imprint on some corners of the military. In the special forces, a sergeant major placed under investigation in 2017 was alleged to have stockpiled stolen ammunition and explosives alongside Nazi memorabilia; at a party, soldiers were said to have performed the Nazi salute, which is banned in Germany. One special-forces unit was so rife with right-wing fanaticism that the defense ministry disbanded it in 2020. Today, screening for extremism is a Bundeswehr priority.

The last time Germany had a permanent armed presence in Lithuania was during the Nazi occupation, when the Wehrmacht swept east, invading the Soviet Union. By the end of the war, the Jewish population of Lithuania had been slaughtered. Near Vilnius, the



Johannes Arlt, an executive at the defense start-up Stark, in Berlin, with a Virtus drone



capital, killing squads dumped corpses into trenches dug in the forest.

Now Germans carrying guns are back in Lithuania. They're stationed in Vilnius, in an office building in the city's business district, where the seventh floor is reserved for Panzerbrigade 45, the first permanent foreign deployment of German troops since the Second World War. When I visited the brigade, groups of soldiers were hanging out on the sidewalk, smoking cigarettes.

The German soldiers' mission is to help fend off a Russian attack. Vilnius is their temporary home; a permanent base for the brigade, projected to number about 5,000 by 2027, will lie near the border with Belarus, the Russian client state that serves

as a depot for dozens of Moscow's nuclear weapons. Lithuania, a NATO member since 2004, is particularly vulnerable because it's located along the Suwałki Gap, the 60-mile expanse separating the Russian exclave of Kaliningrad from Belarus. That strip of land is NATO's only overland route connecting Western Europe to the Baltic states, and the alliance's leaders worry that Putin could try to seal it off.

Brigadier General Christoph Huber, who leads the German soldiers in Lithuania, showed me a 3-D model of the barracks, which will include training fields, sports grounds, and housing. "We are here to defend every inch of NATO territory," he told me. "To put on the fight against"—he

paused, correcting himself—"the *possible* fight against Russia."

The strategic logic is clear. Still, I wondered how Lithuanians felt about the sight of German soldiers. Across the street from the brigade's headquarters is the old Jewish cemetery of Vilnius, a city once called the Jerusalem of the North. PLEASE RESPECT THIS PLACE FOR THE ETERNAL REST OF THE JEWISH PEOPLE states a plaque bearing a Star of David. It stands as a reminder of the Nazi past. But for the people I met in the residential neighborhoods of Vilnius, memories of Soviet terror are fresher, and fears of Russian aggression are ever present. A young mother told me that her family

had suffered under Soviet collectivization policies, and that she feels safer with German soldiers around. I approached another resident, a scriptwriter who said only, “We live next to a shit country.”

I got the sense that the German military is more popular in Vilnius than in Görlitz. Huber told stories of being stopped on the street and thanked for defending Lithuania. We sat in his office, where German, Lithuanian, and NATO flags hung. He described ceremonies held in the spring to inaugurate the brigade, festivities that brought the chancellor and defense minister from Germany. In Vilnius cafés, Lithuanians insisted on buying coffee for his troops. The display panel on the front of city buses announced LTU ♥ DEU. Lithuania loves Germany.

The defense ministry points to the welcoming of German troops as proof of Europe’s support for its military buildup. “The fear of a weak and indecisive Germany is bigger than the fear of a strong Germany,” Pistorius said.

Huber said that his troops are receiving Germany’s most advanced military equipment, including the newest Leopard tanks. They are training on territory where they might go to war, crossing anti-tank ditches, dodging mine obstacles, and navigating rivers. Huber is studying Russia’s tactics in Ukraine, anticipating the “war of the future.” His battalions will become experts in electronic and drone warfare. “The Panzerbrigade 45 has the top priority within the German army,” he said.

The general has a paperweight on his desk quoting Winston Churchill: ACTION THIS DAY. I asked him about another Churchill maxim, delivered in an address to the U.S. Congress in 1943. The Germans, according to the British prime minister, are “always either at your throat or your feet.”

“Much has changed,” Huber said without emotion. There is nothing distinctive, he added, about the German capacity for evil. “We have to be aware of human beings, in general, having a dark side.”

In June, as part of a “Day of Values” observed within the German army, members of the Panzerbrigade cleaned up graves at a Jewish cemetery in Merkinė, a Lithuanian town where hundreds of Jews were shot by Nazi forces and local collaborators in 1941. Some of the tombstones are more than a century old. The soldiers wiped away the dirt that had collected from decades of neglect. The Jews who might have tended the graves of their ancestors are dead, Huber said. “Germans killed them.”

A bronze statue of a naked man with bound wrists stands in the courtyard of the Bendlerblock. It honors the army officers who tried to assassinate Hitler, and who were shot in the courtyard on a summer day in 1944. Toward the end of my interview with Pistorius, after we had discussed tanks and soldiers, I asked him if he finds the statue at all incongruous.





Above: A Puma infantry fighting vehicle on military training grounds in Bavaria

Opposite page: A statue at the Bendlerblock honors the army officers who plotted to kill Hitler, and who were shot in the courtyard in 1944.

Germany must be the only country in the world, I said, to place a memorial to an attempted coup within its defense ministry. Pistorius said that he appreciates the statue as a reminder of the democratic sources of his country's military power. "No oath is ever taken again on a leader, but on a constitution."

But constitutions can be amended. And the oaths of soldiers can change as well, depending on shifting political tides. If the AfD continues its march to power, an illiberal German government could reverse the country's international allegiances—the tanks and drones now equipping the Ukrainian resistance instead advancing Russian interests, the army-building set in motion for the defense of liberal democracy exploited by a resurgent German militarism. Listening to plans for rearmament in the old Wehrmacht headquarters, I wondered whether Germany could get power right this time.

Of course, militarism can serve illiberal ends anywhere, if democracy becomes fragile. The Trump administration has shown an early willingness to deploy the National Guard, and even regular Army units, to American cities. "I could send the

Army, Navy, Air Force, Marines—I could send anybody I wanted," Trump has said. Such rhetoric shocks Germans because it's reminiscent of their own country's past.

After the war, my great-grandfather remembered acts of resistance. He knew a professor in Berlin who read poetry to the Brownshirts in his class, explaining, "That's from the Jew Heinrich Heine"; a taxi driver who took a hunted Polish Jew to the Czechoslovakian border to escape; a father who brought his young daughter to see a burning synagogue, telling her, "Never forget those misdeeds of the Nazis."

Where were "the 'good' Germans?" my great-grandfather asked. In jails and concentration camps, he answered, and buried in the earth. But as a refugee, "rescued here on the foot of the Statue of Liberty," he believed American influence would help secure peace and purge Europe of fascism.

For a time, it did. But that world is disappearing, and Germany's pacifism belongs to another age. *A*

Isaac Stanley-Becker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

Culture & Critics

OMNIVORE

Respect the Drummer

A new history of rock, told through its overlooked heroes

By James Parker

Full disclosure: I play the drums. I play them every chance I get. Although my drumming career has served mainly as a steady education in my own shining mediocrity as a drummer, a reminder that I was put on this Earth for other things, I love hitting the goddamn drums. Left foot on the hi-hat pedal, right foot on the kick-drum pedal, left hand on the snare, right hand on the ride cymbal. When it starts to flow, you're like da Vinci's *Vitruvian Man*: You're



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in a holy circle of equilibrium, blissfully distributed, with consciousness diffused to your extremities.

How do you get better as a drummer? Well, you practice: You do the same thing over and over, slowly building muscle fiber while also experiencing, in your brain, the painless, clueless ache of a synapse trying to form. You get better by being in a band, by entering music as part of a volatile, multi-person, multi-addiction organism. And you get better, lastly, via the drummer's version of the grace of God—which is the jolt, the volt, the heavenly bolt, the electromotive impulse that flashes out from the playing of another, much greater drummer, and claims you.

John Langan's superb *Backbeats: A History of Rock and Roll in Fifteen Drummers* is full of such moments. Moments of transmission—often via vinyl, occasionally in performance—when the creative spark zips and snaps across the pre-artistic darkness and some young drummer somewhere realizes that he's going to have to change his life. Dave Lombardo, pre-Slayer, listening in awe to Phil “Philthy Animal” Taylor pummeling through a relentless double-kick-drum pattern on the title track of Motörhead's *Overkill*. Jody Stephens, pre-Big Star, in the 17th row at a Led Zeppelin show in Memphis: John Bonham was “like a rocket, everyone else was just holding on.” Tony Thompson, pre-Chic, watching the Mahavishnu Orchestra: “I saw Billy Cobham for the first time—and saw God . . . It's still embedded in my soul seeing him play like that.”

The drummer James Osterberg, before he became Iggy Pop, was infatuated with the bluesy playing of Sam Lay. (You can hear Lay's ghostly snare taps on Howlin' Wolf's “Little Red Rooster”; you can also hear him, four years later, tearing through the anarchic-ironic shuffle of Bob Dylan's “Highway 61 Revisited.”) Osterberg made a young man's picaresque pilgrimage from Ann Arbor to Lay's house in Chicago. “His wife was very surprised that I was looking for him,” he tells Legs McNeil and Gillian McCain in *Please Kill Me: The Uncensored Oral History of Punk*. “She said, ‘Well, he's not here, but would you like some fried chicken?’”

My own little drum crisis/awakening came at the hands (and feet) of Dave Grohl, pre-Nirvana, when I saw him playing with the Washington, D.C., hardcore-punk band Screaming Trees. Grohl—skinny, 19 years old—was all attack, all emphasis. He drummed in italics. Simultaneously, there was something subliminal and almost unspeakable about his playing; as devastatingly correct as it was, he also seemed to be pulling information from a rhythmic grid more profound, more capacious, than the mere ticktocking of accurate time.

Because this is the great mystery of drumming: Time. Not just tempo, not just keeping the beat—the guitarist and the bassist can do that—but the drummer's musical relationship to the flow of Time itself.

Opposite page: *Dave Grohl of Nirvana and Foo Fighters, one of the few drummers to become a real rock star.* This page: *Moe Tucker of the Velvet Underground, known for fusing steely minimalism with raw impact to produce her signature drone.*



To the passing of all things, to the universe's rumble toward infinity. John Bonham's left foot on the hi-hat pedal—*shick-shick-shick*—has the cadence of Deep Time. It's Bonham's neurological signature: a lilt, an inflection, a swing that microscopically delays or dis-tends the beat while also fulfilling it. Listen to “Whole Lotta Love,” around 1:18, the start of the freak-out section. Listen to that hi-hat going up and down, up and down. Bonham, steady as he is, is not keeping time. He's releasing it.

His own rumble toward infinity was brief, fiery, and pocked with shadow. Langan pairs him with the Who's Keith Moon: “Their drumming was an accurate reflection of each of their personalities—they were loud, they were destructive, they hurt and endangered people, and they both died young and violently from self-abuse.” Here I think I might respectfully disagree. In both cases, the drumming, the art, transcended the personality.

Grohl and Bonham get a chapter each in *Backbeats*, as does—to my great delight—Earl Hudson from Bad Brains, a low-key powerhouse whose playing steered the shamanic flights of his brother, the band's front man, H.R., through the ether. The great session man Hal Blaine is also featured, and Clyde Stubblefield from James Brown's the J.B.'s, the author of the “Funky Drummer” beat that's since been looped through a thousand hip-hop tracks.

To nondrummers, many of these figures will be obscure. (One main counterexample is Grohl, who made himself a real rock star as the guitarist-vocalist of Foo Fighters.) This is largely the drummer's fate: to be felt but not seen. And this is the ambition of

This is largely the drummer's fate: to be felt but not seen.



Lingan's book—to tell a story of rock-and-roll evolution from the back, from the bowels, from the under-realm of the creator-drummers. How have drummers responded to the increasing power and complexity of the music? How have they themselves increased that power and complexity? By the time we get to Dave Lombardo and Slayer's *Reign in Blood*, we are in a zone of Darwinian mutation, as Lombardo pulls off feats of speed and dexterity unimaginable—and probably terrifying—to his drumming forebears.

The sole female among Lingan's 15 selected drummers is Moe Tucker, of the Velvet Underground. Self-taught, self-willed—"I consciously, purposely, didn't learn more about drums because I didn't want to sound like anybody else"—Tucker fused steely minimalism with raw, repetitive impact. If any rock-and-roll drummer could be said to have made their drums drone, it's her. No crashing cymbals for Moe Tucker: not for her, the big-top vulgarity of those metallic exclamation points. And sometimes no downbeat—the ferocious shuffle she plays on "Run Run Run" is on the snare alone, its clattering, unmoored momentum working like a propellant on Lou Reed's storytelling. *Ka-chunk-a-CHUNK-a-chunk-a-CHUNK*... The addicts are fiending around New York City, looking for a fix, a drag, a taste, anything. Maybe this was Tucker's special compact with Time—Time as narrative; Time as unfolding drama.

John Bonham and Jimmy Page of the New Yardbirds perform in Denmark in September 1968, a month before the group was reborn as Led Zeppelin.

BACKBEATS:
A HISTORY OF
ROCK AND ROLL
IN FIFTEEN
DRUMMERS

John Lingan

SCRIBNER

And one last thing about Time: Of all the members of the band, it comes for the drummer first. Guitars get heavier as you get older, high notes harder to hit, but the drummer pays a private tax to mortality. The drummer's strength goes faster. Exactly how fast depends, to a degree, on the music. Metal drumming is famously punishing, and high-speed punk rock, as Lingan writes, "has always survived on heroic drumming. Someone has to sustain that pulse." But even the mid-tempo drummer will have their moments of naked endurance. A 2008 study of Blondie's Clem Burke revealed that, during live sets, he played with the stamina of an athlete, burning about 600 calories over the course of an 82-minute show. Many bands, when they re-form for their 20th- or 30th-anniversary tours, have a new man, younger and stronger, on drums.

So what's a jowly old superannuated drummer to do? How do you stay on that drum stool and keep playing that funky/punky/heavy/wicky-wacky whatever-it-is? Well, you stop thrashing. You move more precisely; you breathe more deeply; you manage your force more shrewdly. You measure the dosage of power in every stroke. You use, in a word, technique. It's like life. *A*

James Parker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



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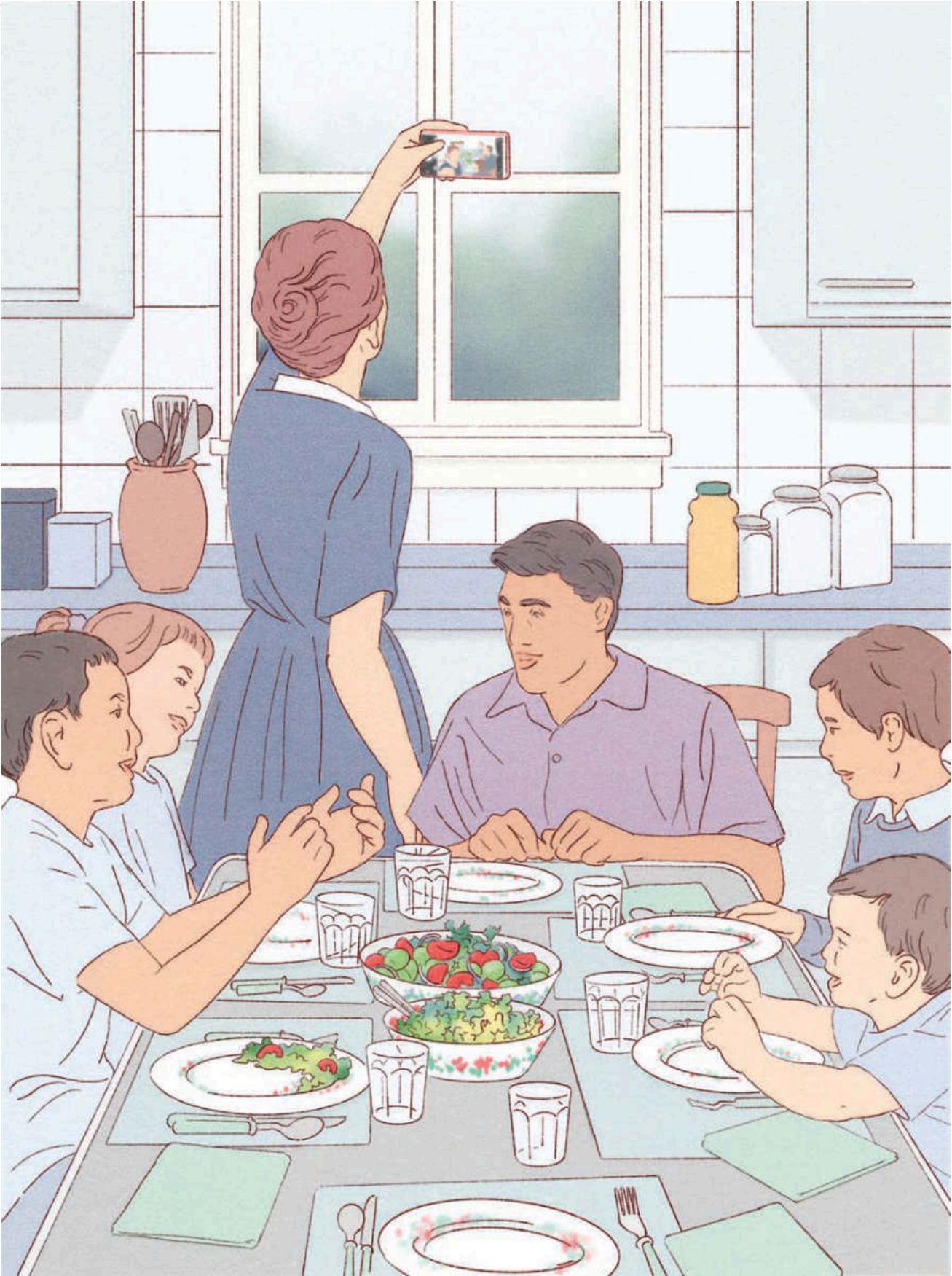
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What's for Dinner, Mom?

*The women who want to
change the way America eats*

By Sophie Gilbert

Sometimes I think I became a mother not in a hospital room but in a Trader Joe's in New York City. It was May 2020. A masked but smizing employee took one look at my stomach and handed me a packet of dark-chocolate peanut-butter cups. "Happy Mother's Day!" she said. I was pregnant, with twins, during the early months of the pandemic, and all I could think about was food—what to eat and how to acquire it. Once a week I dashed clumsily through the store's aisles, grabbing cans of beans and bags of apples while trying not to breathe, like a contestant on a postapocalyptic episode of *Supermarket Sweep*.

Food then was interlaced with a sense of danger, the coronavirus potentially spreading (we worried, absurdly it turned out) even by way of reusable totes. Meanwhile, I knew from my relentless pregnancy apps that what I ate could have monumental implications for my future children's eating habits. I was scared, and I felt powerless, and food seemed like one of the few things I could control, or at least try to.

What I didn't yet know was that I was tapping into a deep-rooted tradition—or that, even as I panic-shopped, it was evolving. Mothers are our first food influencers, and for most of history, they have been our primary ones. The process starts even before we're born, we now know: The tastes we're exposed to in utero inform the preferences we'll have much later in life. Culture, "at least when it comes to food, is really just a fancy word for your mother," Michael Pollan wrote in his best-selling 2008 book, *In Defense of Food: An Eater's Manifesto*. Up until the mid-20th century or so, we humans ate much as our parents did, and their parents before them, and so on: food cooked at home, from fresh ingredients, made predominantly by women.

But a flurry of destabilizing changes followed the Second World War, which had accustomed Americans to mass-produced boxed meals via rations issued to the military. Technological developments

on multiple fronts brought prepackaged meals, frozen food, industrialized agriculture, the microwave oven. Marketers were learning how to subliminally manipulate shoppers. Perhaps most significant of all was a shift taking place at home: Women were joining the workforce, happily ceding the task of dinner to Big Food.

By the 2000s, the consequences of all these changes were becoming calamitous. In the 1960s, 13 percent of American adults and about 5 percent of children were obese; by 2005, the number had risen to 35 percent of adults and more than 15 percent of children. Food companies had long since mastered the art of engineering products to encourage mindless overconsumption with every lab-perfected crunch, crisp, and snap. They'd also figured out how to maximize their sway over U.S. food policy, donating to politicians and directly funding scientists. And they did so while decrying as intrusive any efforts to rein in the ruthless lobbying tactics laid bare by the nutritionist and advocate Marion Nestle in her 2002 book, *Food Politics: How the Food Industry Influences Nutrition and Health*.

Nestle, whom *The New York Times* has called "one of the most influential framers of the modern food movement," has spent the two decades since then trying to help Americans understand the extent to which the systems that feed them are implicated in sickening them for profit. Big Food, she was among the first to highlight, often bypasses parents to target kids directly using cartoon mascots and promotional collaborations with toy companies. (One of the prized possessions in her archive is an Oreo-themed Barbie doll.) Until recently, Nestle's war against the Pillsbury Doughboy and Tony the Tiger looked unwinnable, as she observes in her new book, *What to Eat Now: The Indispensable Guide to Good Food, How to Find It, and Why It Matters*. An update of her 2006 field guide for supermarket shoppers, it demonstrates how lamentably little progress has been made since then.

Supermarkets and supply chains are even more consolidated than they were 20 years ago, and corporations are more empowered, as Nestle writes, "to sell food products no matter what they do to or for your health." Nearly three-quarters of American adults are now overweight or obese. An array of new products since 2006—oat milk and gluten-free pasta, more global ingredients (gochujang, sumac), plant-based "meats," CBD-infused everything—has added variety, but also confusion. What counts as healthy? The influx certainly hasn't halted a rise in consumption of ultra-processed foods (those heavily reliant on industrial ingredients and methods far removed from anything you'd cook at home). They now make up

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more than half of the average American adult's diet and two-thirds of what children eat. The food system in America, Nestle explains, produces twice the amount of calories we actually need, while ravaging the environment we can't survive without. (Industrialized farming results in water and air pollution, soil degradation, deforestation, and a loss of biodiversity.)

But something perplexing has also been happening for half a decade or so now: Once again, patterns of influence over what we eat are being upended. Enabled by social media, certain mothers have been mobilizing, intent on reasserting their authority over mealtime. I wasn't the only one obsessed with food during the pandemic; something about the confluence of fear, frustration, and way too much time online ignited an impassioned, women-led, influencer-stoked, food-centered movement. A lot of the focus on fresh, homemade meals that this missionary crew has been advocating for has felt familiar—and sensible—to parents like me, dealing with uneaten strips of bell pepper and endless requests for snacks heavy in high-fructose corn syrup. Much has also felt wholly reactionary, rooted not just in the dietary and agricultural traditions of bygone days, but also in old-style gender politics.

The past few years have seen a glut of wellness content about the dangers of seed oils and chemicals, as well as nostalgic imagery disseminated over social media by women labeled “tradwives”: freshly baked bread emerging from a weathered Dutch oven in a lovely country kitchen, cows being milked in bucolic bliss, chubby-cheeked toddlers waddling through vegetable patches. And then “Make America Healthy Again,” a slogan that began life as a winking provocation in a 2016 Sweetgreen ad, morphed into a more politicized mantra among an improbable coalition of personalities who also want milk unpasteurized, food dyes banned, vaccines eliminated—and who also seem to want women re-enshrined in their rightful place in the kitchen.

“Who isn't a food person these days?” the chef Ruby Tandoh asks in her new essay collection, *All Consuming: Why We Eat the Way We Eat Now*, surveying a culture in which everybody seems to be “talking about almost nothing else.” What's striking is that these days, most of us recognize that America's diet needs an intervention that goes beyond talk—and medication: GLP-1 drugs, however remarkable their effects may be, can't feed kids. Yet the dramatic showdown between profit-greedy Big Food and proselytizing Big Family is eclipsing a middle ground of parenting pragmatists. Contradictory nutrition advice online drowns out a basic consensus: Experts overwhelmingly agree that a healthy diet still aligns with the same boring guidelines we grew up hearing—eat your fruits and vegetables, avoid ultra-processed (formerly “junk”) foods, limit sugar. How has

WHAT TO EAT
NOW: THE
INDISPENSABLE
GUIDE TO GOOD
FOOD, HOW TO
FIND IT, AND
WHY IT MATTERS

Marion Nestle

NORTH POINT PRESS

ALL CONSUMING:
WHY WE EAT
THE WAY WE
EAT NOW

Ruby Tandoh

KNOPF

THE LAST
SUPPER: HOW
TO OVERCOME
THE COMING
FOOD CRISIS

Sam Kass

CROWN

the discussion become so polarized? And what might it take to actually fix dinner?

WE'VE SEEN politicized food fights before. In the mid-2000s, a harried mother in Chicago, navigating a fast-track, dual-career schedule with her partner, began to rely on quick fixes when feeding her kids: takeout, ready meals, prepackaged snacks. One day, at a routine doctor appointment, she learned that both of her daughters were on the path to becoming overweight, a warning that spurred her to overhaul the way her family was eating. “I was grateful for the time and the effort that I saved with these kinds of products,” Michelle Obama told a gathering of food-business executives in 2010, after she became first lady of the United States. “But I was also completely unaware that all that extra convenience sometimes made it just a little too easy for me to eat too much, for my kids to eat too much, and to eat too often.” She was unprepared, too, for the partisan ruckus that was about to begin.

The chef, advocate, and policy adviser Sam Kass recounts this story in his wide-ranging and pragmatic new book about America's food failings, *The Last Supper: How to Overcome the Coming Food Crisis*. Kass was just a few years out of college when he was hired by Obama in 2007 to help improve what and how her family ate at home. He then moved to Washington to work with the first lady on expanding her healthy-eating revolution from a personal goal into a political project. At the time, Kass notes, he'd been radicalized by Pollan and Nestle, who were giving shape to an intellectual, leftish, Berkeley-centric movement advocating for sustainable food production and more health-oriented food policies: “I shopped at farmers markets. I ate organic. My beef was grass fed. I thought that everyone should eat that way.” He arrived in the capital, he writes, “ready to decisively take on Big Ag—until reality reared its ugly head.”

In February 2010, Obama announced her first major initiative as first lady: Let's Move, a public-health campaign aimed at lowering childhood-obesity rates in the U.S. Improving the nutritional quality of school meals nationwide was a centerpiece; for children living in poverty, those breakfasts and lunches could be their main source of sustenance. Conservatives instantly caught the scent of a culture war. Figures such as Sarah Palin and Fox News's Glenn Beck regularly fulminated against nanny statism and accused the Obamas of trying to overrule the sacred rights of American parents.

Some of the backlash was bipartisan. When Kass tried to eliminate a policy that offered White House employees free Coke—after all, the administration was trying to get the nation to drink less of it—Michelle



Obama's deputy chief of staff responded, "Over my dead body." And when Kass and the first lady spearheaded a national campaign to get people to drink more water, they were criticized by some of their public-health allies—Nestle among them—for not considering the environmental impact of plastic bottles.

The uproar, in retrospect, is illuminating. Food is deeply personal. Our natural response to being told what to eat is defensive: We tend to be attached to the foods we associate with family, comfort, and care. Obama had presumed that the straightforward changes that had worked for her family might benefit the wider public—and to her credit, she aimed to provide healthier meals for all American children, through broad institutional reform. Kass cites a study showing that the odds of poor children developing obesity would have been about 50 percent higher without the school-meal interventions. Crucially, though, childhood obesity was soon rising again. And Let's Move, rather than surging in popularity, was cast as elitist coercion, and Obama as the mean mommy forcing America to finish its vegetables.

In hindsight, Kass concludes, almost nothing Let's Move could have suggested would have pleased conservatives at the time. But he also infers that the biggest failure of Let's Move was one of communication. If you come across as instructing people on what to eat or, especially, what not to eat, you're more likely to prompt a raised middle finger than compliance. Slide gracefully into people's subconscious by enlisting the power of suggestion—visually presenting healthier products in a way that elicits an emotional response, say, or evokes a sense of home or prosperity—and you can help an idea take hold. There's a reason the MAHA movement caught fire as social-media use escalated. "Marketers will tell you this," Kass writes: "When you are trying to shift culture, seek out the influencers."

ONE THING that Big Food, and now MAHA moms, understands is that what we see fundamentally affects our attitudes about what we eat. In 2010, the same year that the Obamas were hustling to pass the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act, two software engineers debuted a photo-sharing app that they named Instagram, unwittingly ushering in a new hyper-visual food era of "serial virality," as Tandoh puts it. Three years later, when the French pastry chef Dominique Ansel debuted the cronut (a hybrid of French *pâtisserie* and American deep fat frying), Instagram had 100 million users, many of whom responded to photos of his concoction with ravenous abandon. "People just shared the cronut, a platonic torus of golden dough with a sugar-salt-fat ratio to please the gods," Tandoh writes. "Instead of spreading person to person through word of mouth, it spread exponentially, like a contagion."

The cronut wasn't remotely healthy, but it was totemic of food trends in the 2010s, as community bonding through photo sharing took off. While the Affordable Care Act fueled attacks on Democrats as the party of Big Health Care, an alternative subculture was gaining momentum. In September 2008, the Oscar-winning actor Gwyneth Paltrow launched Goop, a newsletter of recipes and recommendations intended to foster—and eventually monetize—a more intimate relationship with her fans.

Paltrow, who had lost her father to cancer, was now the mother of two young children, and believed passionately in the connection between food and health. "I am convinced that by eating biological foods it is possible to avoid the growth of tumors," she told an Italian newspaper, drawing fierce pushback from doctors and dieticians—but not from her audience. Paltrow seemed to intuit the mood of many women in the aftermath of the Great Recession: their concerns, their exhaustion, their eagerness for an escape from their own cramped kitchens offered by images of delightfully wholesome domesticity. Goop gave an

air of both glamour and accessibility to the kind of alternative lifestyle that had previously existed only on the crunchy fringes.

Since Goop's debut, the wellness market has ballooned and is now worth more than \$6 trillion, with the U.S. making up about a third of that figure. Paltrow's association of food with health helped instill in people's minds a connection between what they ate and how they felt. "I would rather smoke crack than eat cheese from a can," she told an interviewer in 2011. And mothers were especially vulnerable to this messaging. We worry endlessly; we (traditionally) manage doctor appointments and household budgets, to the tune of an estimated \$2 trillion a year in America.

Over the course of the 2010s, even as the Alice Waters-inspired farm-to-table cause of the 1980s was enjoying a boost from Pollan and company, a different cottage industry of food and wellness advocates gained influence online. It tapped into valid concerns about health in America, while also hyping fearful ideas about a contaminated state of modernity (ridden with parasites, carcinogens, and GMOs, as well as vaccines and prescription drugs). Zen Honeycutt, a pro-organic-farming and anti-vaccine activist—now one of many mom acolytes of Robert F. Kennedy Jr.—founded the pressure group Moms Across America in 2012. "We, the mothers who buy 85% of the food and we women who make 90% of household purchasing decisions, have the power to shift the marketplace and protect our people and the planet," the group's website proclaims.

In 2020, amid the anxiety and embattled politics of the pandemic, the 21st century's wellness fads, paranoid tendencies, and regressive gender dynamics consolidated. The horseshoe gap between leftist naturopaths and libertarian farmsteaders began to close, enabled by health influencers, podcasters, and the cheap thrill of algorithmic engagement. Today, the people most likely to be advocating online for slow food are homesteaders and tradwives, canny content creators who post reels of themselves churning butter and pulling dirt-dusted produce out of the soil.

YET YOU DON'T HAVE TO BE a homesteader to be anxious about the food systems and environments that your children grow up in. Many of us parents have been buying organic and baking from scratch and trying to get creamed spinach off upholstery since our kids were born. We give them whisks and make cooking time part of family time, and do our best to serve them fresh, colorful meals. Though we may rarely live up to Waters's edict about lovely food preparation and presentation—"Beauty is a language of care," as she writes in her new book, *A School Lunch Revolution*—there's always the joy of messy participation.

Today, the people most likely to be advocating online for slow food are homesteaders and tradwives.

What few of us have is the tradwife's luxury of retreating to the Instagrammed home, of opting out of an external reality where food conglomerates go unchecked and food deserts unchanged. "Don't overcomplicate it," the homesteader known online as Greenview Farms posted this summer, in text overlaying a video of a sunset. "Just marry your best friend, have his babies, spend your days on the land, plant a garden, get a few chickens and a cow, and live a simple life." (This surfaced in my feed, shared approvingly by a distant relative, a woman who—for the record—works in finance.)

If you overlook the very real public-health ramifications of vaccine hesitancy and raw milk, the rise of the MAHA movement might offer some promise. Trump "sounds just like me when he talks!" Marion Nestle exclaimed back in February, laughing at the absurdity of a hard-core McDonald's eater railing against "the industrial food complex." RFK Jr. and his merry band of mothers have, if nothing else, made the importance of good food in encouraging good health more prominent in our culture, and more bipartisan.

But unlike, say, Michelle Obama, MAHA proselytizers simply want moms to take on more responsibility, turning what should be a multifaceted effort into an atomized, individualistic one. The onus isn't on the administration to regulate food companies or restrict marketing to children. It is on mothers to obsess over what their families are eating.

The irony is that plenty of parents who don't dream of returning to the land are already on board for back-to-basics meals, made as manageable as possible. The Instagram account for Feeding Littles, which gives guidance on how to raise "adventurous, intuitive eaters," has 1.9 million followers. The most popular Substack newsletter under the category of food and drink is titled "What to Cook When You Don't Feel Like Cooking"; it dishes out quick, practical recipes oriented toward exhausted parents and has more than half a million subscribers. We care not just because we're fixated on health, or on our own homes. We're also reminding ourselves, and showing our kids, that eating is more than a solo need; it's a communal enterprise, one that thrives on dealing as carefully and fairly with food resources as we can. "You eat. Willingly or not you participate in the environment of food choice," Nestle writes toward the end of her new book. "The choices you make about food are as much about the kind of world you want to live in as they are about what to have for lunch." *A*

Sophie Gilbert is a staff writer at The Atlantic and the author of Girl on Girl: How Pop Culture Turned a Generation of Women Against Themselves.

Yesterday's Idea of a Modern Man

Sam Shepard, a self-made cowboy, was also a poet of masculine angst.

By Michael O'Donnell



Sam Shepard wasn't born a cowboy. The actor and writer made himself into one. The dusty blue jeans, cattle drives, and folksy drawl suited his taciturn profile, giving Reagan-era America someone rugged to admire. Yet the people who knew Shepard best poked fun at his Western persona, which began to emerge in the 1970s and endured for the rest of his life. The singer and poet Patti Smith, a former paramour, called him "a man playing cowboys," and Shepard indeed acted in a number of Westerns. Late in his career, in Andrew Dominik's movie *The Assassination of Jesse James by the Coward Robert Ford*, Shepard portrayed the outlaw's prickly brother. (He'd named his first child, Jesse, after the legend.) A line of narration from the movie seemed to sum up the complicated man behind the character: "wrought up, perplexed, despondent."

The cowboy image may have been cultivated, but it was not false. You might say it was earned, the vaquero as self-made man. Shepard—reluctant movie star, poet of masculine angst, and rock-and-roll hero of the American theater—thought Broadway and Hollywood were full of middlebrow nonsense. Born in suburban Illinois and raised in Southern California, he sought out an authentic country, far from New York City or Los Angeles, where he could hear himself think. He found it in Kentucky, New Mexico, and Texas, places where he lived or set his stories. Framing his work in elemental terms of self-sufficiency, Shepard considered his analog tools: "When you go to ride a horse, you have to saddle it. When you use a typewriter, you have to feed it paper." Like his friend Cormac McCarthy—who grew up in a Tennessee suburb but likewise drifted west—Shepard found in open spaces a wellspring of bracing truth.

He was yesterday's idea of a modern man: strong but vulnerable, brooding until he had something profound to say, deeply flawed but right when it counted. Shepard's plays are full of

anxiety, uncertainty, violence, and the raw friction that pushes men and women, fathers and sons, further away from each other in the grappling match of family life. How does Shepard's version of manhood look now that he's gone and the era of the embittered, rage-prone MAGA male has arrived? One insight comes early in a penetrating new biography, *Coyote: The Dramatic Lives of Sam Shepard*, when the author, Robert M. Dowling, asserts, "Fear is the guiding principle of Shepard's work"—fear of specters such as failure, heredity, and abandonment. A key difference between a man like Shepard and today's dismal exemplars of hypermasculinity is that his currency was guilt, whereas now the watchword is *resentment*. The former internalizes blame, forging stoics, while the latter assigns it elsewhere, yielding brats. Shepard was open about his fears and spent his life trying to understand them. He did not sharpen them into weapons to use on others.

COYOTE IS NOT the first biography of Shepard, but it is finally the one that an artist of his stature deserves. Dowling, a theater scholar who has also written a celebrated life of Eugene O'Neill, treats Shepard first and foremost as a writer. "Writing centered him, and without it, he said, he was lost," Dowling observes; he movingly ends the narrative with an ailing Shepard racing to complete his last book, *Spy of the First Person*, before his death in 2017. *Coyote* also benefits from extensive access to Shepard's intimates, who have avoided prior biographers, as well as to his journals and correspondence, which Dowling quotes to illuminating effect. "Not having a play to write," Shepard wrote in his notebook, "is like being without a friend, homeless, in a state of wandering."

The figure looming over Shepard from the time of childhood was his father, who flew bombing runs across Europe during World War II. An annihilating alcoholic, Sam Sr. had a violent temper and an inability to cope with the compromises and disappointments of postwar life. Shepard inherited his father's temper and his thirst. Sam Sr. beat his son and deserted the family, eventually going on a years-long bender, spending time in prison, and dying bitter and alone. By contrast, Shepard's mother was a steady, reassuring presence. After Sam Jr. found success as a playwright, his father wrote to him, "I don't understand what the hell you're writing. I can't make hide nor hair of this shit, but I have to congratulate you nevertheless." Sam Sr. attended only one of his son's plays, in 1980, and had to be escorted out after drunkenly shouting at the actors from his seat. "This is not the way it was!" he cried. "He knew because he was in it," Shepard later remarked.

Previous page:
Sam Shepard as
Eddie, a rodeo stunt
rider, in the film
adaptation of his play
Fool for Love

Shepard was open about his fears and spent his life trying to understand them. He did not sharpen them into weapons to use on others.

Little wonder that the old man objected. Shepard wrote versions of his father into many of his dramas, including the Pulitzer Prize-winning *Buried Child*—the one Sam Sr. tried to shout down. In the play, the father figure, Tilden, is described as a man "profoundly burned out and displaced"; at one point, he impotently asks his own father for a drink of the whiskey that the old man keeps stashed under the sofa. In *Curse of the Starving Class*, the character Weston rails to his son about a man who may have run off with his wife. "He's not counting on what's in my blood. He doesn't realize the explosiveness." The most haunting echo of Sam Sr. comes in a short autofictional Shepard story that deals with a father's death. The narrator finds an unsent letter addressed to him that ends, "You may think this great calamity that happened, way back when—this so-called disaster between me and your mother—you might actually think that it had something to do with you, but you're dead wrong. Whatever took place between me and her was strictly personal. See you in my dreams."

Buried Child and *Curse of the Starving Class* arrived during Shepard's most artistically successful period, from the late '70s to the mid-'80s. During this magical stretch, he enjoyed a popular and critical glow; he co-wrote the screenplay for the Palme d'Or-winning film *Paris, Texas* and finished three of his best dramas: *True West*, *Fool for Love*, and *A Lie of the Mind*. He also portrayed the pilot Chuck Yeager on-screen in *The Right Stuff* in 1983 and appeared on the cover of *Newsweek* in 1985, looking cool and tough in a cowboy hat and aviators—an image that caused him to wince at being presented as *the* cowboy. He simply wanted to be one.

True West was Shepard's favorite, and it covers the themes that preoccupied him most. A story of two brothers, a bourgeois striver and a tempestuous wanderer, who gradually trade places over two acts, *True West* explores success, failure, aggression, the empty desert, the myth of the West, the inescapability of family, and the archetypal old man somewhere offstage, ruining his life. Made famous by a 1982 production at Chicago's Steppenwolf Theatre starring John Malkovich and directed by Gary Sinise, the play is fierce, absurd, hilarious, and, above all, American. It splits Shepard's persona into a Jekyll-and-Hyde pair and flays masculinity for all to see. "There's nothing wrong with real *machismo*," Shepard told an interviewer a few years after the Steppenwolf production. "The original idea must have had its roots in what at one time was a sense of real courage in the face of danger; but it's been so distorted that it's now mostly externalized behavior that actually has to do with *pretending*, with *covering up*, with *fear*."

SHEPARD WROTE some 60 plays, and he occasionally missed. His golden years were sandwiched between an early, protean period of experimental work, such as *La Turista* (1967) and *Operation Sidewinder* (1970), and a later decline in the '90s and 2000s that saw more pans and fewer raves as his work began to feel repetitive and struggled to maintain its energy and edge. One critic wrote that Shepard had returned to warring family characters so often “that they’ve become icons rather than people.” To pay the bills, Shepard turned to film acting.

The parts that arrived—and what he did with them—embodied his unique take on the tough but thoughtful American man. In *The Right Stuff*, Shepard’s Yeager keeps flying planes after his fellow test pilots go off to join the flashy space program; they drive fast cars while he rides a horse. In 2001’s *Black Hawk Down*, he portrays General William Garrison, the commander of U.S. forces in Mogadishu during a fiasco that led to the deaths of 18 American soldiers and hundreds of Somalis. Instead of joining the troops in exciting battle sequences, Shepard’s Garrison sits in a room and debates the morality of humanitarian intervention. When a Somali character refers to “Arkansas white boys,” Shepard replies with a grin, “Well, I wouldn’t know about that. I’m from Texas.”

On top of his searing plays, these turns on-screen and glimpses from Shepard’s private writing reveal a healthy dose of self-awareness: a surprising trait for a cowboy. He agonized over his failures as a husband and father. Joni Mitchell immortalized Shepard’s wandering eye and general irresistibility in her song “Coyote,” about their love affair. (“Now he’s got a woman at home / He’s got another woman down the hall / He seems to want me anyway.”) After walking out on his wife, O-Lan Jones, and their son for a torrid love affair with Jessica Lange, he wrote in a letter, “The thing that hurts me most is knowing I abandoned everyone.” But he could not do otherwise: “I feel like I’ve found the love of my life, which is like some kind of miracle.”

The relationship with Lange lasted nearly three decades, through much passion and many fights, ending after Shepard followed his father’s path into alcoholism and isolation. This was his greatest fear, and it carried the weight of inevitability. Shepard perceived



Shepard as the pilot
Chuck Yeager in *The
Right Stuff*

that masculinity was what ultimately drove Lange away. In an unpublished essay, he imagined that when the two first met, she thought, “He drives his truck like a real man. (She’s been driving with Mercedes men.) He stays at the Motel 6. (She’s been staying at the Bel-Air.) He smokes and drinks like a fish. She finds that exotic.” But by the end, “she can’t stand him ’cause he’s such a man. In her eyes he drives his truck like a macho fool.”

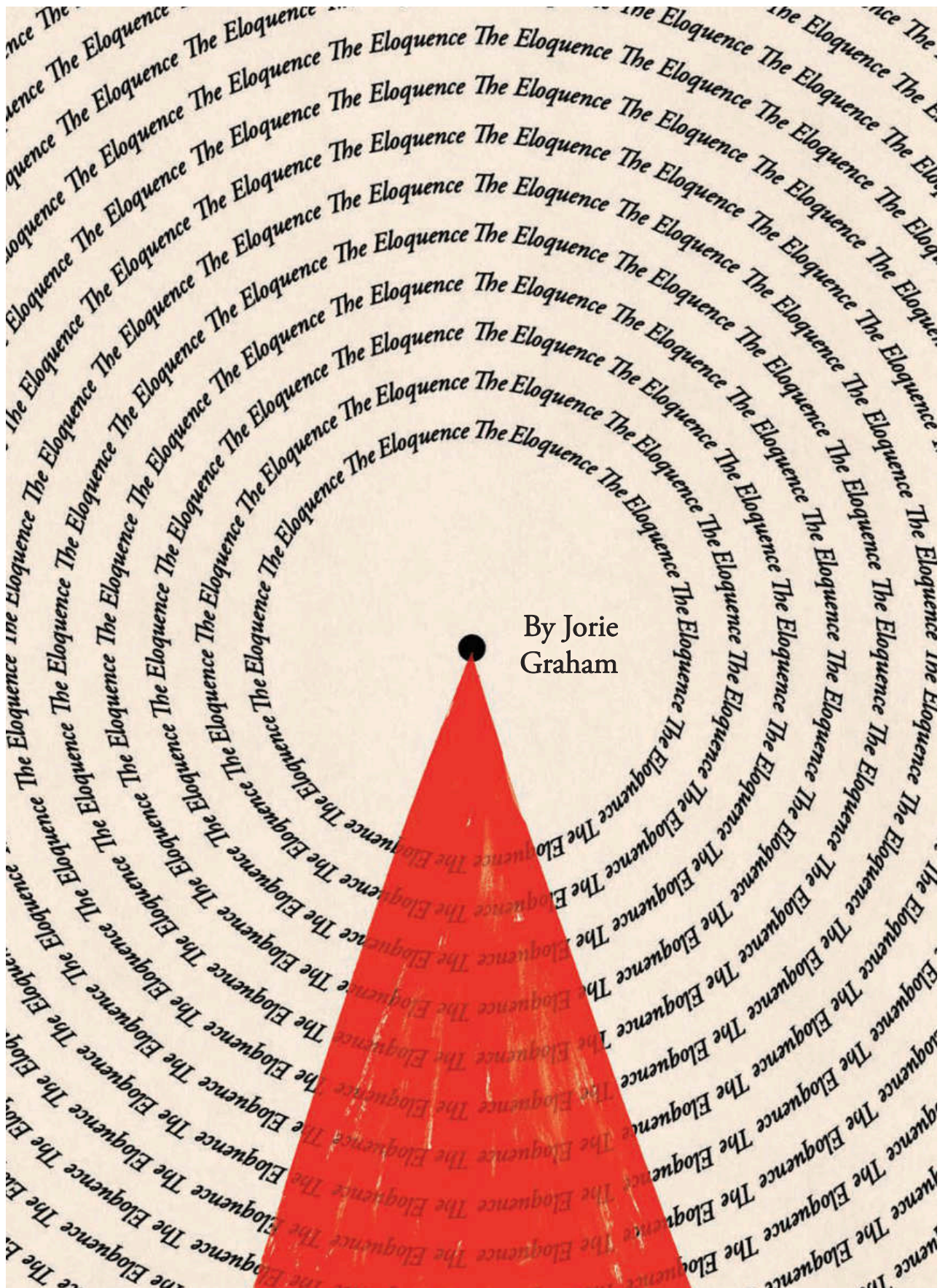
Self-awareness will take a man a long way, offsetting his pride and blunting his tendency to become ridiculous. Yet, as Dowling’s excellent biography demonstrates, self-awareness alone will not solve the underlying conundrum of modern existence. How to avoid the mistakes of one’s parents, find solitude as well as human connection, survive in a violently polarized country, and deal with the absurdity and pain of life? Shepard could pose these questions in his dramas but could no more answer them than any other artist. Knowing who you are does not mean knowing what to do. As Cormac McCarthy wrote, “Between the wish and the thing the world lies waiting.” Like his fellow first-generation westerner, Shepard answered life’s mysteries with diamond-hard writing. The world is a little clearer, though no less perplexing, because of his words. *A*

COYOTE:
THE DRAMATIC
LIVES OF
SAM SHEPARD

Robert M.
Dowling

SCRIBNER

Michael O'Donnell is a critic and the author of *Above the Fire*. His next novel, *Concert Black*, will be published in April.



By Jorie
Graham

The prime minister was watching a disaster movie
 when we found him. We are the
 media we cried. Run.
 The insiders ran around wildly looking for the exits.
 On the face of the deep the ghosts of civilization wailed.
 The shadow of a doubt dissolved,
 everyone just trying to understand how what happened
 happened. Figuring out *how* became the choicest
 profession. Don't misunderstand us—
 we always obeyed the unwritten rules, we always respected
 the number of minutes
 allotted for the interview—always believed in the existence of
 the singular reason
 for the world's incomprehensible
 demise. It was not our job
 to notice the rain
 no longer fell,
 we were busy tracking who was logging in and logging out
 of the current war
 while new faces of God made their appearances
 behind our backs
 as always.
 We checked on our stringers.
 We called in to get a reading on the deathwatch.
 You're breaking up.
 Can you give me 50 words
 The calendar lit up
 with the dates when each thing of value would
 no longer exist.
 We reported it
 exactly,
 the idea was to leave no trace in our language
 of grief, regret,
 despair. Not a trace of us
 must remain.
 But where can our lives be hidden we thought
 as we hurried from telling to telling,
 permeated with absence.
 Then it began to close in all round us, the dry weather of
 information.
 Once I looked up at the clouds as if I'd never felt wind before—
 no it did not rain, but I
 almost remembered the smell—
 whose list are *our* names on—
 we who have passes with access to *all* the realities—
 when will the bullets cross through *us*—
 we who mistake narrative
 for history ...
 If there is peace we are less busy so not to be trusted.
 Those of us whose wounds are still healing

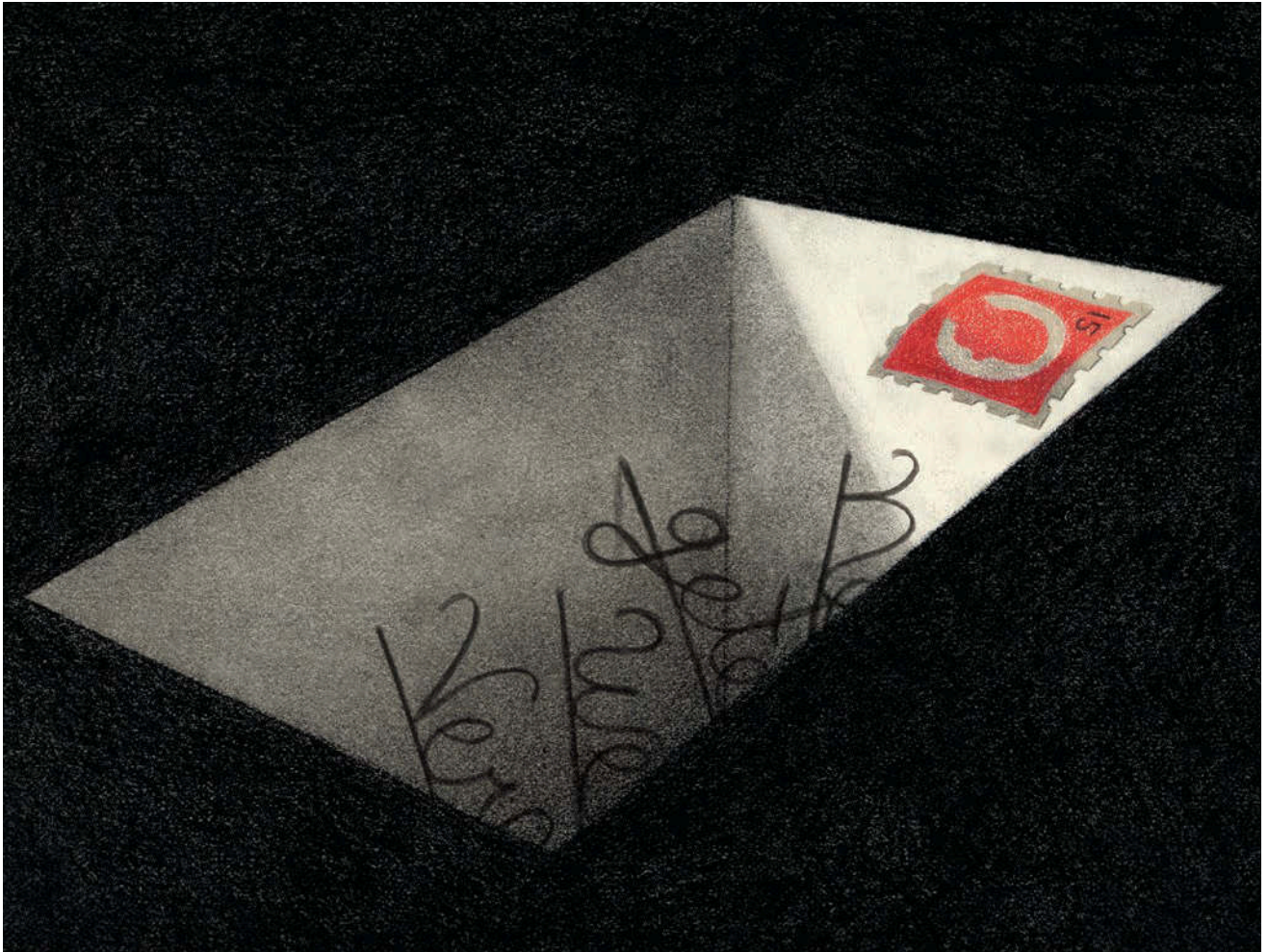
will tell u that story
again & again.
The smell of a newborn escapes us.
The ozone approaching escapes us.
We are part of an occupation whose aims
escape us.
We do not write in order to remember.
Language flows through us—no angles, no corners, no
bends—never an
impasse. As for the past
that is not our business. The prime minister
is now hanging from his rope.
We must report the cries and the laughter, the mood of
the crowd. We never ask
about the strangeness.
But the strangeness is starting to stare at us.
It seems to seethe. We hurry to get it down.
And now it is eloquence which stares at us furiously.
Its gaze reminds us of something—
the scent of ozone rises—
there is thunder is there not—
it's hard to know. We are on deadline.

The killing spree began one day in the suburbs.
It was the first day of its life so at first it cried out.
It tried to move swiftly into the past—but we
got its essence down before it slipped away
into the here-to-stay
where it could hide,
where it could become perpetual.
We didn't report how the trees were bleeding,
how people's pockets filled up with ash,
how strangers' organs ended up on our doorsteps
in baskets, like fish from the market,
slippery & gleaming.
We were becoming watchmen, awake in our sleep.
As the killing developed it needed a sense of direction.
We listened for where the cries were coming from,
the north wind became a stringer,
the south wind brought us the death rattles,
bullets whirled like hummingbirds when there were hummingbirds,
the gold & green ones,
sometimes the ruby-throated ...
You'd find traces that made for good copy—
once broken teeth—many handfuls—in the grassblades in the alley,
sometimes severed fingers, sometimes a whole hand,
you could become emotional if you weren't careful,
but we were careful,
the feeling of living—had we ever had it—
it has been so long now & we are exhausted—
souls like froth in the shorebreak—

movements of men in mud.
 Once I heard clapping behind a wall,
 but for whom or what.
 I know it is my job
 but the seasons have blurred.
 What I wouldn't give for a single voice
 telling a story to a child,
 & knowing the story to be true,
 for the look on the face of that listener
 hearing it all for the first time—
 who we were once, how we slowly lost our
 way—but told as a fable,
 with lists of the creatures which had lived in forests, in
 oceans, & with slow description,
 eloquent & calm, of what oceans were
 & what rivers were, & forests, & dream ...
 I am listening & hiding & my heart is outstretched
 as the news of the battle arrives & I must rise to report it,
 to card out the rumors,
 how much land gained,
 how much land lost,
 my voice must reach you with this report,
 the story of how it all will have been worth it
 to create our new world
 where we will rebuild the cities
 where we will drain the blood from the fields
 where grasses will once again grow into wind.
 I know I speak of suffering I am supposed to speak of suffering.
 And how this is the threshold,
 it is always the threshold ...

Sometimes in the evening the twilight sinks so low as if to
 lie in ambush
 & its long golden body enters our houses
 where we are bent over our notes,
 cleaning up our drafts ...
 As it sinks below the clouds the light slides in even further.
 I do not dare turn around to see it.
 I think I feel it touching my neck,
 tapping my shoulder.
 I almost hear its voice
 moving too easily through the empty branches.
 And I envy the poets who are free to cry out
 as I turn in my copy, the day's final report,
 unless one more incendiary device goes off
 and I have to revise again how many managed to get out in time.
 It is never many.
 It is meant to be none.

*Jorie Graham's Killing Spree is forthcoming in the spring. Her collection
 The Dream of the Unified Field won the 1996 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry.*



BOOKS

How Terror Works

A 1947 German novel explores the sometimes corrosive, sometimes energizing nature of fear.

By Hillary Kelly

In 24 days during the fall of 1946, a German novelist known as Hans Fallada produced a rare, and now especially timely, literary touchstone: a humane depiction of muted resistance. *Every Man Dies Alone* was based on a Gestapo file detailing the case of a Berlin couple who had run an illicit two-year postcard-writing campaign aimed at rebutting Hitler's propaganda. The novel was published in 1947—part of a postwar effort to start de-Nazifying German literature.

Mere weeks before his book came out, Rudolf Ditzgen (Fallada was a pen name) died at 53, weakened after a long struggle with alcoholism and morphine addiction. He'd faced criminal trouble too (he had shot and killed a friend in a botched suicide pact in adolescence, been twice convicted of embezzlement, and in 1944 been detained in a psychiatric hospital after pulling a gun on his wife). His literary credentials were also vexed. After winning recognition as a promising novelist in the early 1930s, Fallada was labeled an "undesirable author" by the newly installed Nazi regime. Later, in a letter to a friend, he confessed to complicity with the government, admitting that, under threat from Hitler's chief propagandist, Joseph Goebbels, he'd altered a novel to

have a character join the Nazi Party. Unsurprisingly, Fallada was preoccupied with gray areas in his final book.

His version of the couple in the Gestapo file, whom he names Otto and Anna Quangel, draft a vivid postcard after their only son dies in combat: “Mother! The Führer has murdered my son. Mother, the Führer will murder your sons too, he will not stop till he has brought sorrow to every home in the world” is the message they leave in the stairwell of an office building across town, hoping the card will be picked up and shared. Soon, they’re writing and delivering a fresh card or two every week to other addresses in Berlin.

They’re well aware that their fellow Germans might be repelled by the postcards: “Everyone’s frightened nowadays.” Earlier, in their own apartment building, the Quangels themselves had been silent bystanders when tragedy befell an elderly Jewish neighbor, a woman who can’t bear the constraints of living shut away. A jittery Frau Rosenthal flees the hiding place provided by a kind neighbor and returns to her flat, only to leap out her kitchen window to her death when she’s confronted by a Gestapo agent who’s been tipped off by a loathsome Nazi neighbor. “We don’t know anything. We haven’t seen or heard anything,” Otto admonishes his wife as officials gather at the scene.

Now, after their own loss, hopes for their enterprise run high: They distribute the cards so broadly and for so long that it seems they may never get caught. “In the end,” Otto exclaims, “scores of people, hundreds, will be sitting down and writing cards like us. We will inundate Berlin with postcards, we will slow the machines, we will depose the Führer, end the war.”

The Quangels’ dream of overthrowing the regime from within gives *Every Man Dies Alone* an inspirational core. Lauded for its portrayal of defiance—Primo Levi called it “the greatest book ever written about German resistance to the Nazis”—it was celebrated anew in 2009 with the arrival, finally, of an English translation by Michael Hofmann, accompanied by biographical and critical commentary in an afterword by the scholar Geoff Wilkes. Fallada’s examination of a social microcosm—one apartment building’s residents in 1940s Berlin—spreads out to encompass the whole city. Capturing both the upright and the compromised, the forceful and the reluctant, the novel becomes a nuanced portrait of the sometimes corrosive, sometimes energizing nature of fear. As Wilkes underscores, *Every Man Dies Alone* excels at describing something far subtler and harder to discern than staunch resistance: the plight of ordinary Germans at the moment of their greatest moral trial. How, in a climate of absolute fear, do people weigh the decision between rebellion and accommodation? How do they hold on to a sense of decency but also stay alive?

How, in a climate of absolute fear, do people weigh the decision between rebellion and accommodation?

FEATURING A CROSS SECTION of citizenry—pet-shop owners and postal workers, petty criminals and recalcitrant resisters, Gestapo inspectors and persecuted Jews—the novel operates in a haze of daily, lingering dread. The major consequences of relatively minor offenses loom large, as Fallada understood firsthand. By 1940, the year the novel begins, Nazi Party machinery was omnipresent in civilian life. All Germans—not just Jews or Communists or political radicals—were one conversation away from turning informant or resister. Donations to organizations such as the Winter Relief Fund (a charitable front for Nazi fundraising, and one of Otto’s favorite targets in his postcards) were viewed as barometers of one’s fealty. Membership in the Deutsche Arbeitsfront, ostensibly a nationwide union but really a mechanism for keeping a close eye on workers, was practically mandatory for a factory foreman like Otto. A refusal to join the party landed you in its crosshairs, and potentially a labor camp. As Fallada writes, “You could see it with your eyes closed, the way they were making separations between ordinary citizens and party members. Even the worst party member was worth more to them than the best ordinary citizen.”

Agencies such as the Gestapo and the SS (Schutzstaffel, a onetime paramilitary group that became responsible for security and surveillance) overtly monitor and menace Fallada’s Germans. One woman being grilled by a gleeful Nazi is told to leave her husband a note reading, “I’ve popped out to the Gestapo. Don’t know when I’ll be back.” She promptly agrees to become “an eager, unpaid, and invaluable spy.” Others, such as a bartender who ignores a directive to inform on a patron, quietly balk. “On the one hand you were afraid of the Gestapo and lived in constant fear of them,” the narrator observes, “but it was something else to do their dirty work for them.” Civil disobedience is muffled, but gut feelings can prompt small acts of resistance.

The Quangels’ own act of resistance, they realize, could get them killed. But Fallada does not endow them with purely heroic, self-sacrificial fiber. Neither husband nor wife has joined the Nazi Party, though until their son is killed at the front, Otto “has been a believer in the Führer’s honest intentions. One just had to strip away the corrupt hangers-on and the parasites, who were just out for themselves, and everything would get better.” (Fallada himself didn’t become a party member, although he enrolled his son in the Hitler Youth.)

Self-interest sways the Quangels too: Both credit the führer with having helped them manage financially in the mid-1930s, when Otto was out of work. A chapter that was removed from the novel before its publication (but restored after Fallada’s German publishing house rediscovered it in 2011) reveals Anna’s record as a “completely reliable woman” and one of the

“hardest workers” in the National Socialist Women’s Organization—before she wrangles her way out of her membership. Fallada highlights the sudden shift in the Quangels’ perspective after their son’s death. The more invested they became in their writing campaign, he explains,

the more mistakes by the Führer and his Party they discovered. Things that when they first had happened had struck them as barely censurable, such as the suppression of all other political parties, or things that they had condemned as merely excessive in degree or too vigorously carried out, like the persecution of the Jews.

One of Fallada’s characters is implausibly angelic, but he isn’t interested in static good or evil. In his pages, righteousness alone rarely motivates opposition to the Nazis. Like the Quangels, some in the novel have become disenchanted with the government after facing personal loss. For others, such as an acclaimed actor who has a trivial disagreement with his friend Goebbels about their opinion of a film and subsequently gets blacklisted, outrage isn’t so much principled as entitled; he’s now “over, chum, finished,” his formerly glamorous life gone. Still others simply think they are canny enough to avoid the brunt of the party’s wrath.

No one who resists, as Wilkes notes in his afterword, leaves a lasting mark. A postal carrier who quits the Nazi Party escapes punishment—but her act of defiance makes no meaningful difference. A low-level con artist who is wrongly accused of distributing the postcards will not concede his guilt; he ends up dead of a self-inflicted gunshot wound after being given the choice between that and drowning. The members of a small, rebellious cell who begin the novel with grand plans to take down the government end up ineffective and disbanded. And like their real-life counterparts, Otto and Anna are caught, convicted in a sham trial, and sentenced to death by guillotine; their postcards also have none of their intended impact. As treasonous objects, they stir resentment and undermine solidarity. Of the 276 cards the Quangels write, 259 are immediately handed over to the Gestapo. A doctor, after finding one in the hall by his office, thinks, “What a selfish and unscrupulous fellow, this postcard writer, plunging people into such difficulties! Didn’t he think of the trouble he would cause with those confounded cards!”

THE TROUBLE, of course, is the point. What makes *Every Man Dies Alone* so compelling, and unsettling, is its demonstration that an oppressive political sphere works in deeply personal ways. Interactions with the state do not have foregone conclusions—citizens still operate as individuals and make impulsive, sometimes self-sabotaging decisions. Nowhere is that more

evident than in the case of Inspector Escherich, the Gestapo agent tasked with finding the writer of the postcards. A former police detective who carries on with his work for the German state simply because he is “a lover of the chase,” he comes to life more fully than any other character in the novel.

Escherich believes himself different from ordinary Nazis—he disdains their midday drinking and derides their lack of intelligence. But as the Javert to the Quangels’ Jean Valjean, he is on the hunt for the perpetrators of a relatively petty crime. And like Javert, he falls victim to his overconfidence. Even after he has failed for months to apprehend the postcard writer, he insolently shrugs off his superiors’ reproaches (*Go find another man for the job*, he taunts them). In response, his supervisor orders him confined to one of the Gestapo’s infamous basement cells, where he “became so thoroughly acquainted with fear that now there is no chance of him forgetting it for as long as he lives.” Escherich is later released and put back on the case, but his ordeal leaves him bitter toward his overlords and newly respectful of the Quangels’ fervor and determination. He cannot bring himself to actually resist, but he also cannot fully comply. He is, like many Germans, stuck between two impossible options.

The German authorities relied on terror, even toward party members, to keep their citizenry in line. But where they erred, as Fallada writes, was in “the assumption that all Germans were cowards.” No German freedom fighters brought down the government, no anti-propaganda mission persuaded the people to rise up en masse against their tyrants; it took a world war to knock Hitler from his perch. Yet some Germans, Fallada shows, found ways to surmount their fear and assert their moral integrity in acts of dissidence, even if they could not topple the regime.

Every Man Dies Alone is more than an engrossing cat-and-mouse tale. Tracking the interior dodging and weaving of his characters too, Fallada delivers valuable insight into the varieties of mental resistance to autocracy. The quietest kinds of opposition—what we read, what we think, what we believe—can keep autocrats paranoid, distrustful, ill at ease. Rising above cowardice can inoculate us against complicity, as some German citizens showed. And speaking out, even surreptitiously and unsuccessfully, stands in stark contrast to remaining silent. As a young woman explains to Otto before he begins his postcard counterattack, “The main thing is that we remain different from them, that we never allow ourselves to be made into them, or start thinking as they do. Even if they conquer the whole world, we must refuse to become Nazis.” *A*

Hillary Kelly is a literary critic and an essayist.

EVERY MAN
DIES ALONE

Hans Fallada

MELVILLE HOUSE

PROMOTIONPROMOTION

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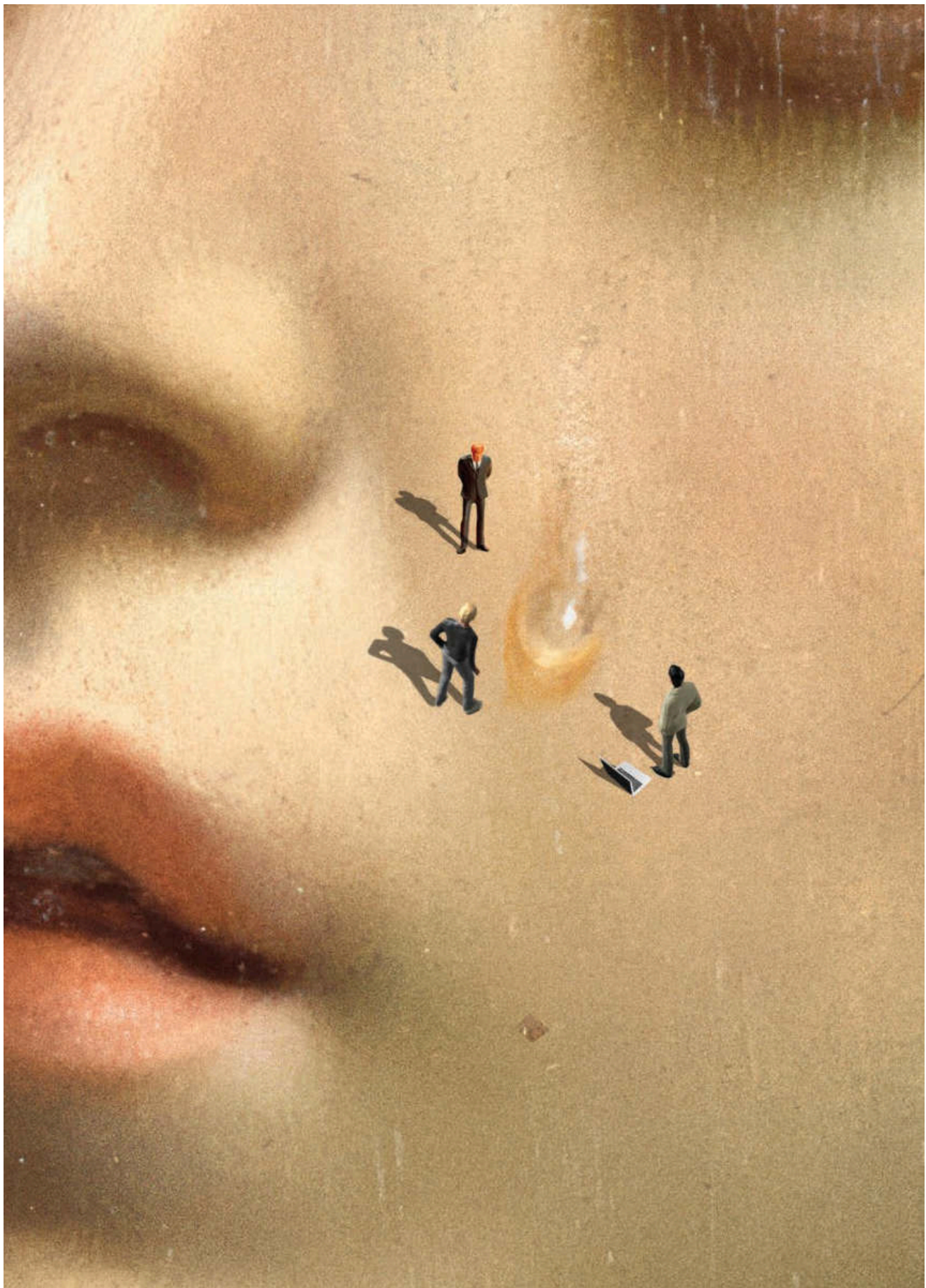
You Had to Be There

*An emerging field
of history asks if
we can ever really
understand how our
forebears experienced
love, anger, fear,
and sorrow.*

By Gal
Beckerman

Illustrations by
Nicolás Ortega

The historian Rob Boddice sat cross-legged on his couch in Montreal on a frigid day last winter and conjured for me the image of a medieval carpenter, hammering away in his workshop. “Imagine this guy; he’s building a table,” he said. Suddenly the carpenter misses the nail and bangs his thumb instead. “What did that feel like for him?” Boddice asked. I stared for a few seconds while Boddice smiled encouragingly, as if he’d



just asked me to solve a quadratic equation in my head. “I guess it probably stung, and then his thumb throbbed?” I ventured, remembering actually banging my own thumb a few weeks back while assembling an IKEA desk. Boddice nodded, then said, “Let me ask you again. What did it feel like for *him*?”

Boddice is an energetic 48-year-old academic who has stormed the field of the history of emotions and senses, a specialized branch that has grown significantly over the past two decades even as most others (such as military and medieval history) have been pruned. Working for the past few years out of an institute he helped found—the Centre of Excellence in the History of Experiences, colloquially known as HEX, housed at Tampere University, in Finland—Boddice has tried to steer this area of study in a radical direction. “Emotions and senses” refers to history focused less on the facts of the past than on its more ineffable qualities, such as the smells of a 19th-century city filled with thousands of horses, and the quality of grief expressed in the letters of widows during World War I. Boddice is interested in a deeper, more expansive concept that encompasses everything about how reality is perceived, melding together emotions and senses and much else into an engagement with “experience.”

For starters, he has little patience for the standard (and impoverished, if you ask him) assumptions about feelings, such as the idea that they come in six basic universal flavors—happiness, sadness, fear, anger, surprise, and disgust. In the 1960s and ’70s, the psychologist Paul Ekman identified these six emotions, which he thought were hardwired into every human. This perception is still fairly embedded in our culture. Just consider the success of Pixar’s *Inside Out*, Boddice suggests, which anthropomorphized some of these distinct sentiments as cartoon characters (anger, for example, is squat and red, and has a head that ignites like a furnace) pulling levers behind a console inside our minds. Much of the social-skills curricula for elementary-school children are built around the same idea: choose from a list of prepackaged emoji ranging from smiley to frowny. There is nothing unusual about a

desire to distill and name emotions in this way. For one thing, it might be the source of empathy. Having a shared “happy” that refers to what you are feeling and what I am feeling seems essential to relationships, and probably also to building any kind of human society.

But as a historian trying to comprehend feelings, Boddice can’t stand those cute *Inside Out* characters. Because not only do we imagine other people to have the exact same set of emotions that we have, but we project this thought backwards through time. Love for us can’t be that different from what it meant to Heloise and Abelard writing letters to each other in the 12th century. The laborers who hauled stones to build the pyramids in Giza felt anger that is our anger. We perform this projection on any number of human experiences: losing a child, falling ill, being bored at work. We assume that emotions in the past are accessible because we assume that at their core, people in the past were just like us, with slight tweaks for their choice of hats and standards of personal hygiene.

Boddice starts with the opposite premise, that we are not the same—that the experience of being human in another era, with all of its component feelings and perceptions, even including something as elemental as pain, is so foreign to us as to live inside a kind of sealed vault. “There is nothing about my humanness that affords me insight into humanity,” Boddice has said. Rather than being a constant—extending across space and time—human nature for Boddice is a variable and unstable category, one with infinite possible shades.

“DOWN WITH EMPATHY,” Boddice said when we met in Montreal, the snow falling outside the window in Mount Royal Park. “I want a T-shirt with that on it.” Boddice has a slim build and a rangy restlessness. His face is boyish despite the crow’s-feet beginning to splay out from the corners of his eyes. He’s eager to show that he has a life beyond writing books—a guitar collection (including a Fender Telecaster and a Gibson Les Paul) rested on stands in an otherwise spare living room, and he wore a marathoner’s bulky running

watch. When he is not in Finland, he lives in Montreal with his wife, Stephanie Olsen, also a researcher at HEX (she has studied children’s dream narratives), and their 8-year-old son.

The idea of “experiential relativity,” as Boddice calls it—a recent paper also referred to his approach as “historical neurodiversity”—might seem squishy and postmodern. It’s a kind of thinking that questions whether anything is real—the sort of speculation that might emerge from a dorm room late at night. The reaction is understandable. But Boddice is interested in some very real things: the brain and the body, and the way they interact with culture to produce experience. His approach reminded me of the philosopher William James, who also didn’t believe that human emotions are “sacramental or eternally fixed,” as he wrote in his 1890 book, *The Principles of Psychology*. Whereas the prevailing thought was that an internal feeling generates outward response—*I’m sad, therefore I cry*—James thought the causality was all wrong. In his schema, what happens first is an external stimulus. This triggers a bodily response, and only then does an internal process of interpretation assign meaning to that response. I might see a sunset and find tears springing to my eyes, and then my mind will interpret this as missing my father, with whom I last witnessed a sunset. Because of this variability of response and interpretation, James wrote, “there is no limit to the number of possible different emotions which may exist, and why the emotions of different individuals may vary indefinitely.”

Unlike James, who was simply intuiting what happens inside our heads, Boddice is layering his own thinking on top of the most recent advances in neuroscience, which have proved just how plastic our minds really are, in much the way James assumed. How a particular brain assigns meaning has to do with a person’s prior experiences—what Lisa Feldman Barrett, the director of the Interdisciplinary Affective Science Laboratory at Northeastern University and the author of *How Emotions Are Made*, calls its “concepts and categories.” The brain, Barrett told me, is trapped in the skull, “a dark, silent box,” so it has to make predictions by drawing

on those concepts and categories, which are “very, very different by culture—even the concept of what an emotion is varies by culture.” This helps the brain predict and hone its perceptions, and these are very much related to concepts tied to a time and place. The process all leads to what the behavioral neurologist Marsel Mesulam has called our “highly edited subjective version of the world.” In other words, there is no spot in our heads where a Platonic (or emoji) version of sadness or happiness resides. Feelings are not determined; they are created. And this is true for even something as seemingly universal as pain.

Let’s return to that medieval carpenter. He has banged his thumb, triggering his nociceptors, or pain receptors—which should really be called “harm receptors,” Boddice said, because all they do is send a signal up to the brain that damage has occurred. They don’t themselves cause pain. To understand what the carpenter experiences, then, we need to begin with a series of questions that might help us reconstruct the meaning produced once the signal reaches its destination. Does this happen a lot? Is the sensation of hitting his thumb a daily or weekly occurrence—something that goes with the job? And then, if religion infused every second of his life, as might very well be true for a medieval carpenter, where would his concept of suffering come from? Does he think about Christ and perhaps feel purified? If suffering, sin, and love are conjoined in an idea of the divine in the carpenter’s brain, and these are “lived connections,” Boddice said, “and you’re surrounded by them,” how might he feel when that hammer hits his thumb?

It no longer seems so simple as just saying “pain.” We cannot put the carpenter in an MRI machine—we will never have total access to his feelings—but by building out his world in all of its dimensions, Boddice believes, we can get closer to appreciating the specificity of those feelings. This points to another radical element of Boddice’s thinking: To re-create an experience, you need to know all of the conditions that may have led the brain to originally create it, and this means bringing dozens of different academic disciplines to bear

on the task, getting fields that don’t usually mingle to interact with one another.

Art history might give insight into what visual representations a person might have been surrounded by; the study of theology might help establish an ideological framework for how they understood their place in the universe; archaeology might reveal what their relationship was like to their material environment. This is the kind of imaginative work that historical novelists usually do, except Boddice wants to scrape the archives to build out a 360-degree understanding based on historical fact. If you know anything about how narrow the categories of academia can be, you can

In a manifesto of sorts, Boddice makes his claim with the gusto and certainty of a Silicon Valley entrepreneur: “What we propose is a disruption of what it is and means to be human.”

probably see why this is a little dreamy on his part, but it’s also how, he thinks, we can fully unlock the great diversity of ways in which people once moved through reality.

Pain has a particular interest for Boddice, and was the subject of his 2023 book, *Knowing Pain*, which he opened with his own experience of having a herniated disc when he was 17 (and his encounter with a physical therapist who kept pressing her thumbs into his neck and demanding, “Is *that* your pain?”). At first, it seems counterintuitive to think of pain as anything other than universal—the same everywhere, and at all times. Yet anyone who has ever been asked to describe their pain to a doctor knows that we are at the

mercy of language. Is it sharp or dull? Does it pound or burn? These are metaphors, and ones that culture gives us.

There was a time in the Western world, just a few hundred years ago, when if you weren’t feeling well, you assumed that one of the four humors in your body—blood, yellow bile, black bile, or phlegm—was out of whack. You might then say, as the 18th-century poet Thomas Gray did, that your pains were “wandering” throughout your “constitution” until “they may fix into the Gout.” One of Boddice’s HEX colleagues, Jenni Kuuliala, wrote about a Tuscan friar, Giovanni Bronsius, who in the fall of 1597 ate a plate of macaroni, soon felt sick, and knew that a witch had poisoned him. When it came to witchcraft, Kuuliala told me, people described a bubbling sensation in the body, a certain restlessness. The friar used these words too, adding other details. (His teeth felt “empty.”) Hildegard of Bingen, a 12th-century German Benedictine abbess, talked of the intense divine visions she was having. They appeared to her as blinding auras—a “reflection of the living Light,” she called them, something “far, far brighter than a cloud which carries the sun.” Modern scholars have assumed she was having migraines. But Boddice doesn’t accept this reasoning. “I don’t want to explain religious visions away.”

We could translate each of these experiences into the word *pain*. But that would conflate what Boddice insists are the unique feelings that the brain in each of these historical moments produced. In a manifesto of sorts—*Emotion, Sense, Experience*, co-written in 2020 with Mark Smith, a University of South Carolina historian—Boddice makes his claim with the gusto and certainty of a Silicon Valley entrepreneur: “What we propose is a disruption of what it is and means to be human.”

This is the kind of provocative statement to which Boddice is prone, and his work can induce a sense of vertigo. To unmoor people from any sense of common humanity means undermining most of the political philosophies and laws that govern our world. If we abandon our sense of shared humanness with people who lived in the past, what does that mean for other people who live in different cultural contexts

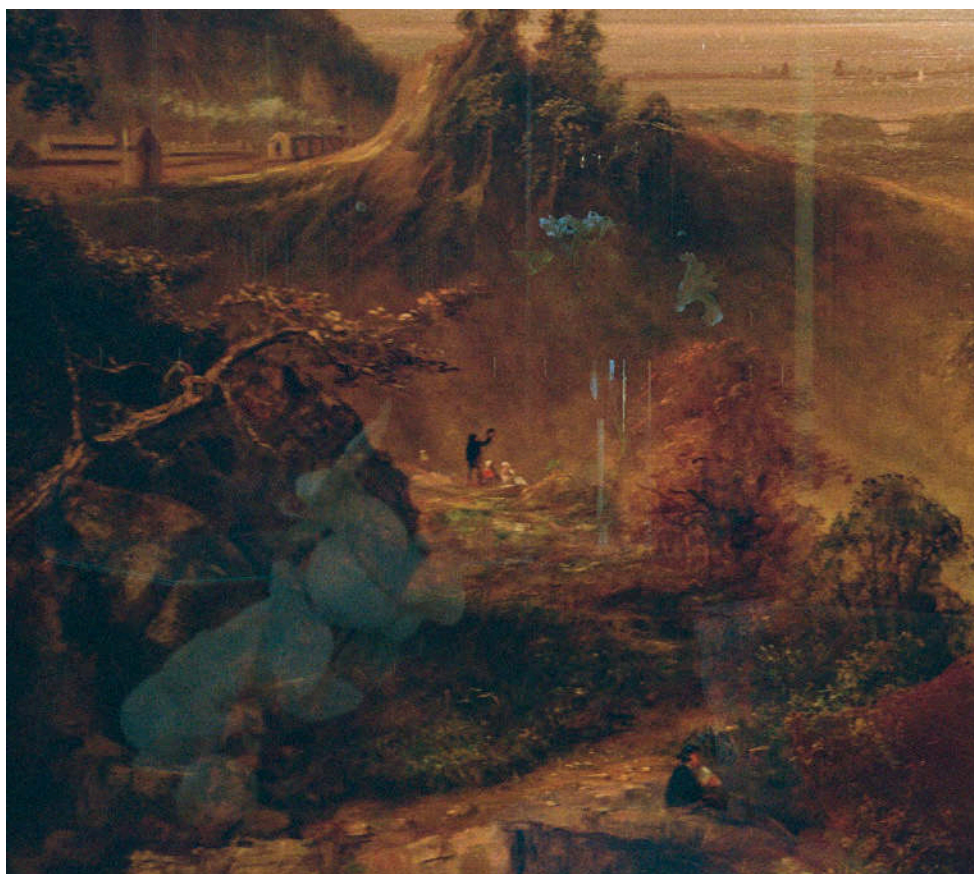
today—in a village in China, or just on the other side of the same city?

And yet the notion that the same inputs may create divergent experiences has some gut-level validity to it—think of how the feeling of being an American changes today whether you are wearing blue or red lenses. And then there are the dizzying advances in AI, which make Boddice's question—what does it even mean to be human?—one that we all face as never before.

ROB BODDICE WAS BORN in 1977 in a mining community near the bleak industrial English town of Burton-on-Trent. From his home, he could see a deep coal mine, Cadley Hill, which was shut down in the late '80s. When he was a boy, everyone's father seemed to be unemployed. "I grew up wanting to escape; it's that simple," Boddice said.

As he made his way into and through academia—he received all of his degrees, up to and including his Ph.D., from the University of York—Boddice tried to lose the biggest marker of class identity in England, becoming "an accent chameleon," as he put it. He was so successful that during his post-doc years, in the early 2000s, he gave a lecture one day in London in such a flawlessly scrubbed-down, international version of English that a British woman in the audience complimented him on his mastery of the language, assuming, because he was with the Freie Universität in Berlin, that he was German. "The only accent I cannot do now is my own, really," he told me.

It's not surprising that someone who has had to cycle through so many versions of himself would be attuned to the way an environment can mold how you talk or walk, which can in turn change the way you think and maybe who you are. Already as a graduate student, he was drawn to the work of anthropologists, such as Clifford Geertz, who appreciated and wrote about their own distance from the lived experience of their subjects, shaped by unspannable chasms of culture. In his dissertation, Boddice stared across this divide, asking why practices such as cockfighting and bullbaiting, now considered brutal and uncivilized, once appeared totally ordinary to British minds, and why this changed in the 19th century.



Rob Boddice, a 48-year-old academic, has transformed the field known as the history of emotions and senses, and co-founded the discipline's leading research institute, in northern Finland.

These were the seeds of his fascination with how variable the human experience can be. His research showed that the same kind of activity that once caused delight, or at least did not cause alarm, could elicit revulsion just a few decades later. He wanted to know how this is possible.

Before the establishment of HEX, in 2018, Boddice struggled to find his place among the stiflingly confined categories of academia. He wanted to ask "the *Bill & Ted* question of history—what is the meaning of life?" and this was not the standard way for a young researcher to begin to make his career. In the history of emotions and senses, Boddice finally found a receptive field, with well-funded new institutes in Berlin and Australia, that appealed to him for its more foundational approach to the human condition. But he also saw its

limitations. Researchers were jumping into the archives with their own preconceptions; they were looking, say, for love in the 16th century by highlighting the word in various texts, but taking for granted a 21st-century sense of what love meant.

In *The History of Emotions* (2017) and then *A History of Feelings* (2019), Boddice wrote of the need to "surrender," to let go of the very human impulse to empathize with the dead, as if their feelings and perceptions had been more or less like ours. He also suggested an interdisciplinary approach that is still unusual in most of academia—the attitude is generally one of "I'm a political historian, I'm an art historian, I'm a religious historian, I'm a material historian, I'm a historian of language," he told me. Whereas if you want to summon back to life a world in which people lived and moved—and thereby isolate and characterize specific experiences—you need all of those disciplines together.

A History of Feelings opens by looking at the first word in the Western canon, which happens to refer to an emotion. At the start of *The Iliad*, Achilles is described



as having *mênis*, which is usually rendered simply as “wrath” or “anger” or “rage” by English translators. Boddice didn’t think this made sense, because, first of all, Achilles doesn’t really act enraged; he just kind of broods. It isn’t until his friend Patroclus is killed, much later in the story, that he enters battle. This might seem like pedantic textual analysis, but for Boddice it is an opening to an emotion from deep antiquity that has been lost to time. Through a close reading of ancient-Greek usages of *mênis*, the feeling revealed itself to Boddice as something closer to unease at cosmic disorder (or, as Boddice put it to me, a “cosmic sulk”) than anything we’d associate today with anger. If *mênis* wasn’t motivating Achilles after Patroclus’s death, then what was? After examining images of Achilles on Greek pottery and reading accounts of ancient funeral rites, Boddice discerned what seemed like yet another form of grief, more violent in nature, which also has no real analogue today.

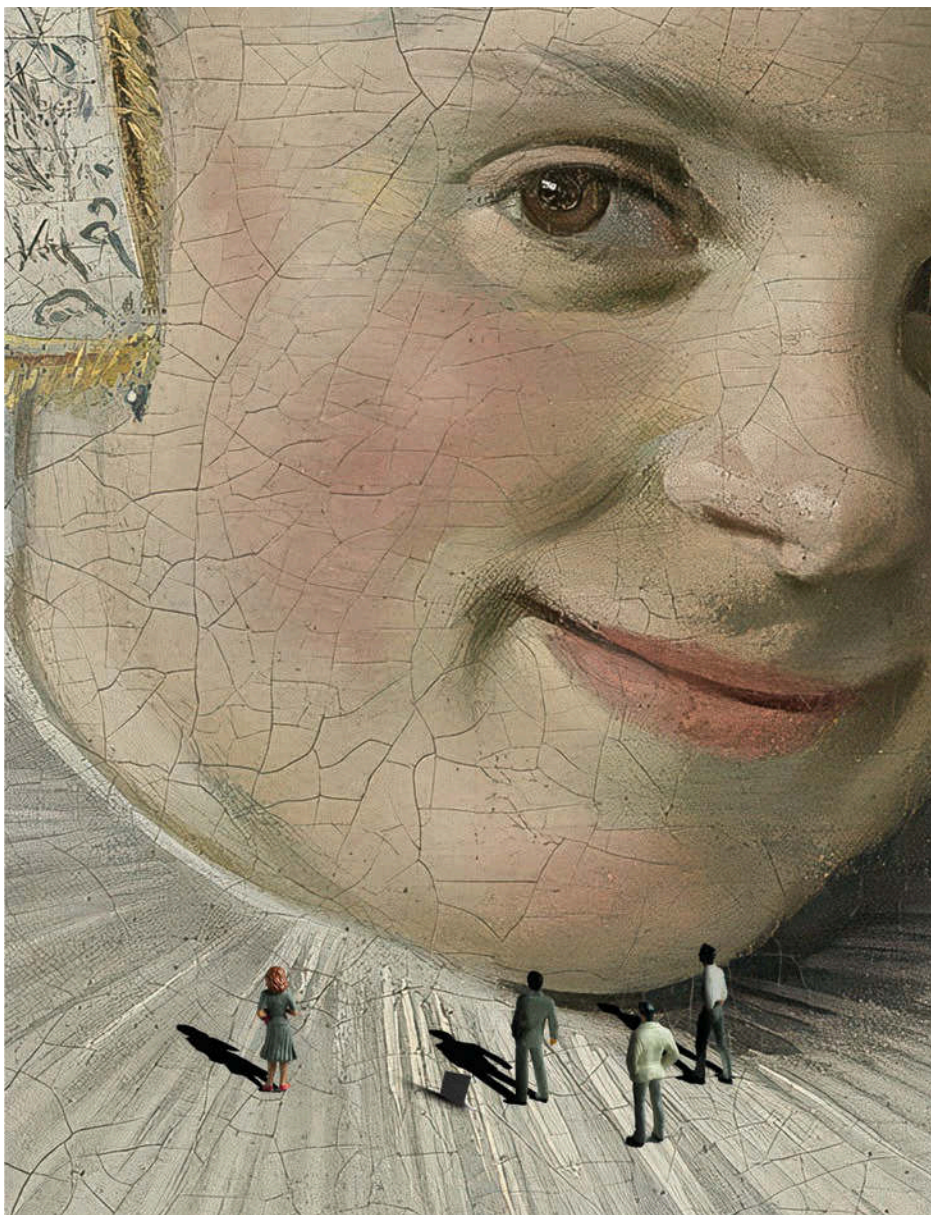
A 2020 paper by the German historian Bettina Hitzer shows how this approach to history can undermine what we often

take for granted—for instance, that a bad smell is always and forever a bad smell. Hitzer looked at the way Nazi politics affected how the odors of cancer patients and their advanced tumors were perceived. Whereas in the 19th century these smells were mainly described as useful for aiding in diagnosis, in the Germany of the 1920s and ’30s, they elicited extreme disgust and were characterized as repellent in the medical literature of the time. Hitzer concludes that this has to do with the Nazis’ focus on purity and use of disease metaphors and imagery (describing Jews as “cancerous tumors” and having a distinct stench); this association altered what happened after the smell of the patients reached people’s noses, with the result that those odors created a feeling of moral disgust. It is impossible to understand sense and emotion—experience—without taking in the overwhelming politics of that era. As she notes, after 1945, “references to smell and disgust disappeared almost completely” from writing about cancer.

If the history of experience, as practiced and preached by Boddice, has a godmother,

it is the celebrated New Zealand-born historian Joanna Bourke, now a professor emerita at Birkbeck, at the University of London, and a fellow of the British Academy. She has never deployed *experience* as an overarching term for describing her focus, but it captures well her approach to understanding the past, particularly in her work on how violence is felt. Her award-winning 1999 book, *An Intimate History of Killing*, considers how soldiers responded to violence in 20th-century warfare, including through what might seem like unexpected emotions, such as joy and catharsis. When I asked her if she’d gotten pushback earlier in her career from other historians for her focus on experience, she let out a big laugh. Recovering the feelings of historical actors was simply not done, she explained. If you wanted to understand people in the past, she said, “the emphasis was much more on what they did and what that tells us about the ways they are thinking, as opposed to what they were feeling and therefore what they did.”

I was curious specifically about Bourke’s work on the history of rape. The subject is



at the past, this is the work of the historian, Bourke said: “to unpick the universal experience.” When she says *unpick*—a word Boddice also uses—I imagine the historian delicately tugging at the threads of what appears to be a smooth fabric and loosening it into a messy collection of misshapen emotions. Some will repel us, some will enlighten us, and some will remain forever impossible to grasp.

BODDICE’S HOPE was for HEX to be a center of research that would take what he saw as the incredible heterogeneity of human experience as its starting point. The institute was funded in 2018 for a period of eight years with a 10-million-euro grant from the Finnish government. A few months before the funding ran out, Boddice moved to the University of Helsinki to begin what he called “a new, multi-disciplinary project on panic.” (He remains affiliated with HEX as a researcher.) In 2023, I went to Tampere for HEX’s annual conference, hoping to get a sense of how widely shared Boddice’s approach is. The town is sometimes referred to as the Manchester of Finland, a 19th-century industrial hub whose skyline is still punctuated by puffing smokestacks (and where reindeer meat appears on every menu). Even in March, the ground was covered in treacherous black ice,

inherently disturbing, and her treatment is itself unsettling. If we are to take seriously the idea that we cannot simply project backwards, then even those acts considered to be the gravest violations of bodily autonomy need to be understood for how they were felt in their time. How might rape have been experienced differently when it carried a societal stigma of “ruining” the woman who was attacked? And, even harder to grasp, what about what we now call marital rape? “Bodily autonomy is not what a woman in the 17th or 18th century is experiencing,” Bourke said. “She’s experiencing submission to the will of God, submission to the will of the husband.” But

would the act feel different to her because the notion of bodily autonomy wasn’t part of her conceptual vocabulary, which is what I take Boddice and Bourke to be saying? She might feel a physical sensation of hurt, Bourke told me, but that is different from violence, which is the meaning one makes of hurt. At a time when there was not “any sort of idea of an emotional soul or self, or certainly not psychological self, that is being harmed,” the act would be perceived in a totally different way than in a world, like ours, with a concept like trauma, which can be physical or psychic. As strange and troubling as it may be to put aside our own moral precepts when looking

and the sky hung heavy and gray. The university campus is a series of modernist glass-and-concrete structures in the center of the town. Boddice stood out during the three days, partly because he was wearing a three-piece pinstripe suit and a fedora most of the time, but also because he seemed to be the clear intellectual heavyweight trying to corral a scattered group of scholars and graduate students toward his vision of what the history of experience means.

Some of those present were very much aligned with the program, such as Pirooska Nagy, a Hungarian-born medievalist in cat’s-eye glasses who is a co-editor, together

NICOLÁS ORTEGA. SOURCE: PORTRAIT OF A MARRIED COUPLE, FRANS HALS, CIRCA 1622.

with Boddice and Mark Smith, of a Cambridge University Press series on the history of emotions and senses—a gatekeeper role where they can nudge the field in their direction. “I made my Ph.D. on weeping,” Nagy told me, “a thousand years ago, when nobody worked on this kind of thing.” Nagy wrote about how crying in the Middle Ages was seen as signifying closeness to God. Both men and women alike cried in public (though each had different weeping styles) as a kind of ritualized act, a way to show contrition, ecstasy, or the presence of divine love.

At the HEX conference, many of the presentations I listened to would have been at home in nearly any such gathering focused on cultural history or comparative literature, with scholars seizing on some dredged-up nugget of esoterica from the archives without much context or sense of why it mattered. This was exactly the narrow, blinkered kind of history that Boddice was trying to break with. On a few occasions, I saw him gently take issue with a speaker for using decidedly contemporary categories to comprehend the past. One Finnish researcher, peppered by Boddice with questions about how generally he was describing emotions, answered, “But I’ve read Plato and Aristotle and those guys, and they talk about anger and fear.” I already knew enough to anticipate Boddice’s response: *How can we understand what they meant by anger and fear?*

You can’t entirely blame the other scholars; Boddice’s standards are exacting. At the same time, they lead to a place with no boundaries at all. If we concede that the meaning of experience is not necessarily the same from past to present, doesn’t the same logic make you wonder about the meaning of experience from culture to culture in the present? In fact it does, as Boddice readily admits. He is skeptical that any kind of universal baseline can be established for capturing how humans make their way through the world.

Producing history that tries to put a finger in this swiftly moving river is not easy, but when it actually happens, the results do feel revelatory and significantly different from other encounters with the past. For a good example, a few scholars at the HEX conference pointed me to a remarkable

paper by the late Jan Plamper, a professor at Goldsmiths, at the University of London.

Plamper chose as his topic the sensory experience of the 1917 Russian Revolution, and specifically the *change* in experience that took place between the February revolution, which led to the czar’s abdication, and the October revolution later that year, when the Bolsheviks took power. Plamper considered the sounds and smells of that period not “as spice in the narrative” but as subjects “in their own right.” Drawing on contemporaneous observations from a variety of sources, the paper is crammed with extraordinary detail—the way the smell of cigars, associated with the bourgeoisie, suddenly provoked revulsion among the revolutionaries, or how the reality of peasants and workers pouring into the cities could be felt physically because the sidewalks were covered in sunflower-seed shells, the snack of the lower classes (“Pedestrians felt like they were walking on a cushioned carpet”). Between the disappearing sound of church bells and the increasing prevalence of the color red, the sensory environment was undergoing its own revolutionary change.

You can almost imagine the brain of a Russian that year trying to make meaning out of all the new signals. In February, when the revolution began, the new sound of occasional rapid gunfire was terrifying, but soon Petrograders could distinguish between live ammunition and blanks, and by October, when shooting started up again, they were habituated to the noise—and the particular quality of silence that followed it—as part of what marked revolutionary time.

This is history as disorientation, listening for the dissonances, when the gunfire starts and stops. The sources are the existing ones, but they are being used in new ways and in new combinations to try to answer how the Russian Revolution “became known”—in Plamper’s words—to the people who lived through it. The work pushes historians to do the uncomfortable and move outside the boxes they’ve been trained to operate within.

THE UNIVERSALISM that Boddice mistrusts is a relatively new concept in human history. It comes to us from the Enlightenment. The presumption that all people

share a common nature was dreamed up by European intellectuals sitting in their salons. Plenty of critics, starting with postcolonial thinkers, now understand this to have been an ideological attempt to exert power and order over a world that had recently become bigger and stranger. But this impulse toward uniformity is not just an 18th-century one. Freudian psychology also reduced the dynamism of the human mind to a machine powered by predictable and shared drives. By the time we get to our current globalized culture, in which a Korean thriller can win Best Picture at the Oscars and Latin pop stars dominate the U.S. charts, the notion that our emotional registers are all essentially alike feels self-evident.

And for all we know, it may be true. Even some historians who are keen, like Boddice, to reconstruct experience from scratch are reluctant to take the leap he makes when he questions whether humans have anything in common. Javier Moscoso is a professor at the Spanish National Research Council, and on its face, his methodology seems very similar to Boddice’s—the two have a lot of respect for each other. Moscoso’s most recent book, *Arc of Feeling*, looks at the experience of swinging as it has shown up across a very long sweep of human history—yes, swinging, as in going up and down on a swing, as well as the disorientation, but also the pleasure and pain, this causes. His many data points include depictions of swings in cave paintings made in western India during the fifth century C.E.; the “witch’s cradle,” once a form of torture in England in which a woman was placed in a sack suspended from a tree; and a 17th-century erotic Chinese novel that featured a swing in a loss of virginity. Moscoso’s process, he told me, is to “pay attention to the very singular, to something which is in principle irrelevant,” and build from there. He spoke to me of discovering, for example, the record of a Roman coin minted in the time of Tiberius that depicted two men pushing a woman on a swing, part of a series of coins depicting sexual positions, perhaps used for entry into a brothel.

Moscoso spoke with me over Zoom from Madrid, his head barely visible over a

fluffy white cat that had decided to recline on his keyboard. Unlike Boddice, he is searching for continuity, not dissonance. And he definitely finds it in the physical experience of oscillation, which, over millennia, in almost every human society, has had strong associations with either sex or death (or both)—the swing shows up in similar erotic scenes on ancient-Greek vases and in 18th-century French pornography, and likewise as a source of terror, whether it's witches rising and falling in the art of Goya or the condemned swinging from the gallows.

There is a “political agenda”—his words—to Moscoso's work, and it is to discover commonality precisely at a moment of growing fragmentation in the modern world. “In times in which we are so much focused on differences, and identities, and precisely this kind of a parcellation of reality, you find, as a matter of fact, certain common features,” he told me. If Boddice insists that it is a mistake to go looking for love in the archives based on our definition of what love feels like, Moscoso counters by bringing up how consistently similar love stories are in different cultures and time periods. For instance, he pointed out, many of them are about lovers who are unequal and whose love is forbidden—whether it's Pyramus and Thisbe in Ovid's *Metamorphoses*; or the ancient-Chinese story of the butterfly lovers, Liang Shanbo and Zhu Yingtai; or Shakespeare's Romeo and Juliet. For Moscoso, these “structures of repetition” give you “an account of differences, but also of similarities,” a way people relate to love in the same way despite thoroughly different circumstances.

“My research is a sort of protest,” Moscoso said. “I believe that we are connected.” What we need is a “new Enlightenment,” a reassertion of what “makes us human”: at the very least so that there is a basis for something like civil rights and all the political philosophies—such as democracy, to name a particularly

endangered one—that are built on the idea that to be human is a singular thing.

Does Boddice too blithely throw out this idea? “I like the romance of it,” he said when I asked him. And for the record, he added, he is not against finding common threads that connect humanity if he happens to come across them. But that is not *his* agenda. The way he wants his work to affect how we think today—a mission he also believes to be “ethically urgent”—is to move us away from the universal and automatic understanding of what it is to be

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human. Boddice is concerned that we are flattening ourselves. By not appreciating the full range of feeling that people are capable of, we are foreclosing a deeper engagement with one another, an engagement on terms that don't demand that everyone be the same but leave room for the great unknown of what happens in other people's heads. In *A History of Feelings*, he described our diminished and too limited vocabulary for emotions as “vague, empty or else crude.” The danger is that this reduced language, this emojiification of emotional life, also

reduces, quite literally, how much we can feel. History, at least in the way he sees it, might help. “I was motivated to not only show the richness and the unfamiliarity of past experience, but also to try to give people the tools to interrogate the politics of feeling in their present,” Boddice told me.

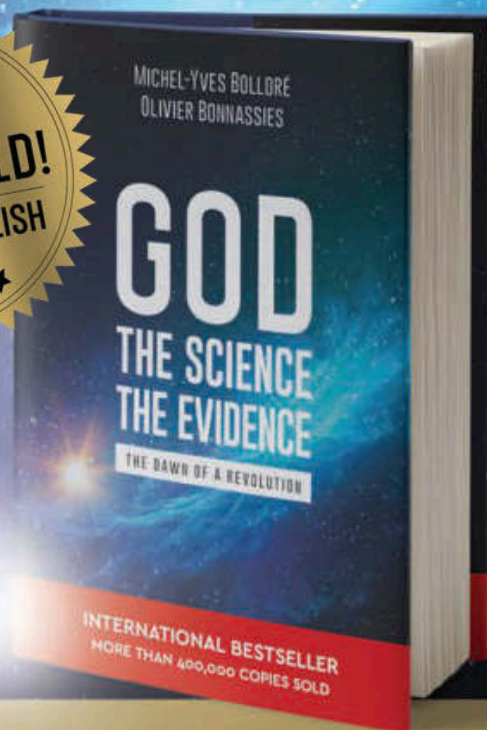
There is a danger, I think, and not a small one, in letting go of the bonds that connect us—in saying “Down with empathy”—but I can't deny that Boddice's perspective has a strange appeal at a moment when we feel so thoroughly alienated from one another's experience of reality. We struggle to understand how other human beings don't feel the same things we do—and this frustration often turns into anger and resentment. Maybe we would do better to start by recognizing the mystery of other people.

Certainly when it comes to the past, Boddice is up against strong (and popular) impulses, such as the notion that by donning a Civil War uniform or throwing an ancient spear, we can know something about how our ancestors related to the world. It makes sense that he has taken a radical position, if only to loudly resist such oversimplification.

But if I can offer something of a bridge: There is a universality to the question that Boddice spends most of his waking hours posing—that is, a universality to the very act of posing it. What species besides ours demands: *What did it feel like?* What animal besides us stares into a stranger's eyes, or into the eyes of their grandparents, and builds whole philosophies around this question? Whether we see our reflection in others—past and present—or, like Boddice, insist on difference, the compulsion to ask this question, again and again, marks us. Maybe to be human, at the most basic level, is to be curious about other humans. *A*

Gal Beckerman is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

What if
GOD'S EXISTENCE
wasn't a matter of belief...but
EVIDENCE?

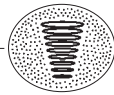


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LEARN MORE



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By Caleb
Madison

Warning: This crossword puzzle starts easy, but gets devilishly hard as you descend into its depths. See which circle you can reach before you abandon all hope.

ACROSS

- 1 Common road-paving material
- 4 Vehicle often used by touring musicians
- 7 "___ it or lose it!"
- 8 Words exchanged at the altar
- 9 Only element whose name is spelled with three letters
- 10 Rug rat, e.g.
- 11 "Good old" country, casually
- 13 Little troublemakers
- 16 Like pre-Revolution Russia
- 19 Galore
- 20 Cinematic humanoids that can become warriors by bonding with an Ikran
- 21 Pop's pop
- 25 Big name in both agricultural technology and classic rock
- 26 Thrums
- 29 *Moonstruck* role played by Cher
- 30 Tearing sound?
- 31 "¡___ es!" ("That's it!")
- 32 Filling meals?
- 36 Enters with gusto, maybe
- 37 Story by a fan, for short
- 38 ___ kwon do
- 39 Stretch of misfires
- 41 Digital receipt?
- 42 ___-fit (Nike product line)
- 44 Alternative to *grams*
- 47 Putti-like, perhaps
- 49 Someone working on a deck?
- 50 Statesman who brought about the end of the Western Roman empire
- 51 One who lumbers to work?

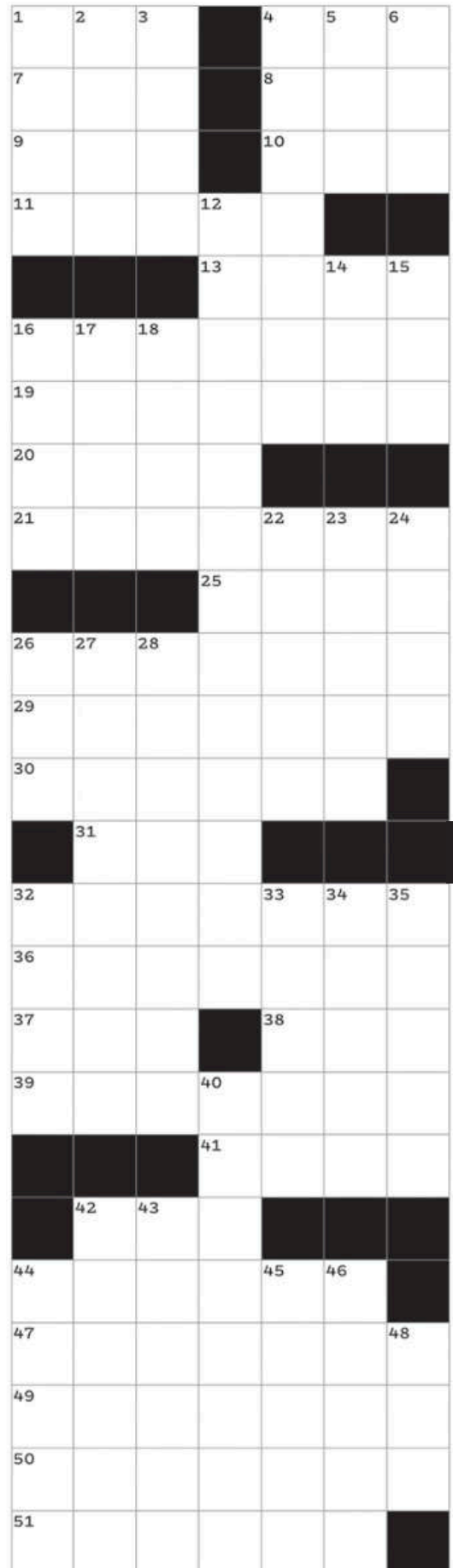
DOWN

- 1 Costume typically worn in classical ballet
- 2 Yard-sale qualifier
- 3 Nevada's "Biggest Little City in the World"
- 4 Its bottle might be *Flintstones* or *Bluey* branded
- 5 Kerfuffle
- 6 "Psych!"
- 12 Shout before an explosion, maybe
- 14 Three hours behind EST
- 15 Digs for a pig
- 16 Zest
- 17 Play-fight, maybe
- 18 Thomas ___ Edison
- 22 Because of
- 23 Philosopher who conceived of the tripartite soul
- 24 He lost the Oscar for Best Supporting Actor to Freeman in 2005
- 26 Org. that deals in ballpark figures?
- 27 Many an Outlook auto-response: abbr.
- 28 *Sgroppino* ingredient
- 32 *Die Bernauerin* composer
- 33 Youth-Dew creator ___ Lauder
- 34 Top with rocks?
- 35 Golf's "Slammin' Sammy"
- 40 Good time for Amazon exploration?
- 42 "¡No hay problema!"
- 43 Sprout back
- 44 Safari setting?
- 45 Character who says that "being so many different sizes in a day is very confusing"
- 46 Older partner, often
- 48 Middleman for the NHL

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